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INSIDE



U.P. court acquits Rahul in 2018 defamation case

LUCKNOW
An MP/MLA court in Sultanpur in Uttar Pradesh on Monday acquitted Congress leader and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, in a defamation case filed against him for allegedly making a defamatory statement in 2018 about then BJP national president Amit Shah. » PAGE 4



SIT to probe Jarange-Patil's ₹500-cr. charge

MUMBAI
The Mumbai police on Monday formed a three-member special investigation team (SIT) to probe Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil's allegation that the BJP paid ₹500 crore to him through Shiv Sena MP Shrikant Shinde to "manage" the Maratha agitation. » PAGE 2

Govt. approves ₹2.12 lakh crore for defence deals

NEW DELHI
The Defence Acquisition Council, chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, on Monday accorded Acceptance of Necessity for capital acquisition proposals worth about ₹2.12 lakh crore for the three Services, with about 82% of the procurements to be sourced from the domestic industry. » PAGE 4

Lula beats far-right, wins 4th presidential term

- Brazilian President makes a dramatic comeback after trailing in the first round against Bolsonaro
- Lula secures a historic 64 million votes, defeating far-right leader by more than four million votes
- Brazil is nobody's backyard, he says amid alleged U.S. meddling in election in favour of Bolsonaro

Shobhan Saxena
SAO PAULO

Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva secured a historic fourth presidential term, defeating Flávio Bolsonaro of Liberal Party (PL) in Brazil's runoff on Sunday. Lula secured 64 million votes, the highest total ever recorded in a Brazilian presidential election, defeating Mr. Bolsonaro by more than four million votes.

Declaring a "defeat for lies and denialism", Lula, 80, pledged to govern for all Brazilians and protect the country's sovereignty.

"Brazil is nobody's backyard," he declared at a midnight rally, sending a message to U.S. President Donald Trump as he said Brazil has defeated the far-right lies, foreign interference and election meddling by social media firms.

An emotional Lula thanked women and older voters for their support and praised the mobilisation of youth on the streets and on social media.

"People went out to vote because we managed to convince them that their votes were extremely important to safeguarding democracy in the country," he said.

Lula secured an unprecedented comeback in the election. He trailed in the first round, receiving 45.16% of valid votes against 47.03% for Flávio.



Aligned stars: Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva greets supporters outside his residence in Sao Paulo on Sunday. REUTERS

Dramatic democracy

As the prospect of a Bolsonaro presidency caused a major concern among the young, especially about public education, healthcare and transport, millions joined weekly rallies across the country, pledging support for Lula and demanding protection of public services.

On Sunday, Lula told his young supporters that their voices have been heard.

"We will make increasing investment in the Unified Health System, develop a national artificial intelligence system, continue to expand public universities and support the digital and creative economies," said Lula.

The turnaround after the first round of election on October 4 was not only historic but also dramatic. Lula's official campaign team almost took a back seat as millions of people came out on streets and joined the social media campaign.

With most opinion polls predicting a neck-to-neck race and some even giving an edge to Mr. Bolsonaro till a few days back, the Workers' Party shifted its messaging from a comparison of the candidates' personal records to a forward-looking agenda centred on concrete promises.

Even as Lula made his promises to the electorate, his campaign faced a big challenge: Big Tech firms openly supported Bolsonaro's campaign while suppressing advertising by Lula's team.

In his speech on Sunday, Lula said he had to overcome "interference" by digital platforms and pledged to regulate big tech companies in Brazil.

"This election was one in which we had to overcome interference coming from outside and through digital platforms. We will have to regulate them," Lula said.

On October 16, after an expose in the Brazilian media, Meta had admitted that its artificial intelligence tool had blocked the generation of advertising material supporting Lula while allowing the same technology to be used by the Flávio campaign.

EDITORIAL: A FINAL SURGE
» PAGE 8

Mud trail



An earthmover clears debris from the Nilgiri mountain rail tracks near Hillgrove station in Coonoor, Tamil Nadu, on Monday. M. SATHYAMOORTHY

Bid to restrain functioning of CEC against law: ECI to SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (ECI), Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, and the two Election Commissioners (ECs) have filed a joint affidavit highlighting that any attempt to restrain the functioning of the CEC will be contrary to the law.

The nearly 250-page document, filed in the top court late on Monday, said a CEC cannot be removed from office except in the manner and the grounds identical to ousting a Supreme Court judge.

The affidavit said a media report on the inner frictions and alleged unilateral or authoritarian functioning of the CEC was hardly evidence in court. Petitions basing itself on media reports should not be even maintainable in court.

Petitioners who have challenged the functioning of the CEC include the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and other INDIA bloc leaders. The affidavit, which shows the CEC to be on the same page as both ECs Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, said the commission had "neither released nor authorised the release of any internal note or file to any news agency".

> Decisions are first sent to one Election Commissioner and then to the other Election Commissioner and then finally to the CEC. Such approved decisions of the EC are duly noted in the files concerned of the EC and bear the signature of the Election Commissioners and the CEC. Thereafter, the decision is notified and implemented by the EC Secretariat
>
> ECI AFFIDAVIT IN SC

'Rule of majority'

They submitted the multi-member Commission, in case of any "difference of opinion" would follow the rule of majority to arrive at decisions in accordance with Section 18 of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023.

The affidavit indicated that there was no room for unilateral decision making in the ECI. Decisions were vetted at various levels.

"Decisions are first sent to one Election Commissioner and then to the other Election Commissioner and then finally to the CEC. Such approved decisions of the EC are duly noted in the files concerned of the EC and bear the signature of the ECs and the CEC. Thereafter, the decision is notified and implemented by the EC Secretariat," the affidavit said.

However, the ECI concedes in the affidavit that "when it is not feasible for the CEC or any of the ECs to be available in person", an approval of the members of the ECI is obtained through "electronic means" and recorded later in the official file.

"Important functions" were "directly under the Commission as a whole". "Decisions taken in meetings of the EC or are noted in files bear the signatures of the ECs and the CEC," the affidavit said.

An office order was issued on July 28, by an IAS officer of the rank of additional secretary, who had been posted on deputation to the EC, pertaining to internal work allocation.

The affidavit, however, indirectly confirmed that Mr. Sandhu and Mr. Joshi had written to the Cabinet Secretary about the conduct of Senior Deputy Election Commissioner Maneesh Garg, following a controversial July 28 order affecting levels of IT oversight over electoral rolls. The order was passed without the knowledge or consensus of the two ECs.

'No change in Form 6'

"On July 29, the two ECs had written separate letters to the Cabinet Secretary in relation to this order and the conduct of the officer," the affidavit said. It said that the July 28 order was "never implemented".

The ECI denied allegations that Form 6 was amended in consecutive special intensive revision (SIR) orders of June 24, 2025; October 27, 2025; and May 14, 2026. It reasoned that the additional declaration form requiring voters to provide details of mapping was "not part of Form 6, which is the statutory form for inclusion in the electoral roll".

"The declaration form is one of the documents which is required to be submitted by any applicant along with Form 6 for inclusion in the electoral roll during the SIR exercise," it said.

The poll body said that the "mapping concept" in the additional declaration form only obviated the need for submitting further documents for verification. It was only a "measure taken for the assistance of voters".

"There is no change in the Form 6," it said.

Former T.N. Minister held in multi-crore graft case

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

Hours after his anticipatory bail plea was dismissed by the Madras High Court on Monday, former DMK Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi was arrested by the Chennai police in connection with an alleged multi-crore scam.

According to police sources, a special team of the Central Crime Branch (CCB), which is investigating allegations that several crores of rupees were collected as 'party fund' from various private school managements across Tamil Nadu, arrested Mr. Poyyamozhi, who was the School Education Minister between 2021 and 2026.



Under scanner: Former DMK Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi being taken into custody. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

'Fleeced schools'

The case arises from a complaint lodged with the Chennai Police Commissioner by C. Elangovan, secretary of the Tamil Nadu Private Schools Federation, accusing B.T. Arasakumar, 59, of having collected large sums of money by running an unregistered association named the 'Tamil Nadu Private Schools Association'.

The CCB had included Mr. Poyyamozhi as an accused in the case after evidence emerged during the inquiry pointing to his involvement in the alleged corruption.

The complainant alleged that Mr. Arasakumar, who was later detained under the Goondas Act, had collected money from private school managements by promising to offer services such as obtaining approvals for upgrading schools, getting permanent recognition, and securing building plan approvals, using his supposed clout in the then-ruling dispensation, the sources said.

Muthukumar, a close associate of Mr. Poyyamozhi, was allegedly involved in the scam to the tune of about ₹100 crore. "He is absconding and efforts are on to apprehend him at the earliest. We are tracking some clues that might lead to his location," a police officer said.

'Political vendetta'

This is the first arrest of a senior DMK party functionary and former Minister after the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) came to power, sweeping the DMK out of office.

Former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin strongly condemned Mr. Poyyamozhi's arrest, terming it an act of "political vendetta".

In an official statement, Mr. Stalin accused the ruling administration of attempting to divert public attention from governance failures. "By arresting Anbil Mahesh, who has been fully cooperating with the probe into the allegations against him, the ruling government believes it can divert public attention and cover up the deplorable collapse of law and order and rotting administrative breakdown for a few days. Anbil Mahesh will face the allegations against him legally," Mr. Stalin said.

In a late development, PTI reported that Mr. Poyyamozhi was produced before the Special Court for cases under the Prevention of Corruption Act here at 10.10 p.m. after a medical check-up at a government hospital.

INBRIEF



Cabinet reshuffle in J&K today; Congress to keep out

The ruling National Conference (NC) on Monday geared up for the upcoming reshuffle and expansion of the Council of Ministers in Jammu and Kashmir with all five Ministers submitting their resignations to the party leadership in Srinagar. Ally Congress has decided against joining the government citing continuing Union Territory status as a reason, in spite of the top NC leadership reaching out to the Congress high command in Delhi. J&K Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha will administer the oath of office and secrecy to legislators newly named to the Council of Ministers in Srinagar on Tuesday.

People block Odisha highway to protest youth's death

People in Odisha's Malkangiri town on Monday blocked National Highway 326 to protest the death of a youth in the custody of a Haryana police team, an officer said. Tanup Dey (22), a resident of MV-65 village, was picked up by a Haryana police team on Sunday on charges of ganja smuggling. The police team later kept him at a hotel in Malkangiri town overnight, the officer said. On Monday morning, Dey's body was found hanging in the hotel, he said. Following the incident, the family members of Dey alleged that the Haryana police team beat him to death and then tried to pass it off as suicide. PTI

Congress sets ball rolling, eyes over 175 seats from SP in Assembly election

Cong. U.P. in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam says party has shared a list of around 200 seats with ally; SP president parries question on numbers, says objective is to remove BJP from power

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW



Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav addressing a press conference in Lucknow on Monday. PTI

The Congress on Monday said the party is keen on contesting at least 175 out of the 403 seats in the upcoming Uttar Pradesh Assembly polls as part of the INDIA alliance in the State and it has shared a list of around 200 with the Samajwadi Party (SP) for further discussions on seat sharing over the next few weeks. Party leaders added that the Congress wants an alliance with "mutual respect".

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Uttar Pradesh Congress in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam said, "We have given the list of 175-200 seats to the Samajwadi Party. Both parties will together fight the Uttar Pradesh Assembly election. Congress want an alliance with mutual respect and a collective dedicated effort to defeat the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in Uttar Pradesh. Further discussions on seat sharing will happen in coming days."

Responding to questions about its alliance with the Congress, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav said, "Samajwadi Party and all our leaders know how to bring people together. We all have experience in managing alliances. We will strengthen our alliance ahead of the Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections." The objective was to "remove the BJP from power permanently" in Uttar Pradesh, he said, questioning who had put up a recent hoarding in Lucknow carrying the photographs of Congress leaders and reading: "200 seats are our right; U.P. trusts Rahul Gandhi'. "These objectionable posters have not appeared for the first time. Who is putting them up? Who is spending money on them? Who is running this racket?" Mr. Yadav said.

'Want strong seats'

Another senior Congress leader said the party's focus is on "strong seats". "In the 2017 Assembly election, our party was given 105 seats in alliance with the SP. We won only seven seats. Our alliance partner will question the strike rate, but the fact that out of those seats, more than 75 were extremely difficult seats or weak seats such as urban constituencies or seats mostly represented by the BJP in the past. A realistic approach would be to divide difficult seats uniformly. Quality along with quantity will matter," the senior leader said, pointing out that 80-odd seats in U.P. are "difficult" for the Opposition alliance in the light of past outcomes and social realities.

SP spokesperson Sunil Singh Yadav 'Sajan' said the top leadership of both parties will collectively decide on seat sharing. "It is very clear that the SP and Congress will together defeat the BJP. On seat sharing, the top leadership of both parties will decide on seats. The larger and only focus is to defeat the corrupt and communal BJP."

Charge sheet to be filed in Veeramani case soon, HC told

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI



R. Veeramani

State Public Prosecutor R. John Sathyan on Monday told the Madras High Court that a Special Investigation Team (SIT) would file the charge sheet soon in a case booked against 84-year-old R. Veeramani of Gem Granites and others under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012, for having sexually exploited many minor girls over the years.

Justice V. Lakshminarayanan recorded the submission and adjourned to November 12 two writ petitions filed by R. Varaaki and advocate M.L. Ravi of the Desiya Makkal Sakthi Katchi seeking the transfer of investigation to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) since a few Indian Police Service (IPS) officers had allegedly attempted to save the prime accused.

When the writ petitions were listed for admission on September 30, the judge had refused to order a CBI probe and observed that the SIT must be allowed to investigate the matter in peace since it involved a highly sensitive issue of many minor girls, belonging to the Scheduled Castes, having been subjected to sexual abuse and the offence having been video-recorded.

The judge had also directed the writ petitioner, Mr. Varaaki, to appear before the SIT and submit materials, if he had any, to prove the alleged involvement of any IPS officer in concealing the crime.

Accordingly, the SIT filed its first status report before the judge on October 7. When the two writ petitions were taken up for hearing on Monday, the SIT filed its second status report.

After perusing it, the judge directed the Registrar (Judicial) to keep both the status reports in safe custody so that the details of the investigation did not leak out.

Mumbai police forms SIT to probe Jarange-Patil's ₹500-cr. allegation

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI



Manoj Jarange-Patil

The Mumbai police on Monday formed a three-member special investigation team (SIT) to probe Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil's allegation that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) paid ₹500 crore to him through Shiv Sena MP Shrikant Shinde, son of Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde, to "manage" the Maratha agitation.

The SIT comprises three IPS officers and will be led by Additional Police Commissioner Shailesh Balkawade. The other two members are Deputy Commissioner of Police (Zone 3) Vijaykant Sagar and DCP (Cyber, Crime Branch) Bajrang Bansode, according to an order issued by Mumbai Police Commissioner Deven Bharti on Monday.

"Mr. Manoj Jarange-Patil held a press conference and played an audio tape before the media. The tape referred to certain individuals and the exchange of a specific amount. It is important to conduct a forensic and technical examination of the audio, along with an impartial and in-depth probe into the matter. Therefore, a Special Investigation Team is being formed," the order stated.

Mr. Jarange-Patil's allegations have stirred Maharashtra's political circles, creating a rift between alliance partners. The activist has called for a thorough probe and sought accountability from Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and Mr. Eknath Shinde.

Letter to Shah

Meanwhile, Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut wrote to Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday, seeking a probe by the Directorate of Enforcement into the allegations.

Mr. Raut said the public needed to know what action Mr. Shah would take in the matter, "unless he himself provided the money".

"To buy out an agitation, the BJP had given ₹500 crore. Earlier, it used to buy political leaders. If this kind of money is being spent to stop agitations now, and if BJP leaders themselves claim ₹500 crore was given to Shrikant Shinde to be handed over to Mr. Jarange-Patil, then where is that money now? He says he has not received a single penny. This is a case of hawala. This matter comes under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act," he said after writing the letter.

Amid alleged liquor deaths in M.P., police nab 10 for illicit trade

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

Days after locals alleged death of around 13 persons in a month due to consumption of spurious liquor, the police in Madhya Pradesh's Dewas district have arrested 10 persons for allegedly selling illicit liquor in the region, officers said on Monday.

According to the police, the crackdown was launched based on information from the district hospital about the death of two persons on October 15 and 18, whose families alleged that they died after consuming spurious liquor. The 10 accused have been booked under Section 34(2) of the Madhya Pradesh Excise Act, 1915.

The crackdown comes days after Ujjain Divisional Commissioner Asheesh Singh formed a five-member special panel to carry out a detailed probe into the alleged deaths in Chandana and Binjana villages. The Dewas district administration, however, had earlier dismissed news reports and Congress claims, denying any deaths related to spurious liquor while saying that the samples of the two deceased who underwent post-mortem examinations have been sent for forensic tests for clarity. It had also said that various liquor samples tested following locals' allegations were not found containing poisonous contents.

Congress claim

The locals of the two villages have claimed that 13 persons have so far died since September 26. M.P. Congress president Jitu Patwai, who visited the affected villages, also alleged that about 35-40 people had damaged their vision due to spurious liquor .

Rahul to launch Punjab election campaign with rally on Nov. 4

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH



Congress leaders K.C. Venugopal and Sachin Pilot during a meeting with senior party leaders from Punjab on Monday. PTI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi will address a 'Hisab Maango' rally in Punjab's Sangrur on November 4, launching the party's campaign for the 2027 Assembly poll, party leaders K.C. Venugopal and Sachin Pilot told reporters on Monday.

Attacking the Bhagwant Mann government, Mr. Venugopal said the law and order situation is "completely broken" in Punjab, and it is becoming the epicentre of the drug mafia.

"Our goal is to win Punjab, save Punjab from all this evil," he said.

Mr. Venugopal held a series of meetings with senior Punjab Congress leaders, district unit presidents, and other leaders, and discussed preparations for the Assembly poll and Mr. Gandhi's visit.

Mr. Pilot, said the party is united in election preparations. He also attacked Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government over the drug menace issue.

Meanwhile, labelling AAP an "anarchic, criminal party"", the BJP alleged that "murderers" are finding protection under the Punjab government and demanded the resignation of Mr. Mann for "failure" of law and order.

'Rival parties scared'

Mr. Bhagwant Mann on Monday accused the rival parties of targeting him and alleged that they are "scared" of the support AAP has garnered in the poll-bound State.

On Rahul Gandhi's rally in Sangrur on November 4, Mr. Mann, while speaking to reporters in Patiala, said every leader will visit Sangrur, AAP's 'capital'.

"Amit Shah had come. He spoke nothing against the Akali Dal nor did he speak against the Congress. He only took Bhagwant Mann's name and left. Rahul Gandhi will also leave by taking my name," he said.

Junior doctors, interns at W.B. govt. hospital allege threats over pandal stampede claims

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA



The junior doctors and interns alleged lack of basic facilities during treatment of the Durga Puja pandal stampede victims. ANI

Junior doctors and interns at Medical College Kolkata, a government institution in the West Bengal capital, have said that they are facing continued threats and intimidation after flagging alleged mismanagement and a lack of basic facilities in the treatment of victims of last week's Durga Puja pandal stampede, which claimed 19 lives.

"There is a constant attempt to attack the junior doctors and interns for speaking about the lack of facilities at the hospital while they tried to treat the people injured in the stampede," Debasish Haldar, a member of the West Bengal Junior Doctors Front (WBJDF), said on Sunday.

Mr. Haldar said they had repeatedly raised concerns with the State Health Department about the lack of basic facilities at government hospitals.

The junior doctors alleged that they had received threatening WhatsApp messages and that their families had also been targeted in an attempt to intimidate them.

They also accused Dr. Birupaksha Biswas, who was embroiled in controversy during the protests over the 2024 RG Kar rape and murder case, of threatening them following the recent stampede.

Soumyadeep De, an intern, filed a police complaint against Dr. Biswas by e-mail at Bowbazar police station over the alleged threats.

Several senior doctors expressed support for their junior counterparts.

'*Dimagi* naxals'

Responding to the allegations, West Bengal Health Minister Dr. Sharadwat Mukherjee said they did not represent the entire community and could not speak for all junior doctors and interns in government hospitals.

"Who made them the representatives of junior doctors and interns? This is a very small cohort of people and does not represent all junior doctors and interns in government hospitals. These are what we call '*dimagi* naxals'. They are self-proclaimed leaders. If there were no elections to make them leaders, then they cannot officially be called representatives," the Minister told *The Hindu* on Monday.

Ankita murder case: new FIR against actress; Cong. decries police action

Press Trust of India
DEHRADUN



Urmila Sanawar. FILE PHOTO

A fresh FIR was filed against television actress Urmila Sanawar in connection with the Ankita Bhandari murder case here on Monday, a day after she was arrested in Uttar Pradesh's Saharanpur. She is scheduled to appear in court after she gave consent to undergo a narco-analysis test on Friday as part of the CBI inquiry into the case.

Ms. Sanawar was arrested from her house on Sunday after the daughter of former Uttarakhand BJP MLA Suresh Rathore filed a complaint over her social media posts.

The new FIR was filed Sunday night at the complaint of a Dehradun resident flagging "objectionable and defamatory allegations" against Sikkim Governor Dushyant Kumar Gautam and BJP national general secretary B.L. Santosh in connection with the case. Complainant Sagar claimed Ms. Sanawar made "indecent, inappropriate, false, and malicious statements" in a video that circulated on social media platforms and news channels.

"Ms. Sanawar has levelled, without any judicial order or evidence, objectionable and defamatory personal allegations against Mr. Gautam, Mr. Santhosh, Aarti Gaur, and others," he said.

On October 24, Deepika Rathore, daughter of Mr. Rathore, filed a police complaint against Ms. Sanawar, claiming her remarks outraged the family's reputation.

Meanwhile, State Congress decried the police action, alleging Ms. Sanawar was arrested even after she consented to undergo a narco-analysis test. "Jailing those who speak the truth while giving a free hand to the main suspects proves that every possible tactic is being employed to shield influential people within the government," State Congress spokesperson Pratima Singh said in a statement.

Gujarat govt. declares four districts as drought-hit

Press Trust of India
GANDHINAGAR

The Gujarat government on Monday declared Devbhoomi Dwarka, Kutch, Jamnagar and Porbandar districts as drought-affected.

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel said the decision on drought declaration was taken as per the guidelines of the Centre after monsoon ended in the State. As per the Centre's 2016 guideline on drought, the announcement will be in effect for six months, Mr. Patel added.

"The State has received 89% rain this monsoon. However, Devbhoomi Dwarka, Kutch, Jamnagar and Porbandar received very little rain," he said.

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SC rejects petition for CBI investigation into 'horse-trading' in T.N.

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



Petitioner had pointed fingers at TVK Minister Anand and four former AIADMK MLAs

The Supreme Court on Monday dismissed a petition seeking a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into allegations of "horse-trading" involving Tamil Nadu Minister and Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) general secretary N. Anand and four former AIADMK MLAs who shifted political allegiance to the ruling party after the State Assembly elections in May 2026.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant rejected the petition filed by Tamil Nadu resident M. Srinivasan, who alleged Mr. Anand and the four former AIADMK MLAs – K. Maragatham Kumaravel, S. Jayakumar, P. Sathyabama, and E. Subaya – had indulged in "horse-trading" to secure a majority in the Tamil Nadu Assembly.

Mr. Srinivasan, represented by advocate Achintya Tiwari, had sought directions for an investigation and the filing of a final report in a time-bound manner.

Petition sought 'rules'

The petition had also sought the court to invoke its extraordinary powers under Article 142 of the Constitution to frame specific and stringent "rules" to prevent MLAs who have either been disqualified or have resigned from the Assembly without any "valid, material and justifiable" reason from contesting subsequent bypolls in the same constituencies. The plea further sought directions to the Union government, the Election Commission of India (ECI) and the State of Tamil Nadu to recover from the resigned MLAs the expenditure incurred for conducting the Assembly elections in their respective constituencies. The petition also urged the court to direct the four former AIADMK MLAs to deposit the entire costs for the upcoming byelections in their respective constituencies.

The TVK formed the government in the Tamil Nadu with the help of the Indian National Congress, the Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi, the Indian Union Muslim League, the Communist Party of India and the Communist Party of India (Marxist).

During the ensuing floor test, 25 MLAs had defied the party whip to support the TVK government.

Kerala HC stays FIR against Pinarayi, kin in CMRL case

Division Bench admits appeals filed by former Keralam Chief Minister, daughter and son-in-law against Single Bench order; court stays further probe; accused cite procedural lapses in FIR order

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI





Former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and daughter T. Veena.

The Kerala High Court on Monday stayed the First Information Report (FIR) registered in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case involving Keralam Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan and his family members.

A Division Bench of Justices K. Natarajan and Johnson John admitted the appeals filed by Mr. Vijayan, daughter T. Veena, and son-in-law and former Public Works Minister P.A Mohamed Riyas against a Single Bench order directing the registration of an FIR in the pay-off case.

The court also stayed further investigation in the case. The Division Bench also stayed the single Bench order directing the registration of the FIR.

The Single Bench had observed that an offence was *prima facie* made out in the letter given by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to the State Police Chief, which allegedly contained details of a predicate offence under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, against the accused.

The ED was investigating the alleged pay-off case under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002. The accused had sought permission to appeal against the Single Bench order, but were denied by the Division Bench. Subsequently, the accused approached the Supreme Court, which stayed the State's investigation and restored the case to the Division Bench files.

The accused, represented by lawyers N. Hariharan, Sidharth Luthra, K. Gopalakrishna Kurup and T.A. Shaji, argued that the petitioner, lawyer K.M. Shajahan, had not followed proper procedure as per the Bharatiya Nyaya Surakhsha Sanhita, 2023, in seeking the registration of an FIR before the single Judge.



Disruption continues: The Nilgiri mountain train service between Coonoor and Mettupalayam has been affected due to landslides at many places along the route. M. SATHYAMOORTHY

Persistent rain in Nilgiris triggers 7 more landslips

Wilson Thomas
COIMBATORE/NILGIRIS

Persistent rain in the Nilgiris in Tamil Nadu triggered seven more landslips and uprooted 15 trees in the 24-hour period ending 7 a.m. on Monday, further disrupting life and road connectivity at some places.

According to the rainfall data released by the district administration, the district recorded a total of 734.5 mm and an average of 23.69 mm. Kinnakorai in Kundah taluk (110 mm) and Kotagiri (68 mm) received heavy rain. A total of 14 rain-gauge stations, including Burliar (59 mm), Yedappalli (54 mm), and Kodanadu (42 mm), recorded moderate rain. Two men and a woman suffered injuries in rain-related accidents, including a tree fall, and three huts were partially damaged.

The Nilgiris had recorded 62 landslips when the district received a cumulative total rainfall of 453.9 mm in the previous 24-hour period that ended on Sunday morning.

Ms. Thanneeru said four relief camps had been established in schools and community halls. A total of 65 people were shifted to the relief camp.

The Collector said officials of the National Highways Authority of India and geotechnical experts assessed the damage caused by the landslips to Mettupalayam-Udhagamandalam Road on Monday. "Vehicular traffic can be allowed on the road only after the damaged portions were repaired," she added.

The Salem division of Southern Railway on Monday said two services of the Nilgiri Mountain Railway (NMR) would not operate for three days starting from Tuesday owing to the obstructions caused by mudslides and landslips.

The division added that the obstructions were being removed, but continuous rainfall was hampering the restoration and the difficult terrain posed severe challenges.

Judge booked over car crash involving minor son; victim's family stages sit-in

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kochi City police have arraigned as an accused the additional district judge, who is the father of the 17-year-old boy accused of causing the death of a man after allegedly ramming his car into the victim's scooter on Sunday.

The judge, who is posted in a court in Irinjalakkuda in Thrissur district of Keralam, has been booked under Section 199A of the Motor Vehicles Act, which stipulates that where an offence has been committed by a juvenile, the guardian of the juvenile or the owner of the motor vehicle shall be deemed guilty of the contravention and liable to be proceeded against and punished accordingly.

On Monday, the Juvenile Justice Board (JJB) granted bail to the teenager citing the absence of any previous criminal antecedents.

Sit-in for justice

The deceased was identified as Jayabalakrishnan, 55, of Chittur, Cheranalloor. He was returning after closing his eatery at Chittur and died due to his injuries on the spot. The accident occurred around 2.20 a.m. near a car showroom at Maraparambu on Container Road in Cheranalloor.

The victim's family staged hours-long sit-in in front of the Cheranalloor police station on Monday demanding the arrest of the father-son duo booked in the case. They sought to know why the judge wasn't suspended and arrested. Despite negotiations led by Deputy Commissioner of Police (Kochi City), they refused to back down and threatened to continue their protest until their demands were met.

INBRIEF



Operate affordable flights, say Malayalis in Saudi Arabia

The Malayali diaspora in Saudi Arabia has sought the State government's intervention to arrange chartered flight services between Saudi Arabia and Keralam at affordable rates amid the escalating conflict in the Gulf region. They have submitted a proposal to this effect, along with other demands, to the State government following a meeting held under the aegis of NoRKA-Roots, the field agency of the Department of Non-Resident Keralites Affairs (NORKA), to discuss the challenges faced by Keralite expatriates in Saudi Arabia.

Work afoot to plug gas leak from ONGC pipeline in A.P.

Safety personnel of the Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) are working to plug a natural gas leak from a pipeline near Machavaram village of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema district, Andhra Pradesh. Local residents reported a minor gas leak around 8.30 a.m. on Monday. ONGC authorities, who are coordinating the operation, told *The Hindu*: "Our own safety wing personnel are involved in plugging the natural gas leak from the pipeline and later the existing pipeline will be replaced. The fire was under control by 11.20 a.m."

Nepal gang held in ex-IPS officer's wife murder case

Six months after the murder of a retired IPS officer's wife at Jubilee Hills in Hyderabad, the police have arrested four accused – all Nepali nationals – from the Nampally Railway Station. Tanuja Ranjan, the retired officer's wife, was killed at her house in May. The accused include a woman who worked as a maid at the residence. The police said the gang's modus operandi was to commit offences, flee to Nepal and return later to resume criminal activities, the police said. The four were held on their return trip to India.

Keralam defends generic SMA drug, eyes further price cut

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam government on Monday defended the switch to a generic drug for patients with spinal muscular atrophy (SMA) and said it would try to further reduce the price of the drug.

Speaking in the Assembly, Health Minister K. Muraleedharan announced that the government's aim, eventually, was to offer medicines free of cost to all SMA patients.

The Minister was responding to an adjournment motion moved by the Opposition Left Democratic Front (LDF). While the Opposition accused the government of launching "clinical trials" on SMA patients and pushing a corporatisation agenda in the health sector through the task force, Mr. Satheesan said both decisions were taken in the best interests of the people.

Mr. Satheesan said the government decision gave patients access to a generic drug that cost just ₹15,000 when the branded version cost ₹6.5 lakh for 12 days.

The generic alternative, marketed by Natco Pharma, had statutory clearances from the government agencies concerned, he said. "It has brought immense relief to the families of patients. Our belief is that the price can be reduced further to ₹9,000," Mr. Satheesan said.

A still spread



Bountiful blue: Fishermen at work in the catchment area of the Malampuzha dam in Palakkad, Keralam, on Monday. The northeast monsoon has brought good inflows into the reservoir. K.K. MUSTAFAH

Maharashtra agrees to review higher Tummidihatti barrage

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has responded positively to Telangana's request to increase the height of the proposed Tummidihatti barrage across the Pranahita river on the Telangana-Maharashtra border from 148 metres to 152 metres, while making it clear that the project should not adversely affect Maharashtra or its people.

At a meeting with Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy in Mumbai on Monday, Mr. Fadnavis proposed constituting a joint committee headed by the Principal Secretaries of the Irrigation Departments of the two States to examine the technical feasibility of the proposal, water availability, and other related issues.

The committee will assess the likely impact on agricultural land and local communities, compensation requirements and possible alternatives before preparing a timeline and roadmap for further action. The Central Water Commission (CWC) will continue its technical examination within its jurisdiction.

Barrage at 152 metres

Telangana Irrigation Minister N. Uttam Kumar Reddy made a detailed presentation explaining why a barrage at 152 metres would be more viable than the 148-metre height envisaged in the 2016 agreement. He cited the need to maximise gravity-based water conveyance in view of rising power costs, energy requirements, environmental concerns, climate change and long-term operational sustainability.

Mr. Uttam Kumar Reddy also conveyed the Telangana government's willingness to compensate farmers in Maharashtra whose agricultural land might be affected by submergence, in accordance with that State's land acquisition guidelines and compensation policies.

Karnataka to publish final post-SIR electoral roll today

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

After more than three months of a clean-up drive under the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, Karnataka's final electoral roll will be published on Tuesday. The list will be uploaded on the website of the Chief Electoral Officer, Karnataka.

The exercise led to the deletion of 1.07 crore names across the State. Karnataka had 5.54 crore voters when the exercise began. The draft rolls contained 4.54 crore voters, with around one crore names struck off the rolls. Details on the number of ineligible voters identified, or the count of foreign citizens – another stated aim of the SIR – remain unknown so far.

During the draft rolls stage, 16.39 lakh names were deleted on the ground that the voters were dead, while over seven lakh were identified as duplicate entries. Another 3.83 lakh names were deleted under the "Others" category, which is not seen in many other States that conducted the SIR. Even as the exercise comes to an end, the CEO's office has not clearly explained what the "Others" category comprises.

However, the largest category of deletions – 80.62 lakh names – comprised voters who had shifted residence or were not found at their addresses during the enumeration phase. Unlike those identified as dead or duplicate, these voters were not necessarily ineligible to vote. They would have had to apply through Form 6 to have their names restored to the rolls. Yet, only 7,87,534 applications for inclusion were received, a figure that also includes applications from new voters.

The scale of deletions under the SIR has not been offset by additions in any constituency across the State, with applications for inclusion falling far short of the number of names struck off the draft rolls.

ECI suspends 6 U.P. officials for dereliction of poll duty

The Hindu Bureau
LUCKNOW

Amid uproar over alleged supervisory lapses in the Legislative Council election to the Agra Division teachers' constituency, the Election Commission of India (ECI) on Monday placed six officials under suspension with immediate effect for failing to ensure effective supervision within and in the vicinity of the polling stations.

The commission, in a letter to the Chief Electoral Officer of Uttar Pradesh, said such dereliction of duty on the part of officers holding supervisory positions cannot be condoned.

Report sought

The Chief Electoral Officer has been directed to send a compliance report immediately.

Earlier, the ECI, on the recommendation of the Chief Electoral Officer, Uttar Pradesh, had declared void the polling conducted on October 23 at three stations for the Agra Division teachers' constituency election, and announced a repoll on October 26. Monday's repoll was conducted peacefully as the total polling at the three stations stood at 57.16%.

Centre approves defence deals worth ₹2.12 lakh cr.

Approvals cover a wide range of platforms, weapons and surveillance systems for the Army, Navy and Air Force; 82% of the total procurement value has been earmarked for the domestic industry

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Defence Acquisition Council, or DAC, chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, on Monday accorded Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) for capital acquisition proposals worth approximately ₹2.12 lakh crore for the three Services, with about 82% of the procurements to be sourced from the domestic industry.

According to the Ministry of Defence, the approvals cover a wide range of military platforms, weapons and surveillance systems aimed at enhancing the operational capabilities, mobility and combat preparedness of the Army, Navy and Air Force.

For the Indian Army, the DAC cleared procurement of high mobility vehicles (HMVs), self-propelled tracked gun systems, gun shot response systems (GSRSs), light multi-role helicopters (LMRHs), very short-range air defence systems (VSHORADS), platform-based counter-unmanned aerial systems (C-UAS), long-range unmanned aerial systems, surveillance UAVs, integrated surveillance and strike systems, and long-range kamikaze drones.



For the IAF, approvals were accorded for helicopters, air defence systems to strengthen its war-fighting capabilities. MURALI KUMAR K.

Logistics boost

The HMVs are expected to strengthen logistics and mobility, while the self-propelled tracked gun systems will provide mechanised formations with matching mobility and firepower. The GSRS will act as a force multiplier by providing real-time situational awareness. The LMRHs will be used by the Army and the Air Force for reconnaissance and surveillance, combat operations, search and rescue, and humanitarian assistance and disaster relief missions.

The VSHORADS will enhance the Army's capability to engage emerging small-sized aerial threats, while the platform-based C-UAS will improve the survivability of tanks on the modern battlefield. The surveillance and drone systems are expected to strengthen the Army's reconnaissance, surveillance and targeting capabilities.

For the Navy, the council accorded AoN for the procurement of Active Offboard Decoy Systems (AODS) and other major naval platforms. The AODS will strengthen the Navy's anti-missile defence capabilities. The indigenously designed and constructed naval platforms will incorporate modern warfare capabilities and enhance the Navy's overall combat potential.

Approvals for IAF

For the Air Force, approvals were accorded for helicopters, air defence systems, weapons and mobile x-band doppler weather radar systems to strengthen its air defence and war-fighting capabilities. The procurement of special utility helicopters will address the IAF's transport requirements, while the radar systems will provide high-resolution, localised weather surveillance.

The DAC's approvals are expected to provide a significant boost to domestic defence manufacturing, with nearly 82% of the total procurement value earmarked for domestic industry.

Parliaments have a vital duty to listen to concerns of youth, says Om Birla

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Parliaments have a vital responsibility to listen to young people and understand their hopes and concerns, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla said at the inaugural session of the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum at the Samvidhan Sadan here on Monday.

Mr. Birla said the youth today have growing access to quality education and technological knowledge, along with a strong desire to innovate, excel, and contribute to society.

"The aspirations of the youth must be met with meaningful opportunities, dignity, and an enabling environment in which their talents can flourish," he said, adding that empowering young people was not only an investment in their future but also a commitment to the collective destiny of nations.

Mr. Birla said the world was passing through a period of "profound uncertainty", marked by regional conflicts, economic instability, and climate change, whose consequences transcended borders. He stressed the need for countries to work towards a shared future, ensuring that dialogue translated into action.



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla with UAE Federal National Council Speaker Saqr Ghobash in New Delhi. PTI

Mr. Modi interacted with the delegations after the inaugural session, officials said. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, Congress MP Shashi Tharoor and other Indian parliamentarians also met the visiting delegates from BRICS member and partner countries. The member countries participating in the two-day forum are Brazil, Russia, China, Egypt, the UAE, and Iran. Partner countries attending the meeting include Belarus, Cuba, Thailand, Uganda, Vietnam, Uzbekistan, and Kazakhstan.

Rajnath to lead Indian delegation at ASEAN meet in Philippines

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will lead the Indian delegation at the 13th ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting (ADMM)-Plus in Cebu, Philippines, from October 28 to 29, where he is scheduled to address the forum on regional and international security issues.

On the sidelines of the meeting, Mr. Singh is expected to hold bilateral discussions with his counterparts from participating countries to review ongoing defence cooperation and explore avenues for further strengthening strategic partnerships, the Defence Ministry said.

The ADMM-Plus is a key regional platform for dialogue and cooperation on defence and security issues, bringing together the 11 ASEAN member-states and eight Dialogue Partners – India, the U.S., China, Russia, Japan, South Korea, Australia and New Zealand.

The meeting will provide an opportunity for countries to exchange views on the evolving regional and international security environment and discuss ways to strengthen defence cooperation.

The Philippines is chairing the ADMM-Plus in 2026. India, meanwhile, is co-chairing the Experts Working Group on Counter-Terrorism with Malaysia for the 2024-2027 cycle.

Book offering comprehensive view of cancer care launched

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Hindu Group, in association with the Cancer Institute (WIA), Adyar, launched *Cancer 360: Overview of Detection, Treatment, Palliation*, a book examining cancer care from prevention and early detection to treatment, rehabilitation and palliative care. The book was launched at *The Hindu* office in Chennai.

N. Ram, Director of The Hindu Group, launched the book alongside Suresh Nambath, Editor of *The Hindu*. Mr. Ram handed over the first copy to E. Hemanth Raj, Executive Vice-Chairman of Cancer Institute.

Speaking at the launch, Mr. Ram emphasised the importance of making advanced cancer care accessible and affordable. He highlighted the institute's work in providing treatment to those who need it most and stressed the need to ensure that advances in cancer care reach patients facing barriers to treatment.



(From right) Suresh Nambath, Editor, *The Hindu;* N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group; Dr. E. Hemanth Raj, Executive Vice-Chairman, Cancer Institute, Adyar; Dr. Mahalakshmi Rangabashyam Shetty, ENT surgeon and lecturer; Dr. Arvind Krishnamurthy, Deputy Medical Director, Cancer Institute, Adyar; Dr. V. Surendran, Professor and Head of the Department of Psycho-Oncology; and Ramya Kannan, Chief of Bureau (Tamil Nadu), at the Cancer 360 book launch at *The Hindu* office in Chennai on Monday. R. RAGU

Dr. Hemanth Raj spoke about the need to translate advances in cancer research, much of which takes place in the West, into practical interventions in local settings. He also highlighted the institute's charitable programmes, supported by donations, to help patients access treatment and facilities, and its plans to expand cancer care to reach more patients.

Arvind Krishnamurthy, Professor of surgical oncology at Cancer Institute, stressed the need for continued research to improve cancer care and develop better treatments.

At the launch, N. Ram emphasised the importance of making advanced cancer care affordable

The book also addresses care beyond treatment. Mahalakshmi Rangabashyam Shetty, ENT surgeon and lecturer in the Department of Surgical Oncology at the institute, spoke about individualised treatment plans developed through multidisciplinary consultations. She also highlighted the need to tailor exercise and nutrition regimens to individual patients, alongside supportive services such as hospice care.

Surendran Veeraiah, Professor and Head of the Department of Regional Cancer Centre, Cancer Institute, emphasised the importance of psychological support and allied services.

He said the book could help make technical information on comprehensive cancer care accessible to more people.

The book features contributions from experts across oncology and allied disciplines. Its chapters cover multidisciplinary tumour boards, psychological care, onco-physiotherapy, palliative care, cancer research, speech and swallowing rehabilitation, early detection, precision treatment, pathology, nutrition and healthcare quality.

The book is available free of cost to *The Hindu* subscribers at https://www.thehindu.com/premium/ebook/

Trial judge in Lakhimpur Kheri case shifted, SC told

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court was apprised on Monday that the trial judge hearing the Lakhimpur Kheri killings case, involving the son of a former Union Minister in the array of prime accused, has been transferred out.

Senior advocate Siddharth Dave, for Ashish Mishra, former Minister Ajay Mishra's son, said the transfer was a "routine one", and had nothing to do with the suspicions raised by the victims.

On October 3, 2021, eight people, including four farmers, were killed in Tikunia in Uttar Pradesh's Lakhimpur Kheri district during a protest by farmers against Deputy Chief Minister Keshav Prasad Maurya's visit to the area.

On Monday, the apex court allowed Mr. Ashish Mishra to visit hometown for Deepavali festivities.

U.P. court acquits Rahul in 2018 defamation case over remarks against Amit Shah

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

An MP/MLA court in Sultanpur district in Uttar Pradesh on Monday acquitted senior Congress leader and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, in a defamation case filed against him for allegedly making a defamatory statement in 2018 about then BJP national president Amit Shah.

The case, filed by local BJP leader Vijay Mishra, alleged that Mr. Gandhi had called Mr. Shah a "murder accused". During the hearing, the Congress leader disputed the allegations and said the statement was presented out of context. Mr. Gandhi was present in court when the Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate pronounced the verdict.

"A defamation lawsuit related to a remark made in Bengaluru during the 2018 Karnataka Assembly elections... Judge Shubham Verma of the special MP/MLA court in Sultanpur dismissed the case," said Kunwar Singh Nishad, chairman, media department, Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee.



Rahul Gandhi meets his legal team in the 2018 defamation case in Sultanpur on Monday.

Rahul's remarks

Speaking in Karnataka in 2018, Mr. Gandhi had allegedly said, "People in India forget that the president of BJP is a murder accused. That's the truth. The party that talks about honesty, decency, has a person who has been accused of murder as president."

K.C. Venugopal, general secretary (organisation) of the Congress, repeated Mr. Gandhi's words and said that the BJP was run by criminals and promoted those who commit the worst crimes. "The Hon'ble Court has clearly held that there is nothing defamatory about Rahul ji's 2018 statement about Amit Shah... Ours is a noble fight to defeat these criminals. We will fight on Gandhian lines and defeat them with love, compassion and perseverance. Satyamev Jayate," he wrote on X.

Before the hearing, at least four vehicles and an ambulance following Mr. Gandhi's convoy collided on the Purvanchal Expressway. The Uttar Pradesh government has constituted a three-member special investigation team to probe the accident.

Violence marks shutdown against proposed dam in Arunachal Pradesh

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Violence during a 12-hour shutdown paralysed parts of Arunachal Pradesh's Upper Subansiri district on Monday, leading to the cancellation of a public hearing on the proposed 1,605-megawatt Subansiri Upper Hydroelectric Project, also known as the Menga Dam.

Several student and community-based organisations, led by the All Tagin Students' Union (ATSU), called the shutdown. The alleged attempt by the police to detain ATSU president Tadak Pakba late on Saturday night was among the triggers for the protest.

A district official, declining to be quoted, said the shutdown was marked by arson, vandalism and clashes with the police. Much of the violence was concentrated in Daporijo, the headquarters of Upper Subansiri district, which has been in the news over alleged incursions by Chinese soldiers.



Villagers along the river belt protesting against the project in Siang district of Arunachal Pradesh. FILE PHOTO

Videos shared on social media appear to show a private vehicle being set on fire, a police vehicle being damaged and overturned, and some two-wheelers being damaged. Protesters also reportedly damaged or burnt equipment, computer peripherals and surveying instruments at an office associated with National Hydroelectric Power Corporation, which is pursuing the project.

The protesters demanded the withdrawal of the proposed project on the Subansiri River, citing concerns over its environmental impacts, livelihoods, indigenous rights and the interests of affected communities.

Second stir in 48 hours

The agitation against the Subansiri project followed a similar protest on October 24 against the pre-feasibility study for the proposed 11,200-MW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project in the Siang River valley. Pasighat, the headquarters of East Siang district, was the epicentre of that protest.

Locals, mostly belonging to the Adi community, are against the Siang project, fearing large-scale displacement and adverse environmental consequences. The Centre, however, considers the project necessary to counter a 60,000-MW hydropower project that China is building upstream on the Yarlung Tsangpo, the river that enters India from Tibet as the Siang and meets Dibang and Lohit rivers downstream to form the Brahmaputra.

The Centre ordered the deployment of two additional companies of the Rapid Action Force after the Pasighat violence, in which four women experienced tear gas-induced problems and a few security personnel were injured in stone-pelting.

Rajnath slams Cong. chief for his remarks against Modi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday criticised Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge for his remarks about the late father of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Mr. Singh said the Congress chief's remarks had hurt the sentiments of crores of Indians. Political opposition should remain confined to policies and should not violate personal and family decorum, he said.

Describing the remarks made by Mr. Kharge in Patna on Saturday as "a reflection of the Congress's political culture and ideological decline", Mr. Singh said instead of admitting its mistake and expressing regret, the Congress was "busy justifying and defending the statement".

He said a "greater seriousness, restraint, decorum and responsible conduct" was expected from Mr. Kharge in public life and such remarks went against the "dignity of his office" and raises serious questions about the "political culture" of the Congress. "Political opposition has its place, but such conduct cannot be acceptable under any circumstances," he said.

CEC worked under Modi, Shah's instructions: Cong.

Cong. chief appeals to citizens to join INDIA bloc's *Chalo Dilli* rally on November 1; Rahul tells traders that Congress' protest will end in '30 seconds' if govt. sacks Chief Election Commissioner

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI/CHANDIGARH

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Monday said that while people were battling "back-breaking" inflation during the festive season, the government was preoccupied with "vote theft".

Appealing to citizens to join the INDIA bloc's *Chalo Dilli* rally on November 1, Mr. Kharge said Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar should resign and the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls should be stopped immediately.

"It's festival season, but at this time you are struggling with back-breaking inflation. Yet the government has absolutely no concern about this, because it only knows how to steal votes," Mr. Kharge said in a video statement posted on his X handle.

The Congress chief alleged that vote theft had taken place on a massive scale and was continuing. "The constitutional right to vote of millions of Indians is in danger. For this, CEC Gyanesh Kumar is solely responsible. He has done all this on the instructions of the Prime Minister and the Home Minister," Mr. Kharge claimed.


Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi have been speaking out against the SIR of electoral rolls. FILE PHOTO

In a separate post on X, Mr. Kharge said the Election Commission of India had refused to provide information under the Right to Information Act on the software used for the SIR, citing "trade secrets".

Traders' concerns

Senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi also responded to reports that the protests planned for the festive season had affected traders in Delhi, saying the agitation would end within 30 seconds if the CEC was removed.

"To every trader in Delhi: We love you and hear you. The Govt shut the metro, sealed our roads and locked down our capital. With a stolen vote nothing is safe – your shop, your savings, your children's future," Mr. Gandhi said in a post on X. "Tell Modi to sack accused no. 4, Gyanesh Kumar and the protests will stop in 30 seconds," he added.

Mr. Gandhi's post came after traders staged a protest in the Kashmere Gate area of Old Delhi, demanding that the Congress defer its November 1 rally at Ramlila Maidan until after Deepavali.

Chamber of Trade and Industry chairman Brijesh Goyal claimed that major wholesale markets within a five-km radius of Ramlila Maidan could be affected by the rally. These include Chandni Chowk, Sadar Bazar, Khari Baoli, Naya Bazar, Chawri Bazar, Daryaganj, and Kashmere Gate.

Defends Cong. chief

Congress general secretary K.C. Venugopal defended Mr. Kharge's alleged offensive remark against Prime Minister Narendra Modi, calling it an ideological, not personal, attack.

Responding to a question surrounding the remark, Mr. Venugopal said, "I think Khargeji means that ideologically. Ideologically, of these BJP people, the parent is the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh [RSS], and Khargeji means that only. That's what I understood. Who represents that ideology? The RSS. That's what Kharge *ji* means. You see, what did they do against Kharge *ji*? Purification exercise. He [Kharge] comes from a marginalised background; he went for a program, and after the program, a purification exercise was done. What does it mean?".

Ahead of local body polls, fate of deleted voters in Kolkata remains uncertain

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

With elections to Kolkata and Howrah Municipal Corporations in West Bengal scheduled to be held next month, the fate of voters whose names have been deleted during the special intensive revision (SIR) of voter lists, including those whose appeals are stuck in tribunals, remains hanging as it is unclear whether they would be able to vote in the urban local body polls.

As per Article 243ZA of the Constitution, the superintendence, direction and control of the preparation of electoral rolls for all municipal elections vests with the State Election Commission and not with the Election Commission of India (ECI).

The State Election Commission, according to Section 5 of the West Bengal State Election Commission Act, 1994, has the "discretion" on whether it wants to adopt the electoral rolls used for Assembly election in the municipal elections. It also has statutory powers to undertake additions and deletions to the electoral rolls, which has been used for Assembly election.

The ECI, on its part, has also begun special drives to re-enrol voters left out during the SIR and has also announced the annual special summary revision (SSR) following widespread protests over large-scale deletions of voter names. The final SSR list will be published on January 4.


No clarity: People submitting their applications to an appellate tribunal for appeals related to SIR of electoral rolls in Bengal. PTI

Opposition's demand

Opposition parties as well as civil society members have also demanded that the State Election Commission, consider holding elections only after the conclusion of the special re-enrolment drive and special summary revision.

In a memorandum submitted to State Election Commissioner Krishna Gupta on Monday, they also urged him to include all appellants, whose appeals are pending before the SIR appellate tribunals.

Those who signed the memorandum included Pradesh Congress president Subhankar Sarkar, Mamata All India Trinamool Congress MP Saugata Roy and former MPs Samik Lahiri and Jawhar Sircar.

According to the leaders, the office of the State Election Commissioner has said that he will meet a delegation of representatives of the signatory organisations on Wednesday to deliberate upon the issue. In West Bengal, nearly 60 lakh voters were removed during the enumeration phase under the Absent/Shifted/Duplicate and Dead category. Simultaneously, the cases of more than 37 lakh voters are stuck in Appellate Tribunals.

Deleted voters will not be prosecuted for filing Form 6: SC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday orally assured that no voter, whose name was deleted during the special intensive revision (SIR) of poll rolls in Maharashtra, will face prosecution for merely applying for re-registration by filing Form 6.

The oral observations came during a hearing in which the court agreed to urgently take up on November 5, a plea challenging the deletion of voters in the Maharashtra SIR.

Redevelopment projects

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant was informed that thousands of voters were marked absent in Mumbai and Pune because of the home development projects in these cities.

"Old residential buildings are undergoing redevelopment for new flats. As a result, residents are shifted out. They number in thousands. They are all found to be marked absent in the SIR and later deleted from the electoral roll," senior advocate Arvind Datar, for petitioner Arun Anantagiri, submitted.

He said there were 3,500 such redevelopment projects in Mumbai and 1,500 in Pune.

Mr. Dattar also pointed out that deleted voters are being compelled to submit Form 6 (application to register as a new voter) and represent themselves as fresh voters.

"Pre-existing voters misrepresenting themselves as fresh voters is an offence and liable for prosecution," Mr. Datar submitted. "Do not worry. Nobody will be prosecuted," Chief Justice Kant responded orally.

Mr. Datar said a new form should be notified exclusively for deleted voters in the SIR.

Raided Kuki-Zo camp among two to be relocated under new MHA deal

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Sinai, the designated Kuki-Zo insurgent camp in Kangpokpi of Manipur that was raided by the security forces, is one of two camps run by Kuki-Zo insurgent groups that the Union Home Ministry and the Manipur government want relocated as per a new agreement signed in 2025.

The October 23 raid had led to the arrest of 17 people.

There are 24 Kuki-Zo insurgent groups under the umbrella of the United Peoples' Front (UPF) and the Kuki National Organisation (KNO), which signed a suspension of operations (SoO) agreement with the Home Ministry and the Manipur government in 2008, after the Kuki-Naga clashes of the 1990s when hundreds were killed.

The pact was periodically extended till February 2024, when the Manipur government refused to extend it, in the wake of the ethnic violence that broke out between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo people on May 3, 2023.


Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh during an inspection of the Sinai Camp on Sunday. PTI

The SoO was then signed afresh on September 4, 2025, with new terms and conditions after renewed tensions in the State, with ethnic violence extending between the Naga and Kuki communities. The new SoO agreement says the KNO and UPF shall have six camps each, instead of the 14 total camps presently. The camps must be located away from populated areas, national highways, and areas vulnerable to conflict, and at a reasonable distance from the Myanmar border as well as inter-State boundaries.

In a "surprise raid" on October 23, a joint team of Manipur police, Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), and Assam Rifles had found only 18 people at the Sinai camp, against the sanctioned strength of 150. According to police, the "17 individuals were found impersonating registered SoO cadres using false identities."

The camp is now under the custody of the CRPF. The camp is close to Nongshum, a hilly area near the border between the Meitei-majority Imphal East and the Kuki-dominated Kangpokpi districts, where three Meitei villagers were killed on October 19.

A senior government official said that since the SoO has not been extended, the raid at the Sinai camp would set a precedent. "SoO camps till now were untouchable, but from now, we expect adherence to ground rules. As per our record, 159 cadres were supposed to be at Sinai. However, only one out of 18 people found at the time of the raid was authorised to be there," the government official said.

India is working hard to reduce fiscal deficit: Sitharaman

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUCHI

The government had been working to bring down the fiscal deficit despite challenges, she said

India is among the few nations working actively to reduce its fiscal deficit in the global economy, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said in Tiruchi on Monday.

Speaking to reporters after attending the platinum jubilee celebrations of her alma mater Seethalakshmi Ramaswami College in Tiruchi, she said the government had been consistently working to bring down the fiscal deficit despite challenges posed by developments such as the COVID-19 pandemic.

"When you study the credit situation of nations in the post-COVID era, our country's efforts to reduce our debts before and after the pandemic, have borne fruit, as seen in the steady decrease of the fiscal deficit in the past three years. We are confident of achieving the target of reducing national debt to 50% of the gross domestic product by 2030," she said.

"Many leading global organisations acknowledge that India is making the most creditworthy efforts to reduce its fiscal deficit. We are also working actively to increase the per capita income of every Indian citizen, but we have had a series of challenges, such as the pandemic, then war [in West Asia] and the soaring rise in fuel prices. We are trying to control the burden of inflation faced by the public," she added.

Ms. Sitharaman declined to answer questions on Tamil Nadu's borrowings.

SC directs U.P. to pay ₹6 lakh to man jailed after 'slipshod' murder probe

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Pulling up the Uttar Pradesh Police for a "slipshod investigation" that led to a man spending six years in custody as an undertrial in a murder case, the Supreme Court on Monday directed the State government to pay him ₹6 lakh as "reparation".

The court said the State police would "do well to educate their officers in the process of investigation". The top court was hearing a plea by the undertrial, who had challenged an order of the Allahabad High Court denying him bail in a kidnapping and murder case registered in Agra in 2019. He had been in custody since November 14, 2019.



> It is unfortunate that despite the absence of evidence, the petitioner was imprisoned for six years as an undertrial
> **SUPREME COURT BENCH**

"It is unfortunate that despite no evidence against the petitioner, he was imprisoned for six years as an undertrial. Based on a slipshod investigation, a haphazard prosecution was carried out, which resulted, fortunately, in the acquittal of the accused. We cannot but deprecate the manner in which the investigation was carried out," the Bench observed.

On March 23, the top court, noting his prolonged incarceration and the prosecution's reliance entirely on circumstantial evidence, directed the trial court to conclude the proceedings within three months. The trial was subsequently completed and he was later acquitted.

The top court said it was "appalled" by the manner in which the probe had been carried out. It described the proceedings as a "classic case of how an investigation should not be proceeded with".

"We come across such travesty of justice in many matters, but in some, so blatant and shocking, as in this case, which requires reparation to the accused, who in turn is a victim of the system. We, hence, direct the State to pay an amount of ₹6,00,000, though paltry in comparison to the years spent in custody within a period of one month to the petitioner," the Bench said.

Media association challenges govt.'s data privacy law in Supreme Court

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Digital News Publishers Association (DNPA), which has members drawn from across the media spectrum, including those owned by the Ambani and Adani Groups, has challenged the Union government's privacy law as a violation of journalistic freedom.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant is scheduled to hear a batch of petitions filed by activists on Tuesday. *The Hindu* is a member of the DNPA.

The petition filed by the DNPA, which is also listed before the Bench, challenged specific provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, and the Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025.

The DNPA said the law was completely in contravention with the law laid down by the Supreme Court in its privacy judgment, which held the right inviolable and fundamental to human dignity and life. "They impermissibly restrict the fundamental right to information and freedom of speech and expression," the petition said.

No exemption

They fail "to provide any exemption in favour of journalistic activity as a distinct class of processing, entitled to constitutional protection under Article 14 and 19(l)(a) of the Constitution of India and threaten the full spectrum of journalistic activity carried out by journalists, ground reporters, citizens, whistleblowers, RTI activists, and other stakeholders," the petition said.

It said publishers, editors, reporters and correspondents were, as a consequence of the law, brought within a regime of notice and prior consent, compelled erasure, and verifiable consent.

Unbridled authority

Section 36 of the DPDP Act, read with Rule 23 and the Seventh Schedule of the DPDP Rules, vested the Central government with an unbridled and standardless authority to requisition any information from any data fiduciary or intermediary, unaccompanied by judicial oversight, any requirement of necessity or proportionality, or notice to the affected data principal.

"Such a power is capable of being turned to the identification and targeting of journalistic sources and is thus constitutionally infirm," the petition said.

Section 44 (3) of the DPDP Act, by amending Section 8 (1)(j) of the Right to Information Act, 2005, has placed every category of "personal information" beyond the reach of disclosure.

INBRIEF



4 killed in M.P. as car catches fire after falling into culvert

Four men were charred to death and one injured in Madhya Pradesh's Dhar district after their car caught fire as a tyre burst and fell into a culvert, the police said on Monday. According to the police, the incident took place around 11.30 p.m. on Sunday. Five friends, all residents of district's Sagore area, were returning after visiting a temple. Additional Superintendent of Police Parul Belapurkar said Tushar Mandloi, 20, got thrown out of the car when it fell into the roadside culvert and survived, while the other four got trapped inside the vehicle. The deceased are Bheem Dhakad, 24; Chetan Dhakad, 21; Aditya Tiwari, 22; and Abhishek Solanki, 19.

No relaxation of bail terms for riots accused, rules top court

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to relax a bail condition barring Shadab Ahmad, an accused in the alleged larger conspiracy behind the 2020 Delhi riots, from leaving the national capital to attend law classes at a university in Ghaziabad. A Bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M. Pancholi declined his plea to modify the condition requiring him to remain in Delhi during the trial. On January 5, the top court had granted bail to Mr. Ahmad, along with activists Gulfisha Fatima, Shifa Ur Rehman, Mohd Saleem Khan, and Meeran Haider, in the Delhi riots conspiracy case, while imposing stringent conditions and cautioning that any misuse of liberty would invite cancellation of bail.

Five persons shot dead in Guwahati hotel; one held

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Five persons, including two women, were killed while another was injured in a firing incident in Guwahati on Monday night.

The incident occurred around 9 p.m. at a hotel in a lane in the city's Ulubari area. While four persons died on the spot, a fifth, identified as 48-year-old Narayan Das, died at the Gauhati Medical College and Hospital (GMCH).

"Another person, identified as Satyendra Pathak (42), is undergoing treatment. His condition is stable," a GMCH doctor said, adding that the two persons brought to the hospital were from western Assam's Barpeta.

"We found the bodies of four persons at the crime scene. We will nab the perpetrators," Guwahati's Commissioner of Police Parthasarathi Mahanta said.

The police in the city's Paltanbazar area caught a person suspected to have been the shooter in the incident. His identity was not disclosed. Among the dead were Helena Bharali, the owner of the property, and her son Debarshi Bharali. The motive behind the shooting was not immediately known.

A.P., Odisha step up evacuations as Cyclone Arnab nears coast

IMD issues red alerts for seven districts in Andhra Pradesh for today; 4,711 pregnant women will be shifted to safer healthcare facilities; Odisha readies 1,700 shelters in five southern districts

Nellore Sravani
Satyasundar Barik
VIJAYAWADA/BHUBANESWAR

The Andhra Pradesh government has directed officials to evacuate people from flood-prone areas, prioritise vulnerable residents, and deploy disaster response teams in the wake of Cyclone 'Arnab'. Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu has ordered heightened preparedness across the State, officials said, adding that 4,711 pregnant women will be shifted to safer healthcare facilities. They said 30,043 fishing boats have returned to the harbours.

With the cyclonic storm moving closer to land, the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Amaravati, has issued red alerts for seven of the 28 districts in Andhra Pradesh for Tuesday. Isolated extremely heavy rainfall, of 200 mm or more, is likely in the districts of Kakinada, East Godavari, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema, Eluru, West Godavari, Alluri Sitharama Raju, and Anakapalli, while heavy to very heavy rainfall of around 70 mm to 200 mm is likely in the districts of Vizianagaram, Visakhapatnam, NTR, Krishna, Guntur, Bapatla, Srikakulam, and Parvathipuram Manyam.



A policeman alerts tourists at Kothapatnam beach in Prakasam district of Andhra Pradesh on Monday. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

The storm is likely to cross the coast as a 'very severe cyclonic storm', with wind speed gusting to 140 kmph, close to Yanam or Kakinada in Andhra Pradesh around noon on Wednesday. The State has deputed seven National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and eight SDRF battalions to districts that are likely to be affected. For assistance, the public can contact 112, 1070, and 18004250101, the government said.

The Andhra Pradesh Eastern Power Distribution Company Limited has opened 30 divisional control rooms, in addition to 11 circle-level control rooms, to monitor the situation and coordinate emergency response.

1,700 shelters ready

In neighbouring Odisha, the government said over 1,700 shelters are ready to accommodate people likely to be evacuated in the southern districts of Malkangiri, Koraput, Nabarangpur, Gajapati, and Rayagada, which will be impacted by the cyclone.

Addressing the media after a review meeting with Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan through a video conference, Odisha Chief Secretary Anu Garg said, "We have prepared district-specific plans to face an emergency situation. We are monitoring the condition of roughly 3,000 pregnant women. They will be shifted to safer places if the situation warrants."

The Centre has assured the State that it will send additional disaster response forces and provide assistance of the Army and the Navy if the situation worsens, she said. Special Relief Commissioner Rajesh Pravakar Patil said the State has 135 permanent cyclone shelters in the vulnerable districts and 1,600 temporary shelters have been made available.

Eight NDRF teams, 40 Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force teams, and fire services personnel have been deployed.

"We are in constant touch with the Chhattisgarh government. When the cyclone curves away to Chhattisgarh, it will trigger heavy rain. This will leave the Mahanadi River in spate. Since we are around the full moon day, discharge of water to the sea would not be that easy," Suresh Pujari, State Revenue and Disaster Management Minister said.

3 paraded naked in Kolkata by kin of girl; 3 held

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

An 18-year old boy, his father, and a friend were paraded naked in a south Kolkata neighbourhood by the family members of a minor girl on Sunday. The girl's parents and uncle were arrested by the police on Monday over the incident.

The incident took place on Sunday night when the boy, accompanied by his 19-year-old friend, had gone to meet a 13-year-old girl.

The girl's family members, who were upset at this, caught hold of the two and physically assaulted them. When the boy's father rushed to the place, he too was assaulted. The police said the family members threatened to kill the three with a gun if they did not walk naked on the street. "They were paraded naked for about 50 metres in the lane in front of their house," the Kolkata Police said.

"The girl's father, her maternal uncle, and mother have been arrested. Searches are ongoing to arrest the remaining accused," the police added.

A case has been registered under various Sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act.

Plant-based meat beats traditional ones on protein bioavailability: study

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

While plant-derived kababs may still struggle to replicate the taste and texture of meat from a tandoori joint, they may contain relatively more protein in a form that the body can absorb, according to a study presented on Monday .

In a collaboration between the CSIR-Institute of Himalayan Bioresource Technology (CSIR-IHBT), Palampur, and the Good Food Institute (GFI) India, a non-profit that promotes alternative proteins such as plant-based, fermentation-derived and cultivated meat, scientists investigated whether protein bioavailability (meaning protein in a form that's nutritively useful to the body) of traditional meat was the same as that of plant-based meat. Tests on five cooked plant-based products – two burger patties, a nugget and two seekh kebabs – showed higher bioavailability percentages than their chicken counterparts, according to the findings presented at a press conference on Monday. The plant-based kebabs scored 80.8% and 86.1% against 38.8% for chicken. The nugget scored 61.2% against 43.4%, and the patties recorded about 57% and 58% against 21.2%.



The team used In vitro method for the study . GETTY IMAGES

The findings do not mean plant-based meat is healthier, but only that they are nutritively comparable, as 'healthier' is a subjective term, Dr. Padma Ishwarya, senior scientist at GFI India, told *The Hindu*. "It's too much of a vague term. It's too broad a term...for health, we need to do further studies."

The chicken products held more crude protein and released more amino acids, the building blocks of protein, during digestion, and Dr. Ishwarya said more products and samples would be tested in the next phase. The work has not yet been published as a journal paper. "It is a report that is hosted on our website, but it is very much peer-reviewed," Dr. Ishwarya said. Two experts reviewed it, she said, adding that detailed manuscripts would follow. The team used in vitro method that simulated digestion in a laboratory. Samples went through a two-minute salivary phase, then a stomach phase with digestive enzymes at pH 2 to 3, and then an intestinal phase. The method follows INFOGEST, an internationally harmonised protocol, Dr. Ishwarya said.

The team added an ultrafiltration membrane chosen to mimic the pore size of the human intestine. Whatever passed through the membrane was deemed bioavailable.

Animal studies remain the gold standard, she said, but are tedious and require ethical clearances. The simulated method is faster and more reproducible. The team plans to conduct tests across laboratories next year so that NABL-accredited labs can use the method.

Several IITs have far fewer counsellors than recommended by UGC: RTI data

Abhinay Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The number of mental health counsellors for students at multiple Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) across the country is several times lower than what the University Grants Commission (UGC) recommends, data obtained through the Right to Information Act (RTI), 2005, revealed.

While the UGC's guidelines for higher educational institutions on mental health and wellbeing recommend having one mental health professional/psychologist for every 500 students, RTI replies seen by *The Hindu* showed that IIT-Kharagpur is functioning with one counsellor for every 1,136 students, IIT-Roorkee has one counsellor for every 1,317 students, and the IIT in Varanasi (BHU) is operating with one counsellor for every 4,750 students. IIT-Jodhpur reported having six professional counsellors and psychiatrists for about 4,000 students, IIT-Patna had two for about 4,000 students, and IIT-Tirupati had three counsellors and psychologists for a student population of about 1,700. Only IIT-Ropar reported having enough counsellors as per UGC recommendation.



Sahil Wakode's parents sitting on hunger strike demanding institutional accountability. FILE PHOTO

Responding to detailed RTI queries from Pranav Jeevan, a former student of IIT-Bombay, IIT-Kharagpur revealed that it had recorded 10 student suicides in the last five years while IIT-Roorkee and IIT-BHU reported three suicides each in the same time.

This data come as protests are mounting in Mumbai seeking institutional accountability for the death by suicide of Sahil Wakode, a Dalit student at IIT-Bombay. A cursory check of IIT-Delhi showed a total of 12 counsellors available for around 12,000 students. Meanwhile, the website for IIT-Bombay's Student Wellness Centre is currently inaccessible.

The data obtained by Mr. Jeevan further showed that almost none of the seven IITs mentioned above fulfil reservation mandate for faculty members, with just IIT-Ropar reporting that 15% of its faculty members were from Scheduled Caste and 8.6% from Scheduled Tribes.

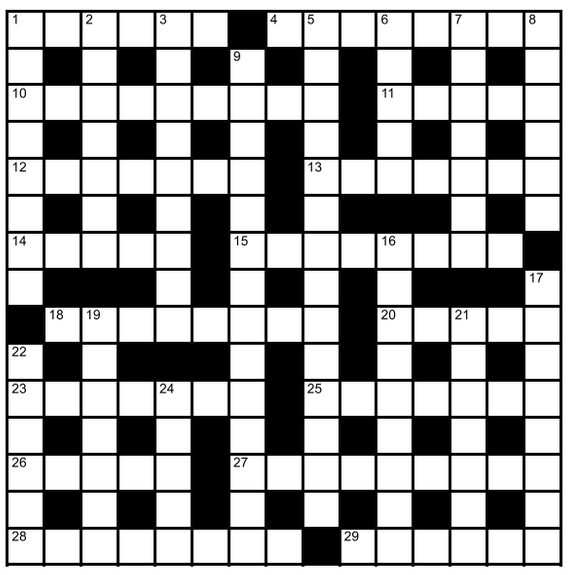
Apart from this, the representation of SCs among faculty members ranged from 2.8% to 10.9% in these institutes, of STs from 0.2% to 2.1%, and OBCs from 1.5% to 17.5%. The reservation policy mandates reserving 15% of hirings for SCs, 7.5% for STs, 27% for OBCs.

THE HINDU CROSSWORD + 14933

(set by KrisKross)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 Assign setter's place at end of table (6)
4 Venerable members of crusade meet secretly in retreat (8)
10 Healthy boxer is against bananas (9)
11 Worm's stroke of luck (5)
12 Crowd laments over losing last of matches and rubber (7)
13 Team's turn to play in pub and sing drunkenly (7)
14 In America, son of immigrants rejected? That's wrong (5)
15 Takes possession of international banks, having power (8)
18 One Malayali winning preliminary race, cycling all around (2,3,3)
20 Work in short-sleeved shirt and lightweight hat (5)
23 Muscles love running free! (7)
25 Cooked nan - neat dish perhaps (7)
26 Rebellious soldiers welcomed by the old adversary (5)
27 Creature often contaminating kitchens, running over appliances, creating havoc primarily (9)
28 Beast with tip of ear cut, caught in a net, writhing (8)
29 I essentially check and fix - do it right! (6)

Down

1 Following onset of insomnia, old queen gets tablet (4,4)
2 Churchmen in US state surrounded by troublemakers (7)
3 Cutting piece of cloth, start to wrap present afterwards (9)
5 Egotism of man going through elaborate profile in Outook (4-10)
6 Delicate fellow bathed in Northbound river (5)
7 Evil demon controlling ancient city felt sad (7)
8 Elegant English ship stops, having no water (6)
9 How to create acute pain, worry about something trivial? (5,2,1,6)
16 Fan turned out to be ignorant (9)
17 Tech giant announced "Warning!" symbol (8)
19 Developing space agency mostly with American money (7)
21 Aim to cut long ornament (7)
22 Beware! Machinery has rotating device (6)
24 Expression of amusement describing unknown American firm (5)

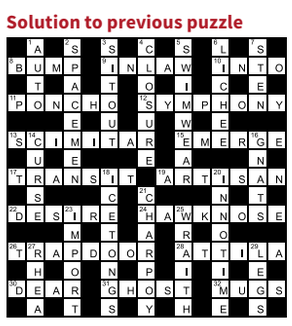
SUDOKU

	9		6					7
		6			8			1
5				3				
		5	7	2			8	
	4	7				1	2	
	8			1	5	3		
				9				6
7			1			8		
3					4		1	

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	3	2	1	8	7	4	9	6
4	8	9	6	5	2	3	1	7
6	7	1	4	9	3	5	8	2
2	5	6	7	3	9	1	4	8
7	4	3	8	2	1	6	5	9
9	1	8	5	4	6	2	7	3
3	9	4	2	1	8	7	6	5
1	2	7	9	6	5	8	3	4
8	6	5	3	7	4	9	2	1

FAITH

Lord Murugan settles debts

Lord Murugan blesses His devotees by granting their wishes, said Sumathi Sri in a discourse. Just as His father Lord Siva helps out devotees in their time of need, so does Murugan. Saint Gnanasambandar's father needed money for a yaga. Gnanasambandar sang the padigam *Idarinum Thalarinum* in the Gomuktiswara temple in Thiruvavaduthurai. Immediately, Lord Siva gave him a bag of gold. The speciality of this bag was that even if you took gold from it, the quantity of gold inside it would never get depleted. Thus Lord Siva provided for his father's worship. Even today, in the Tamil month of Thai, this event is celebrated in the Thiruvavaduthurai temple.

Murugan is known as *kadan adachaan sami* – the god who pays off our debts. There was a poet in Thiruchendur, who had incurred debts. He could not repay them, and the creditors became impatient. They abused him and said he was nothing more than a thief, and added that Murugan the God he worshipped was also a thief. The poet was hurt by the insult to Murugan. He prayed to the Lord to wipe out this insult. That night Murugan appeared in the dream of the temple officer and said the poet's debts should be settled using temple funds. Thus Murugan came to the rescue of His devotee, when the latter had huge debts to repay. Arunagirinatha uses the plural 'names' while talking about the name Murugan. It is not to be seen as a grammatical error. The use of the plural was deliberate. The '*mu*' in Murugan indicates Mukundan, that is Vishnu. The '*ru*' indicates Rudra, and the '*ka*' (ga) indicates Brahma. So when we say Murugan, we are actually worshipping all three Gods.

Kashmir's rice holds clues to a journey from East Asia

Kashmir's traditional varieties carry cold-tolerance and other locally adapted genes that modern varieties have partly lost, making them valuable for climate-resilient farming, research says; the varieties are more closely related to those from Korean Peninsula and Northeast China

Hirra Azmat
SRINAGAR



Fields of gold: A farmer works in a paddy field during the harvest season on the outskirts of Srinagar; the autumn season marks the paddy harvesting period in Kashmir. IMRAN NISSAR

For many generations, Kashmir's farmers have cultivated traditional varieties of rice – and a new study by researchers at the Sher-e-Kashmir University of Agricultural Sciences and Technology (SKUAST-Kashmir), Srinagar, has found that these varieties carry a unique genetic history.

According to the study, published in *The Plant Genome*, Kashmir's traditional varieties carry cold-tolerance and other locally adapted genes that modern varieties have partly lost, making them potentially valuable as climate change increases stress on crops.

The genetic analysis also indicated the varieties are more closely related to those from the Korean Peninsula and Northeast China.

3K rice panel

The SKUAST-Kashmir team began by placing Kashmir's rice on a larger genetic map.

In a 2018 study, Chinese researchers had collected rice germplasm – genetic material from seeds – from around the world and created the so-called 3K rice panel. Their 3,010 samples represented cultivated rice diversity from different parts of the world, including the *Oryza sativa* cultivated in Asia.

However, SKUAST-Kashmir genetics and plant breeding professor Asif Bashir Shikari said the 3K panel didn't include germplasm from Kashmir's traditional varieties.

"That was the primary reason we sequenced 142 rice germplasm accessions from Kashmir region and compared them with the 3K panel in our study," he said.

The team also looked beyond the overall genome. According to Dr. Shikari, rice has roughly 30,000 to 40,000 genes but not all of them are directly related to traits important for agriculture. So the team focused on 21 traits that were relevant and relatively easy to observe, including grain characteristics, starch content, aroma, and those related to adaptation.

They compared the Kashmir germplasm with that from other parts of the world – including China, India and Bangladesh – in the 3K panel on these traits. Thus they found that the Kashmir germplasm showed greater genetic affinity with rice from Korea and Northeast China.

"This was particularly interesting in the case of genes *HAN1* and *CTB4a*, associated with cold tolerance, because Kashmir's traditional rice is distinct from the rest of the country as it is cultivated under relatively cold conditions," Dr. Shikari said.

Tracing the journey

"If such traits were introduced through gene flow or the movement of germplasm, it could also provide clues about the historical movement of rice and help us investigate the possible routes through which these genetic characteristics reached Kashmir," he added. According to Gaurav Zinta, principal scientist in the biotechnology division at the CSIR-Institute of Himalayan Bioresource Technology, Palampur, the distinction "suggests Kashmir's traditional rice likely descends from temperate East Asian rice, similar to that grown in Korea and Japan, and was later shaped by the valley's short, cool growing season".

Dr. Zinta added that, on the other hand, modern varieties grown in the region tell a different story.

"Many were bred using lowland Indian rice to improve yield and grain type, and in the process, they lost much of the cold tolerance," he said.

"So the landraces are more than a piece of history. They are a reservoir of useful genes that modern breeding has partly left behind, and they deserve active conservation."

That said, the landraces are not purely East Asian: "Some of their genes, such as those affecting starch and cooking quality, resemble those of tropical rice, suggesting they also mixed with other rice types over time," Dr. Zinta explained. "Their history is best seen as layered rather than a single straight line."



"Shared genes show that Kashmir rice and East Asian rice are related, [but] not the path the rice took," he continued. "It could have crossed the Himalaya directly or come through Central Asia along early trade routes that later formed part of the Silk Road. The paper mentions both possibilities without clearly separating them."

To confirm the route, he suggested that researchers compare Kashmir rice with rice from regions along the way, including from Nepal and Tibet.

"Ancient rice grains found in Kashmir should also be dated and, where possible, their DNA analysed. This would show when rice reached Kashmir and where it originated."

He also said the study has some limitations, including studying a "fairly small" number of local landraces and the team not testing the varieties for cold tolerance, aroma or grain quality. As a result, "the link between genes and traits is predicted rather than demonstrated," Dr. Zinta added.

He said the effort nonetheless provided a strong foundation for future work.

Archaeology of rice

The research team also considered the fact that wheat, barley, and some millets were among the region's earliest cultivated crops.

Anil Pokharia, scientist at Birbal Sahni Institute of Palaeosciences, Lucknow, said there is no clear archaeological evidence of rice being cultivated in the Neolithic period, around 3,000 years ago.

"Wheat and barley appear to have been the dominant crops, with wheat cultivated as a long-duration crop, sown around October and harvested the following July or August. Rice appears to have been introduced later, possibly around 1000-1500 BC, during the megalithic period, although the exact timing remains uncertain," he said.

"With the introduction of rice as a summer crop, shorter-duration forms of wheat and other crops would also have been needed to fit the changing agricultural cycle."

That said, he added that the archaeological record at Burzahom and Gufkral are limited by the fact that rice grains could not be directly radiocarbon dated, increasing the uncertainty as to their precise age.

According to Dr. Shikari, the genomic evidence provides another line of evidence – and that genetic patterns in present-day Kashmir rice are consistent with the possibility that the region has a distinct history of rice cultivation.

The authors discuss in their paper that the evolutionary history of japonica rice appears to have been closely associated with climate changes during the mid-to-late Holocene, in a period characterised by cooling and unstable weather.

"The onset of cooler environmental conditions may have imposed strong selection pressure on rice populations, favouring genetic variants associated with cold tolerance," Dr. Shikari said.

Dr. Pokharia suggested Kashmir could be an important region for future archaeological research because of its position as a potential junction between influences from East and West Asia.

"The excavations carried out with a broader research perspective, combined with multidisciplinary approaches involving archaeology, genetics and other fields, could help researchers better understand the movement of crops, people and cultural influences into the region," he said.

(Hirra Azmat is a Kashmir-based journalist who writes on science, health, and environment. azmathirra@gmail.com)



Some people want companies to further define terms and intentions to better understand what exactly they hope to gain from religion. REUTERS

AI companies turn to religion for counsel on ethical models

Associated Press

As executives sound the alarm about AI's destructive potential and debate the need to develop morally good models, they are increasingly seeking input from philosophers and faith leaders.

Because these companies are not bound to a particular religion, the goal is often quite broad – an aggregate of moral ideas that can inform their models. But experts and adherents alike warn that this idea fails to reckon with how different traditions and world-views can often contradict one another. In short, they say, it's not exactly how religion works.

For decades, scholars have pushed back against a widespread view of religion as a set of rules or principles that can be divorced from the "messy, practical, ad hoc" ways adherents live, argues Webb Keane, an anthropologist at the University of Michigan.

The idea that religion can be separated from things like culture and politics remains entrenched, even though it suffuses both in many ways. Some worry that AI companies, as they ask various faith leaders to answer ethical questions, will further perpetuate a theory of religion that fails to recognise the importance of doctrine, ritual, and relationships.

Tech firms are turning to philosophers and faith leaders for guidance to build ethical AI models; experts say blending moral ideas from different religions and worldviews is challenging, as they hold conflicting beliefs and values

Here's the issue, Keane argues: If you assume that religion overall can offer a distinct set of extractable moral principles, using it to train AI risks prioritising certain traditions and distorting others – particularly when it comes to faiths that do not see themselves primarily as a system of ethics.

That's not to say these meetings have lacked diverse representation. Nor does it suggest that their engagement with religion hasn't been thoughtful from the perspective of those in attendance, like Meghan Sullivan, a philosopher of religion who leads an initiative on ethics and AI at the University of Notre Dame.

Earlier this year, Sullivan went to Anthropic for one of their meetings, which included Christians from different denominations. In contrast to conversations she'd had with other tech companies, she was impressed by the rigorous engagement with religion at Anthropic, which is widely seen as the AI company taking ethics and safety most seriously.

"The culture inside the company is similar to that on a good college campus in the sense that you've got a collection of very intellectually curious people," she said. "These meetings are pretty nerdy – I don't know if that's the best way to put it – in a good way."

Representatives from Meta, Google and Amazon have also met with the Vatican, while Microsoft has been vigorous about its religious outreach.

Religion is generally considered both ancient and universal. And while experts like the late influential scholar of Jonathan Z. Smith concede that is true in some ways, they say it's also not the full picture. Many scholars of religion today share Smith's view of their field. They call into question the idea that religions are a set of distinct, comparable systems, saying it's a modern notion that can be traced to as late as the 19th century. Buddhism and Hinduism, for example, were not recognised as clearly bounded traditions by the people who practiced them prior to the arrival of European scholars, says Tomoko Masuzawa, a religious studies scholar who wrote 'The Invention of World Religions'. Says Mazuzawa: "All these categories were not native."

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

A quiz on mountaineers and the highest peaks on earth

Radhika Santhanam

QUESTION #1

When mountaineers climb extreme heights, their bodies may not receive enough oxygen to function normally. This condition causes symptoms including confusion, restlessness, difficulty breathing, rapid heart rate, and bluish skin. Climbers on high peaks such as K2 and Everest often experience it. Name the condition.

QUESTION #2

The name of this mountain range translates to "abode of snow". About 50 million years ago, the Indian and Eurasian tectonic plates collided, leading to the formation of this range. Earthquakes are quite common in this range. Name the range.

QUESTION #3

There are 14 mountains in the world that rise above 8,000 metres in elevation. Of these, eight are found in one country. Name the country — and also the man who made history in 2019 by climbing all these 14 peaks in record time and who passed away recently in Pakistan.

QUESTION #4

Mt. Everest lies within the lowest layer of the earth's atmosphere, where clouds form and winds move air masses and high- and low-pressure systems. These processes drive daily weather, seasonal patterns, and larger climate phenomena such as El Niño. Which atmospheric layer is this?

QUESTION #5

Although Mt. Everest is the highest mountain above sea level, this volcano is more than 10,200 metres tall when measured from its base on the ocean floor to its summit. Revered by some as piko, or the "umbilical cord" connecting land to the heavens, it is also a premier site for astronomical observations because of its high altitude and the clear, dry skies over it. Name the volcano and the ocean on whose floor it rises.



Please send in your answers to science@thehindu.co.in

Visual: The Hindu goddess depicted in this photo is said to reside at X peak, which was also the first 8,000-metre peak to be summited. Name the peak. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Answers to October 15 quiz:
1. Boundary around a black hole that light can't escape – **Ans: Event horizon**
2. Effect describing a system's sensitivity to its initial conditions – **Ans: Butterfly effect**
3. Form of energy transferred between systems at different temperatures – **Ans: Heat**
4. Arrangement of numbers central quantum physics, machine learning – **Ans: Matrix**
5. 1958 Alfred Hitchcock film based on an extreme fear of heights – **Ans: Vertigo**

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For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

A final surge

Lula is the resistance to U.S. imperial ambitions in South America

At one point, it seemed almost impossible for Brazil's 80-year-old President, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, to turn the tide after finishing second to Flávio Bolsonaro in the first round of elections on October 4. In Brazil's history, no candidate who has finished second in the first round has gone on to win the presidential run-off. Most of the candidates who dropped out after the first round were from the right. Flávio's Liberal Party cemented its position in both houses of Congress, while right-wing candidates won several provincial elections. But Lula, a former trade unionist and organiser, who lost a finger in an accident as a teenager, was not ready to give up. Lula and his Workers' Party identified campaign weaknesses, shifted their attention to economic issues, promised growth and welfare, and persuaded more voters to turn out for Sunday's run-off. Lula won 51.7% of the vote against Flávio's 48.2%, a greater lead than his victory against Jair Bolsonaro, Flavio's father, four years ago. Over the weeks, Lula turned the right-wing's gains in the first round against it, highlighting the threats that a Bolsonaro victory could pose to democracy and civil rights. Flávio's campaign pledge to free his father – he is serving a 27-year prison sentence for attempting to overturn Lula's 2022 victory, and impeach Supreme Court judges – only heightened the concerns of voters outside the right wing, who rallied behind a familiar face.

Lula unleashed a social media campaign to mobilise younger voters. A WhatsApp channel called 'Lula's Army' with 11 million followers spread his message of continuity. He also announced plans to expand a cash payout scheme for the poor, a new debt relief package and entrepreneur-friendly measures. In the northeast, the Workers' Party's stronghold, he gained nearly three million votes and made considerable gains in the working-class neighbourhoods of big cities, including São Paulo. A relatively stable economic record, marked by growth and falling unemployment over the past three and a half years, also lent credibility to Lula's appeal. His victory bucks the recent trend in South America, where Washington-aligned right-wing and conservative forces have gained ground. While Lula offers predictable stability and social and economic inclusiveness, he could also be, as the President of South America's largest economy, a voice of resistance to Donald Trump's imperial ambitions. At the same time, Lula will have to work with a right-wing-controlled Congress to advance his agenda. He should seek to build legislative consensus while focusing on addressing the economic challenges of Brazil, which remains one of the most unequal major world economies.

Dubious retreat

The National Medical Commission must not be seen as lax on regulation

The National Medical Commission (NMC) has denotified and withdrawn its 2023 Maintenance of Standards of Medical Education Regulations (MSMER), diminishing the framework of penalties *vis-à-vis* educational standards and infrastructure at medical colleges. The move is noteworthy as the MSMER provided for fines of up to ₹5 lakh on faculty members and administrators for submitting false information. Fortunately, the Medical Assessment and Rating Board (MARB) retains the power to fine errant institutions up to ₹1 crore under the 2023 Establishment of Medical Institutions, Assessment and Rating Regulations. MSMER was lauded for its intention to crack down on the deep-seated corruption and malpractice in medical colleges, particularly over 'ghost faculty' and 'ghost patients'. The NMC's justification is that MSMER also introduced a parallel mechanism allowing undergraduate and postgraduate boards to evaluate institutions, stepping on the MARB's toes. However, why the NMC scrapped MSMER wholesale is unclear. The 2023 Postgraduate Medical Education Regulations remain in force and include a provision to fine individual faculty members at postgraduate medical colleges. Non-compliance among medical colleges is not uncommon and seldom nipped in the bud, even as the number of medical seats swells while the transparency of the medical education system has not improved.

Notwithstanding the provision to fine individuals at postgraduate centres, the MARB and the NMC can only penalise institutions, which is harder and risks creating a perverse incentive to accommodate rather than punish, and could mitigate the fear that keeps administrators honest. MSMER also specified timelines to appeal penalties. Although the MARB regulations retain the appeal processes, their 15-day deadline could conflict with the 60-day period under the NMC Act, potentially creating legal disputes that delay penal action. There is also a telling incident. As part of a proceeding under the RTI Act, the Central Information Commission revealed last year that the NMC had stated in 2024 that MARB had neither formally assessed nor rated medical colleges and that its standard forms need not be made public. In a revised reply in October 2025, it said the responding NMC officer's records did not include any of the corresponding reports. However, the 2023 MARB regulations require the Board to publish its latest annual assessment results. If the NMC withdrew MSMER because the powers thereunder also exist elsewhere, the public deserves to know whether the powers are also being exercised and whether the outcomes are as publicly accessible as intended. Unless the NMC has satisfactory answers for all these lacunae, the withdrawal will appear less like simplification and more like regulatory relaxation.

Beyond Kudankulam's fence, a cybersecurity challenge



Khyati Singh

Research Analyst, Centre for North America and Strategic Technologies, MP-IDSA and the author of 'Cyber Leviathan: Digital Strategies in International Relations'

The data breach involving files related to the Kudankulam nuclear power project in Tamil Nadu, reported on July 15, 2026, indicates that India's cybersecurity policy for critical infrastructure is behind the perimeter that now extends well beyond the actual sensitive facility.

The most consequential breach may never touch the facility at all. It could occur in a rented server in a commercial data centre or even within a contractor's network which has documents that the contractor is entitled to possess. That, in essence, is what appears to have happened in the case of Kudankulam. And that is why the incident deserves more attention than the reassurances that followed would suggest.

The perimeter beyond the plant

In mid-July, the group World Leaks began posting sections of an alleged leak of nearly 19,000 files totalling 14.3 GB relating to Kudankulam on its dark web portal. As reported by Reuters, the material spans the years 2016 to about 2025. It includes engineering drawings, supplier information, inspection records, meeting minutes, and insurance documents. The breach was confirmed by Reliance Infrastructure – it won the engineering, procurement, and construction contract for Kudankulam Units 3 and 4 – and added that the data had been stored on a server by its third-party data centre Yotta. It also said that the government had been notified. Yotta confirmed ransomware activity on its site on May 29, and said that the activity has been contained. By June the attackers were claiming the data and demanding a ransom. The Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL) said that the information was only on documents relating to non-nuclear infrastructure, and unrelated to systems supporting nuclear safety.

In all this, caveats are necessary. A ransomware group's claims are not evidence as such groups routinely inflate what they hold. Nothing in the public domain indicates that the reactors or control and safety systems, isolated from the Internet by design, were accessed. The NPCIL's clarification should be taken seriously.

The pertinent question is not whether the "reactor was hacked" – it was not – but how much operationally relevant information about India's most sensitive facilities exists beyond the facilities themselves. These include what is held by contractors, subcontractors, service providers, and their employees, a few of whom fall within the reach of India's regulatory framework.

This is not the first time that Kudankulam has featured in such a discussion. In 2019, the Dtrack malware, which cybersecurity researchers associate with North Korea's Lazarus Group, was found on a computer connected to the plant's Internet-facing administrative network. The NPCIL initially dismissed the reports but confirmed the infection, while emphasising that the critical internal network had been isolated and unaffected. The two are not technically connected, but there is a link. In both instances, the core held and the exposure was at the periphery. First, it was an administrative network; now, it was a contractor's server in a commercial data centre. Seven years later, the question is whether the lesson of 2019 was ever taken seriously – that security risks extend beyond critical facilities and whether there has been a systematic approach to securing the ecosystem around critical infrastructure. The latest incident suggests that it was not.

The Kudankulam breach highlights vulnerabilities beyond a nuclear plant's physical boundaries

A cyber blind spot

These ecosystems are large and growing. A modern nuclear plant, electricity grid, defence production facility or telecommunications system cannot be built or operated as a single organisation. Public utilities sit alongside private engineering and construction firms, equipment and software suppliers, cloud and data centre providers, insurers, certification agencies and layers of subcontractors, many of whom are foreign technology partners. Each of them may legitimately hold sensitive data, such as drawings, purchase order forms, reports, personal data, credentials and schedules. But this information is not necessarily protected by the security measures in place at the main facility, such as network segmentation, air-gapped control systems and physical security. This creates a cybersecurity risk across the supply chain. In other words, an organisation's security depends not only on its own safeguards but also on those of every other entity that has access to its data.

A sophisticated attacker can use this information to identify contractors, find potential targets for phishing attacks and determine which subcontractor offers the easiest route into the system. As Nickolas Roth of the Nuclear Threat Initiative has noted, such documents may also reveal how systems can be accessed. The larger concern is that strategic information can pose a security risk even if it does not provide direct access to operational systems. Any serious assessment must therefore examine not just what information was taken but also how it could be misused in the future.

India faces a gap in cybersecurity governance. It is not that institutions or rules are absent. The Indian Computer Emergency Response Team, CERT-In, is the national agency responsible for responding to cybersecurity incidents, and its 2022 directions made prompt reporting of such incidents mandatory. The National Critical Information Infrastructure Protection Centre (NCIIPC), established under Section 70A of the Information Technology Act, is responsible for protecting critical information infrastructure.

However, India's cybersecurity rules do not necessarily ensure uniform protection for sensitive information shared across contractors, subcontractors and data centres. Although existing regulations cover several categories of service providers, questions remain about the adequacy of security standards, oversight and accountability across the supply chain. In law, a "protected system" belongs to an infrastructure, and the obligations fall on its operator. Once project information is shared with a contractor, and then with a subcontractor or a data centre, its protection depends largely on contractual arrangements. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act does not generally cover engineering drawings and other technical information that do not contain personal data.

This creates a problem of accountability. The operator can truthfully say that its systems were not breached, the contractor can blame its hosting provider, and the host to the malware it had. All these claims may be true, yet sensitive documents may still end up on the dark web. The key question raised by the Kudankulam incident is who is responsible for protecting critical infrastructure information once it leaves the operator's control.

Expansion and risks

India is expanding the Kudankulam plant to a capacity of 6,000 MW, developing smart grids and digital public infrastructure, opening up the defence and space sectors to private companies under Atmanirbhar Bharat, and moving government data and services to commercial cloud platforms. Each of these steps makes strategic sense. But they also mean that more private companies will have access to sensitive information, increasing the risk of cyberattacks and creating more ways for attackers to gain access. A cybersecurity policy designed for a system in which the government builds and controls everything is no longer adequate for one that depends on private contractors, subcontractors and commercial infrastructure.

What are the steps to be taken? First, security obligations must follow the data, not the organisation. Any contractor, subcontractor, or cloud provider handling critical infrastructure data must be bound to defined standards, with liability and audit requirements in the procurement contract. Second, India needs real data classification so that a contractor constructing a conventional facility holds only the data that is needed and only for as long as it is needed. Third, annual compliance certificates should give way to third-party risk assessment, including red-team exercises that test the vendor ecosystem and not merely an operator's perimeter. Fourth, there should be zero-trust. The assumption should be that no network is safe. Every access point should be verified. This should be the policy for projects of national importance. Finally, CERT-In, the NCIIPC, sectoral regulators, and operators should converge on a single national framework for critical-infrastructure supply-chain security – one that assigns responsibility before a breach rather than after. Whether that comes through new legislation or a creative reading of the IT Act can wait.

In the digital era, critical infrastructure is not a building surrounded behind a fence; it is a layered system with many access points, many of them are outside the operator's control. India would be best served by ensuring that every organisation holding the reactor's secrets held to the same standard as those secrets deserve.

A ready solution to tackle anaemia



Marthi Venkatesh Mannar

Former Senior Advisor, Tata Trusts



Rajiv Tandon

Executive Director, The Health Continuum, Adjunct Professor of Public Health Practice at the Public Health Foundation of India, Indian Institutes of Public Health

Despite significant economic progress and sustained public health efforts, anaemia – driven significantly by iron deficiency – continues to be one of India's most pressing public health challenges. Affecting over half of Indian women and almost three-fourths of children, anaemia contributes to maternal mortality, an intergenerational cycle of malnutrition, impaired cognitive development, reduced productivity and substantial economic losses. The Government of India's 7X7X7 Anaemia Mukt Bharat (AMB) strategy, which was launched recently, rightly recognises the multifactorial nature of anaemia through a comprehensive approach spanning prevention, screening, treatment, dietary diversification and behaviour change. Yet, one proven preventive intervention remains significantly underutilised.

The promise of fortification

That intervention is Double Fortified Salt (DFS) – salt fortified with both iodine and iron. Salt offers an unparalleled opportunity to address iron deficiency. Consumed daily by virtually every household across India, in predictable quantities regardless of income or geography, it is uniquely suited to deliver a preventive nutrition intervention at population scale. DFS also addresses one of the fundamental challenges of anaemia control – sustained compliance.

Delivering iron through an everyday food complements interventions such as iron supplementation and dietary diversification, whose effectiveness depends on regular adherence. India already has one of the world's most successful public health platforms in Universal Salt Iodisation, with around 95% of households consuming iodised salt. Building on this existing infrastructure, DFS is already distributed to an estimated 76 million people across four States through government safety-net programmes. Global and Indian evidence strongly support DFS. A global review has shown that DFS can reduce anaemia by up to 21%. Randomised controlled trials in Bengaluru, Darjeeling, and Punjab, along with large-scale implementation in Uttar Pradesh, have shown improvements in iron status and confirmed that, when manufactured to validated specifications, DFS is acceptable to consumers, reduces iron deficiency, and is highly cost-effective. A DFS standard has been issued by the Government of India's Food Safety and Standards Authority (FSSAI), and the Government of India actually mandates DFS' inclusion in the national school feeding programme (PM POSHAN and the national early childhood development programme- Integrated Child Development Scheme, or ICDS).

Double fortified salt offers a scalable solution to one of India's most pressing public health challenges

At an estimated cost of ₹14-₹20 per person annually, DFS represents one of the most affordable population-level nutrition interventions available, with a benefit-cost ratio of 4.2:1 for national DFS introduction, primarily driven by improved health outcomes and subsequent increases in labour productivity. India also possesses the manufacturing capacity to produce high-quality DFS at scale. Established fortification technologies, centralised salt production and existing laboratory infrastructure make quality assurance and regulatory monitoring simpler than for many other fortified foods.

What the barriers are

What has limited DFS from wider adoption? The barriers are now primarily institutional rather than technical. The next imperative is to accelerate its nationwide adoption and ensure last-mile access, particularly the Public Distribution System apart from social safety-net programmes, across all States through a central flagship scheme. Although DFS is recommended under PM POSHAN and ICDS, its integration into the largest safety net programme i.e., the Public Distribution System (PDS) – which reaches around 800 million beneficiaries – remains uneven because implementation depends largely on State governments. Greater policy commitment, dedicated financing, stronger quality assurance, wider commercial availability and consumer awareness are now needed to accelerate nationwide scale-up. These are implementation challenges – not technological ones – and are well within India's capacity to address.

Like all public health nutrition interventions, DFS should be implemented within a robust regulatory framework. It should complement existing strategies under Anaemia Mukt Bharat, align with India's sodium reduction goals, and continue to be accompanied by screening for haemoglobinopathies such as thalassaemia and sickle cell disease. These safeguards are well recognised through experience of rice fortification programme and can be readily integrated into implementation and monitoring systems.

The launch of the revised AMB strategy provides renewed momentum to strengthen the preventive pillar of India's anaemia response and advance the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Potential to be a global model

India has already shown the world how science, policy, public systems, and public awareness can transform nutrition through Universal Salt Iodisation. By scaling DFS nationally, India can not only accelerate progress towards Anaemia Mukt Bharat but also contribute to global efforts to reduce iron deficiency by demonstrating an affordable, scalable model for other low- and middle-income countries.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Remarkable comeback

The re-election of Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva as Brazil's President has brought relief to many in Brazil and around the world, ending uncertainty over the country's political future. The high-voltage election campaign had all the ingredients of a Hollywood cliffhanger which would be remembered as one of the most bitterly contested elections ever in the history of the nation in recent times. It is obvious that President-elect Lula's campaign to continue pro-people policies resonated well with the electorate. On his part, the Opposition candidate should accept his defeat with dignity and grace.

B. Suresh Kumar,
Coimbatore

At a time when several Latin American countries are witnessing the growing influence of right-wing political forces, Brazil's political choices have reignited the debate over democracy, social justice and inclusive governance.

M. Jeyaram,
Sholavandan, Tamil Nadu

Back on the track

The detailed reports on the Indian Turf Invitation Cup, held at the Mysore Race Club, have sparked interest even among readers like me who do not usually follow equestrian sports (Sports page). While the Tamil Nadu government deserves appreciation for ending horse racing, enthusiasts could perhaps be allowed to engage in inter-venue betting on a limited scale.

K. Chellappan,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

A leadership deficit in the military



Ajai Shukla

Editor, Gambit Analytics LLP and Retired Colonel

Last July, at a seminar in New Delhi on *atmanirbharta*, the then maintenance chief of the Indian Air Force (IAF), Air Marshal Sanjiv Ghuratia, delivered an address that contained, as one person in the audience reported "more Sanskrit than English or Hindi". Another attendee wondered who Mr. Ghuratia was speaking to; the entrepreneurs and engineers in the audience or to the Sangh Parivar members who needed a demonstration of his Hindu credentials.

For generals, admirals or air marshals looking for post-retirement employment, Hindutva pays. Last month, Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra, who masterminded Operation Sindoor as the Western Air Command chief, was rewarded with the plum job of running the Ram Janmbhoomi temple. Nothing an IAF pilot learns during his career equips him for such a delicate job in such a volatile environment.

This Hindutva-isation of the military is not new. On May 13, 2025 at a crucial IAF media briefing on Operation Sindoor, the IAF's operations chief, Air Marshall A.K. Bharti, invoked the Ramayan. His briefing commenced with militaristic Hindutva overtones, the Shiva Tandava Stotram delivered in rock concert style. Military audiences in New Delhi are no longer surprised when government-affiliated speakers pepper their speeches with Sanskrit *shlokas*. For no apparent reason, the IAF appears to be more Sanskrit-ised than the other two services. One wag at a recent seminar commented, "it might be because they serve closer to God." However, not every soldier is comfortable with overt displays of Hindutva. One can detect the growing disillusionment of juniors with seniors who are taking the Hindutva route to the top.

Lions and donkeys

After the mass slaughter of World War I, a disillusioned British citizenry popularised the phrase "lions led by donkeys" to describe their military's performance. This encapsulated their resentment against incompetent generals who let down British soldiers by committing units into attacks that were certain to fail.

This is not yet the case with the Indian military, which, as an institution, continues to enjoy the respect of the public. However on-going controversies have exacerbated murmurs among junior officers that the brass looks out only for themselves. On the other hand, generals express disappointment over the "poor quality" of young officers. There is a growing disconnect between the ends of the rank pyramid; between the lions and the donkeys.

Of the greatest concern is the growing "zero error syndrome" amongst senior Indian commanders. As was seen when the Chinese intruded into Ladakh in 2020, Indian commanders shrank from immediate offensive action. Instead, of creating deterrence by displaying aggression and risk-taking ability, the modern Indian general opts to defend vulnerabilities, underscoring weakness that is echoed by commanders down the line. It is not that operational boldness has blighted many careers. In the instances where Indian generals displayed conspicuous aggression against China – as in Nathu La in 1967, Sumdorong Chu in 1986, Doklam in 2017 and in the occupation of the Kailash Range in Ladakh in 2020-21 – the commanders in charge were praised, not castigated.

Contemporary conflict presents numerous examples of weaker forces stalemating, and even defeating stronger ones. Ukraine battles on against Russia, while Iran is standing up to the U.S. and Israel. The intangibles that boost their power are a mix of psychological factors. Soldiers thrive on emotional strength, belief in one's own moral superiority, seeing justice in one's own cause, fairness in processes and methods, and the conviction that soldierly skills will prevail over sycophancy. These moral factors are essential to national power.

Even in these communally polarised times, India's military brass has the leeway to disagree with elected governments. To uphold their convictions, they should be ready to pay the price. No better example exists than the tussle between U.S. President Harry Truman and his commander in Korea, General Douglas MacArthur. Truman wanted a "limited war", to avoid triggering a massive Soviet or Chinese intervention. MacArthur wanted an aggressive expansion of the war into China. Truman dismissed MacArthur in 1951, citing that elected leaders, and not military generals, decide foreign policy. MacArthur returned from Korea, an American hero.

There is something gravely flawed with our leadership training. Many young officers start out as gallant captains and majors. Why then, when they become generals, admirals and air marshals do so many fail to seize the moment?

Of the greatest concern is the growing 'zero error syndrome' amongst senior Indian commanders

Why inclusion is key to the RTE Act



Mansi Middha

Lead at Indus Action



Apoorva Bhatia

Consultant, Indus Action

Every morning, 10-year-old Ria walks from her working-class Delhi neighbourhood to a premium private school with quiet pride. As her friends head to a government school, Ria continues her longer walk, feeling lucky to have won a free seat under the Right to Education (RTE) Act quota.

Yet, inside the school gates, a transformation occurs. Her stride becomes subdued, and she quietly slips into a back-row seat. For the rest of the day, she and a fellow quota student operate in survival mode: meticulously copying notes while avoiding the teacher's gaze. After receiving a C-minus on a math assignment and a harsh reprimand from her teacher, she carries the disappointment for days. Her immense effort remains unseen, and her teachers label her as 'struggling to meet grade expectations'.

Across the city, Sahil, admitted to another private school through the same provision, experiences a strikingly different day. His father works as an industrial labourer and his mother takes on local domestic work. Yet his school feels inviting. His engagement has attracted teachers and peers, and his sincerity is reflected in his grades, participation in sports and confidence on the stage.

Ria and Sahil (names changed to protect identities) secured free seats via Section 12(1)(c) of the RTE Act, 2009 to drive social cohesion. The provision provides access to 50 lakh disadvantaged students to private schools nationwide via a mandatory 25% classroom quota. However, mere entry alone does not guarantee social integration. While many face low grades and class-based alienation, success stories such as Sahil's prove that intentional school practices can overcome superficial integration.

Lacking an institutional blueprint for diverse classrooms, private schools must actively innovate. A study of nine mid-to-high-cost Delhi private schools revealed that inclusion is rarely black-and-white; structural nourishment plays out differently for each child, but success stories consistently emerge where inclusion is a core institutional value.

In typical classrooms, RTE students often drift to the periphery, isolated by organic social segregation and low participation in collaborative tasks. Burdened and undertrained teachers frequently view them through a deficit lens, as demanding 'more effort', while ignoring their emotional distress.

Architecture of access

Conversely, schools with conscious structural intent cultivate an 'invisible inclusion'. In Sahil's school, the day begins with an empathy-driven learning circle where vulnerability is shared safely. Assigned mixed seating and a 'zero period' let peers collaborate on unfinished homework. Lessons rely on collaborative learning with ample scope for student-led discussions with the teacher ensuring that all students participate. While addressing an area problem, the math teacher encouraged an RTE student to share about his family's paddy fields, which validated his lived experience. By noon, teachers co-plan support strategies, preparing for monthly open houses where parents can also exchange insights. Authentic inclusion does not require massive additional material or financial resources. It depends on consistent practices that promote equal participation, recognise diverse lived experiences, and build meaningful connections among students, teachers and families.

Under Section 12(1)(c), the responsibility of fostering an inclusive classroom falls entirely on schools and teachers. Navigating this structural support forces educators to rely solely on personal motivation. In a heavily burdened system, inclusion risks becoming an afterthought. An essential tenet of educational development is that what gets measured gets valued. Inclusion remains deeply undervalued because India lacks the metrics to track it. Unlike academic performance, it never appears on a report card, yet it shapes a student's entire journey. State governments and parent networks must collaborate to monitor benchmarks.

Schools must institutionalise inclusive values through collaborative learning, rotated leadership, dignified and equitable participation of RTE students, and by supporting teachers with specialised resources. For governments, the mandate is to create enabling conditions through financial reimbursements, public recognition of inclusive schools, and cross-state feedback loops.

To ensure that every Ria and Sahil can thrive, inclusion must be pursued with the same deliberate rigour, tracking, and daily practice that we dedicate to academic outcomes.

An essential tenet of educational development is that what gets measured gets valued. Inclusion remains deeply undervalued because India lacks the metrics to track it.

Fewer athletes, more medals: India's best Para games yet

India fielded 168 athletes during the Aichi-Nagoya Para Games, barely half of Hangzhou's 309, yet returned with a record 114 medals

DATA POINT

Kapil Gupta

India finished the Asian Para Games in Aichi-Nagoya with a record 114 medals – 30 gold, 35 silver and 49 bronze – securing the fourth place, its best-ever finish. The tally surpassed its revised total of 108 medals at the 2022 Hangzhou Games, down from 111 after three medals were withdrawn over doping violations. The achievement is all the more striking given that India sent a much smaller contingent this time.

India fielded 168 athletes across 11 sports at the 2026 Asian Para Games, compared with 309 athletes across 17 sports in Hangzhou in 2022. With the Asian Paralympic Committee offering limited athlete quotas across sports, the removal of chess and canoeing from the programme, and India's decision not to field teams in taekwondo and rowing, the contingent was definitely smaller than last time. The para athletics contingent, the country's biggest source of medals, also fell from 123 athletes in Hangzhou to 62. With fewer athletes and fewer sporting opportunities, winning even 100 medals appeared uncertain before the Games.

India's medal tally has increased at every edition of the Asian Para Games since its debut in Guangzhou in 2010 **(Chart 1)**. It rose from 14 medals that year to 33 in 2014, 72 in 2018, 108 in Hangzhou in 2022 and 114 in Aichi-Nagoya in 2026, an eightfold increase over 16 years. Gold medals have followed a similar trajectory, rising from one in 2010 to three in 2014, 15 in 2018, 27 in 2022 and 30 in 2026.The medal-table rank for India has climbed from 15th to ninth, fifth and fourth.

More with less

The sharper story is with respect to medals per athlete **(Chart 2)**. From 2014 to 2022, India won 35 to 38 medals for every 100 athletes it sent. In Aichi-Nagoya, the figure nearly doubled to 68. In Hangzhou, it was about three athletes for every medal, while this one needed fewer than one and a half. Gold followed the same path, from 8.7 per 100 athletes to 18.

Part of the gap reflects what was missing. India won 14 medals in Hangzhou in chess, canoeing, rowing and taekwondo. Without them, Hangzhou's comparable tally is 95, so 114 is about a fifth more in the sports India contested at both Games.

Where the medals come from

Para athletics remains the engine **(Table 1)**. It brought 17 of India's 33 medals in 2014, 36 of 72 in 2018 and 53 in Hangzhou. This time, 62 athletes won 65 medals, 22 of them gold: more medals than athletes. Swimming rose from one medal to 11 and table tennis from two to seven. Badminton slipped from 21 to 16, while archery and shooting, with no medals in 2014, won five golds between them.

The presence of women athletes has grown unevenly **(Chart 3)**. They made up 15% of India's squad in 2010, a quarter in 2018 and 37% in Hangzhou, before slipping to a third this time, 56 of 167. In Jakarta, women won 46 medals per 100 athletes, against 35 for men; in Hangzhou, 29 against 35. In Aichi-Nagoya, the gap nearly closed: women won 36 medals, 10 of them gold, or 64 per 100 athletes, against 66 for men.

Medal tables reflect the programme as much as the athletes. Quotas, events and rivals change from one edition to the next, and China remains far ahead of everyone. A smaller squad also means fewer athletes gaining international experience.

Still, the direction is clear. With the Los Angeles Paralympics two years away, the Aichi-Nagoya numbers suggest that Indian para sport is no longer growing by sending more athletes, but by winning more with those it sends.

Historic medal run

The data for the charts were sourced from Olympics.com and Wikipedia's "India at the Asian Para Games" pages

Kapil Gupta is an Assistant Professor in Decision Sciences and Operations Management area at the Indian Institute of Management, Kozhikode



Medal winners: India's para lifters Ashok Kumar Malik, Kasturi Rajamani and others being greeted upon their arrival at IGI Airport following the 2026 Asian Para Games, in New Delhi on Sunday

CHART 1: India's medal tally at each Asian Para Games, with medal-table rank

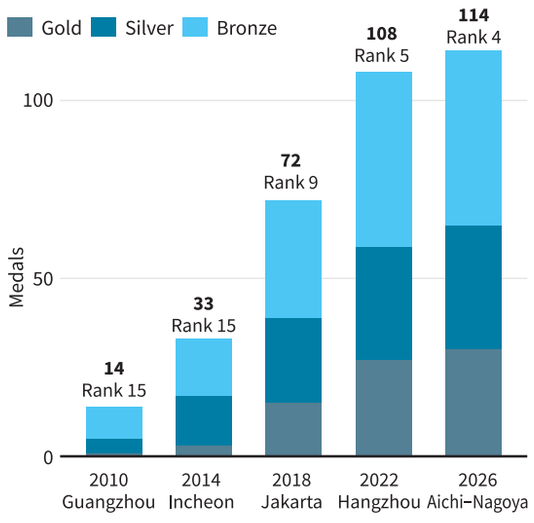
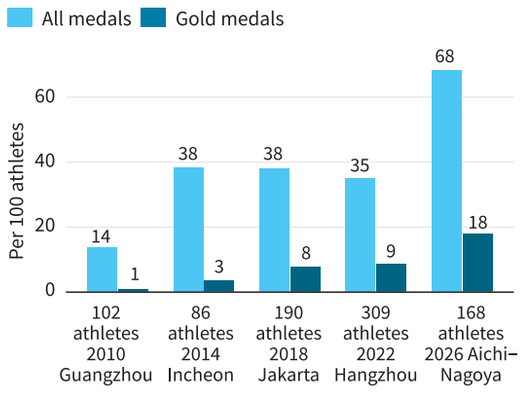


TABLE 1: Sport-wise medals India won in Asian Para Games

Sport	2010	2014	2018	2022	2026
Athletics	7 (1)	17 (2)	36 (7)	53 (16)	65 (22)
Badminton	1 (0)	6 (1)	9 (3)	21 (4)	16 (3)
Swimming	—	7 (0)	8 (1)	1 (0)	11 (0)
Table tennis	—	—	1 (0)	2 (0)	7 (0)
Archery	—	—	1 (1)	7 (2)	6 (3)
Shooting	—	—	3 (1)	6 (2)	5 (2)
Powerlifting	1 (0)	1 (0)	4 (0)	3 (0)	2 (0)
Judo	—	2 (0)	—	2 (0)	2 (0)
Sports not contested in 2026*	5 (0)	—	10 (2)	13 (3)	—
Total	**14 (1)**	**33 (3)**	**72 (15)**	**108 (27)**	**114 (30)**

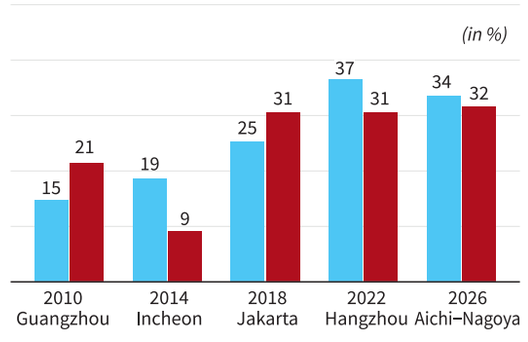
*Note: Medals won, with gold medals in brackets. '—' means no medal. *Wheelchair fencing (2010), cycling (2018), chess (2018, 2022), canoe, rowing and taekwondo (2022)*

CHART 2: Medals won for every 100 athletes sent



Note: Medals per 100 athletes = medals ÷ athletes who competed × 100. Hangzhou 2022 figures are the revised totals (108 medals, 27 gold; 309 athletes)

CHART 3: Women's share of India's squad and medals



The share of medals won by women have increased. In Aichi-Nagoya, the gap nearly closed: women won 36 medals, 10 of them gold, or 64 per 100 athletes, against 66 for men

Note: Mixed-event medals are counted in the total but not as women's medals

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 27, 1976

Foreign bank accounts: 400 cases detected

Madras, October 26: A huge basket of foreign currencies and securities, equivalent to about Rs 30 lakhs, held by Indians in banks abroad have been detected by the Central authorities.

Nuclear scientists, engineers, and economists of Karnataka, doctors of Calcutta and East African repatriates in Bombay, account for a big chunk of the over 400 cases that have come to light. The drive launched early this year, gained momentum in recent months and paid rich dividends in August and September, during which a majority of these cases were discovered.

Quite a few of the cases, officials say are from Karnataka and the persons involved belong to various professions, who managed to secure employment in West European countries. In West Asia also, the State has contributed a bulk of semi-skilled craftsmen, like tailors and carpenters.

Of late, there has been a big spurt in the number of Indians going abroad on assignments from the United Nations and other international agencies, or seeking lucrative positions in West Asian and West European countries.

As part of the crackdown on smuggling activity, the Central authorities started enquiries about the various persons who went for employment abroad and returned to India after the tenure of their duties outside but retained their foreign bank accounts. This type of foreign holdings is lapped by foreign exchange racketeers to finance smuggling into India.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 27, 1926

Kalimpong homes

London, October 26: Lord Ronaldshay presided at a meeting of farewell to Doctor Graham on the eve of his proceeding to India. He declared that Dr. Graham would not realise his ambitions in Kalimpong homes for Anglo Indian boys and girls until he was able to open the door to every child born in India with any European blood in its veins needing the help of homes.

The Maharaja of Burdwan paid a tribute to Dr. Graham's work and said that there were indications of Anglo-Indian determination to participate in the making of India.

The Maharaja of Burdwan later visited the lobby of the House of Commons where he met Col. F.S. Jackson.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of power stations hit by RSF drones in Sudan

5 Sudan's paramilitary Rapid Support Forces launched a coordinated drone attack on Monday, against five power stations, causing mass power outages across the country's east, a government official told *AFP*. The drones hit two power stations each in the states of Al-Jazira and Gedaref, and one in White Nile state, "resulting in power outages across large parts of these states". AFP

Decline in India's green cover between 2001 and 2025

5.6 In percentage points. India saw a decline in green cover and a corresponding expansion of non-green landscapes by 5.6 percentage points between 2001 and 2025, which contributed to rising summer temperatures across the country, according to a new analysis. Non-green land increased from 63.05 per cent to 68.65 per cent during the same period. PTI

Worth of subsidies for household solar push launched by Thailand

1.5 in $ bn. Thailand offered subsidies worth up to $1.5 billion on Monday, to help households install solar panels, as it seeks to boost renewable energy. The government offered almost $1,500 towards installation costs for up to one million households, and promised low-interest loans and tax benefits for those fitting panels to their homes or land. AFP

Commanders from Sudan sanctioned by U.K. over wartime rape

15 Britain on Monday imposed sanctions on 15 military commanders, militia leaders and security officials from both sides of Sudan's conflict, accusing them of sexual violence, torture and attacks on civilians. Those targeted include commanders from the Rapid Support Forces and Sudanese Armed Forces, as well as leaders of armed groups allied to the army. REUTERS

Persons killed in lightning strikes since monsoon onset in T.N.

14 Tamil Nadu Revenue Minister K.A. Sengottaiyan said on Monday that 14 people have died due to lightning strikes since the onset of the Northeast monsoon, even as intensifying rains prompted authorities to bar tourist entry to major hill stations. He said families of the deceased have been given ₹4 lakh each as compensation. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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From climate targets to energy justice

India should reframe the climate issue as a set of national crises arising from unequal energy use, rather than as a global temperature goal driven by emissions; the global policy focus needs to shift from production to consumption patterns, as emerging countries are using much less energy to achieve comparable levels of well-being

EXPLAINER

Mukul Sanwal

The global trend towards electrification has been recognised by the climate process, and the policy challenge is that the shift will involve less commonality and greater differentiation.

This suggests shifting the discussion from the global impact of coal-based emissions to the role of electricity in national well-being. The shift will be away from reliance on global models to a review of national actions. Global emissions of carbon dioxide deal with the symptoms, not the root cause of the problem: national energy use.

The G7 should not be allowed to set the agenda, as the Paris Agreement did 10 years ago. Shifting the global policy focus from production to consumption patterns will require a reframing of the climate process. Real collaboration will only come with a new conceptual framework that treats the global crisis as a collection of national inactions.



The floating solar panels at Periyakulam (Ukkadam Big Tank) in Coimbatore. FILE PHOTO

The limits of global 'consensus'

Academics in the West, acting as "epistemic communities", set up the framework of climate policy and law. This framework comprises interlinked 'global values' that are universal, 'global goods' that are determined by global science, complex 'global models' based on global projections and 'global rules' arrived at through multilateral conference diplomacy in global organisations.

Official experts described complex issues as the best available knowledge to be universally accepted. They achieved this by using institutions of the United Nations as mechanisms to produce technical reports and frame policies, lending them legitimacy under the banner of international cooperation. International law was then used to enforce within countries the decisions driven by global 'consensus'.

In the case of climate change, the gap between the evolving science of global ecological limits and the growing energy needs of urbanising countries seeking comparable levels of well-being was resolved through arm-twisting in an unequal world. There was no commitment to transfer financial resources as 'means of implementation'.

Western diplomats converted a political claim in a vaguely worded treaty into workshops and meetings, where the Global South gained nothing but empty resolutions. Technology transfer has been treated as a 'scientific' issue rather than an 'implementation' issue.

The lesson from 35 years of diplomatic negotiations as well as alternate models of growth to those of the West is the need to reframe climate policy.

First, in a major reversal the United States is echoing reservations of the Global South. The Executive Order "Putting America First in International Environmental Agreements", January 20, 2025, underlines that the U.S. shall "henceforth prioritise economic efficiency, the promotion of American prosperity, consumer choice, and fiscal restraint in all foreign engagements that concern energy policy".

Second, as energy use in the Global South grows to achieve comparable levels of well-being, 'carbonising' will precede 'decarbonising'. This is only partly recognised in the UN's new call for stabilisation, rather than reduction, of emissions. Third, the amount of energy needed for human well-being has never been discussed. China has emerged as the world's second-largest economy and a major global manufacturing power, achieving levels of well-being comparable to those in the West with much lower energy use.

Fourth, China's nationally driven path to achieving stabilisation has been missed in UN Reports even though it provides an alternate to the approach of the West. U.S. emissions increased by 133 megatons in 2025. China's significant steps suggest that the technology aspect of the energy transition should look forward to electrification using renewable sources, rather than focus backwards on eliminating fossil fuels.

Fifth, China's and India's insight lies is limiting consumption as a percentage of GDP, replacing the internal combustion engine, and meeting new energy demand through solar, wind and hydropower. China's more rapid progress shows that because solar and wind power have become "cheaper" than coal and gas, they will not drive the energy transition by themselves. Renewable energy is decentralised, intermittent and has zero-marginal-cost energy, requiring a strategic decision by the state on how to transform the energy system.

China installed more wind turbines and solar panels in 2025 than all other nations combined, adding about ten times as much capacity as the U.S. As this trend is expected to continue, 50% of electricity generation could come from non-fossil-fuel sources by 2030. About 5.62 million new energy vehicles were registered in China during the first half of 2025.

Global trends

Climate policy should now by driven by practice, as a societal problem. First, emerging countries are using much less energy to achieve well-being in cities than the West did earlier, redefining lifestyles and ecological limits. Electrification is making the internal combustion engine redundant. Yet this technological trend in energy use is not captured in global emissions models used by the UN.

Second, in material use, the West's much smaller share of the global population, around one-fifth, is balanced by the sustainable development of the Rest. The demographic trend is now towards ageing. These societal trends are ignored in global models, and taken together with the West's continuing disproportionate use of energy, suggests that there is no global crisis, but rather a few national crises.

Third, given the increasing intensity and frequency of extreme events which affect the Global South, where insurance coverage is limited, continuing with token provision of climate finance by developed countries in negotiations needs to be reviewed. More practical measures include global early warning and regional technical cooperation in disaster relief.

The real question for India is how to build support for a new agenda centred on climate justice.

(Mukul Sanwal is a Former UN Diplomat and Policy Adviser UNFCCC.)

THE GIST

- Global emissions of carbon dioxide deal with the symptoms, not the root cause of the problem: national energy use
- As energy use in the Global South grows to achieve comparable levels of well-being, 'carbonising' will precede 'decarbonising'. This is only partly recognised in the UN's new call for stabilisation

What are the powers of Special Executive Magistrates?

Who appoints SEMs? Can they conduct criminal trials or convict people? Can they grant judicial custody?

Rizmi Lia M.

The story so far:

A Special Executive Magistrate (SEM) court in Delhi accepted the sureties and granted bail to Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) activists Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka last Wednesday.

Despite the Delhi Police seeking a three-day extension of custody, Assistant Commissioner of Police Ritu Raj, who presided over the proceedings, ordered their release. CJP activists had challenged the legality of their continued detention. The case has brought into focus the roles and powers of SEMs and their differences from Judicial Magistrates.

Who is Special Executive Magistrate?

State governments appoint SEMs for specific areas or purposes and give them the powers exercised by the Executive Magistrates under Section 15 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023.

While Executive Magistrates perform continued administrative and preventive functions, SEMs are appointed for a specified period, area or function, such as particular situations that require preventive action or maintenance of public order. Their powers also depend on the authority conferred upon them by the State government.

What is the function of SEMs?

The powers of SEMs are intended to allow authorities to intervene when there is a likelihood of disturbance, rather than responding after the offence has occurred. They maintain public order and prevent breaches of peace by performing preventive and administrative functions.

The Executive Magistrate can require a person who is likely to cause a breach of peace or disturb public tranquility, to show cause as to why they should not execute a bond to keep the peace. So, depending on the circumstances, they may be required to furnish a bond for a specified period. It is subject to the procedure established by law. This is dealt with under Section 126 of the BNSS.

Executive Magistrates can also issue urgent orders in case of nuisance or apprehended danger. It is likely to prevent, or tends to prevent, obstruction, or injury to any person lawfully employed, or danger to human life or safety or a disturbance of the public tranquillity, or a riot, or an affray.

Preventive arrest can be made by police officers when necessary to prevent the commission of a cognisable offence that cannot otherwise be prevented, according to Section 170 of the BNSS. This is a police power, not exclusively that of SEMs.

The police initiated a preventive proceeding against the CJP activists, alleging that they had breached peace bonds they had signed. The SEM extended their custody on October 19, citing concerns about public peace. Later on Wednesday, their sureties were accepted, and they were released on an undertaking that they would not call for any protest at Jantar Mantar while it remained a denotified protest site.

The proceedings before the SEM primarily concerned only the alleged violation of a signed peace bond and not the criminal cases registered over the October 13 Jantar Mantar incident.

What is a peace bond?

Section 126 of the BNSS allows an Executive Magistrate to require a person to execute a peace bond for up to one year to prevent breach of peace.

According to Section 135, the Magistrate conducts an inquiry into the information received. In certain circumstances, they can also order a person to provide security while the inquiry is pending and record the reasons in writing. In case of a breach of a peace bond, the Magistrate may order that the person be arrested or detained for the remaining period of the bond. This is dealt with under section 141(1)b.

In the present case, the SEM proceedings concern allegations that Mr. Das and Mr. Ranka breached their earlier peace bond through actions at the Jantar Mantar.

How are SEMs different from Judicial Magistrates?

Section 9 of the BNSS provides for the establishment of courts of Judicial magistrates of the first and second classes. For that, the State government determines the number and location of these courts. Presiding officers are also appointed by the High Court.

Judicial Magistrates form part of the judicial system and deal with criminal cases, including remand proceedings, bail applications and trials. They are independent and impose sentences permitted by law.

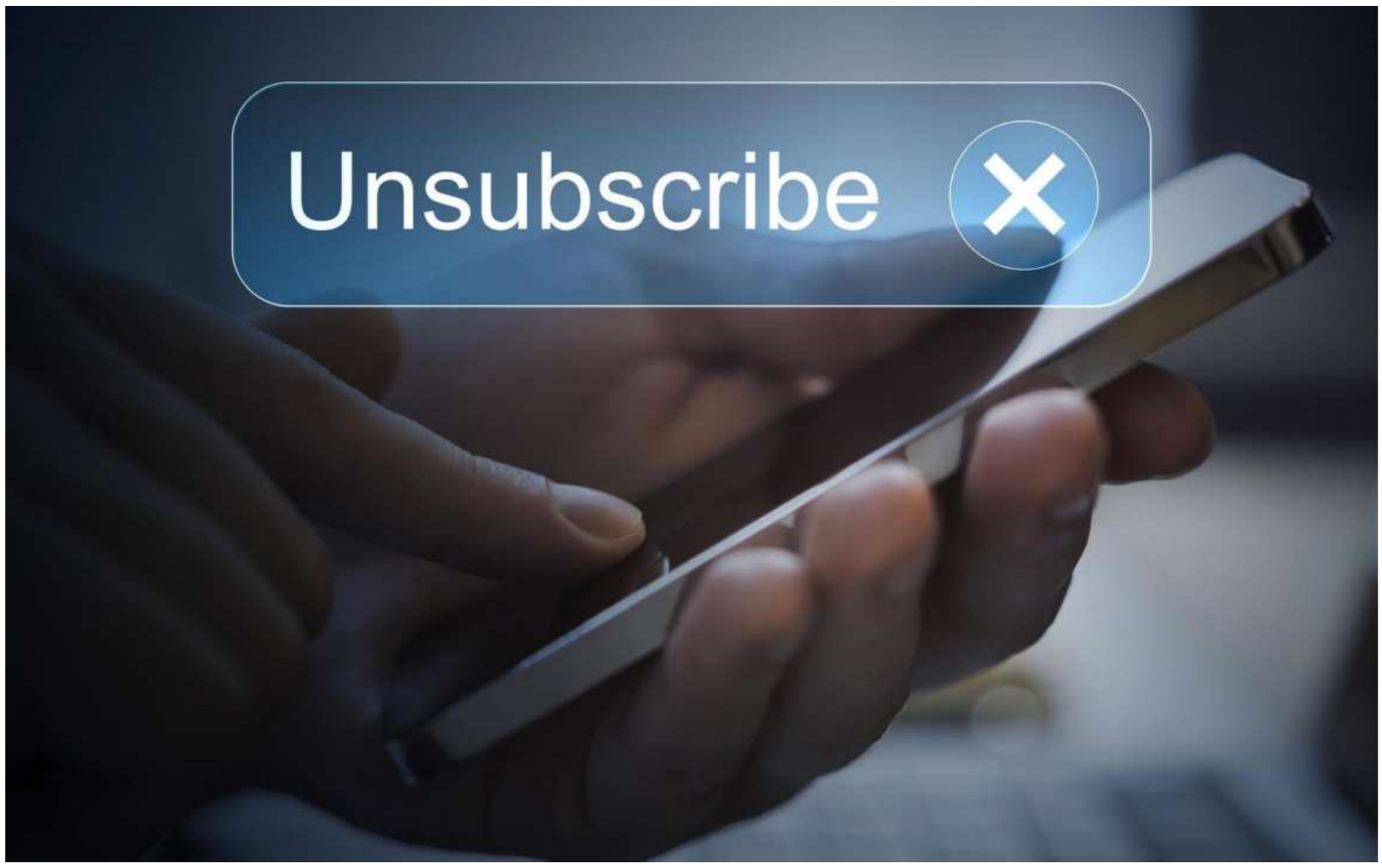
SEMs are limited to administrative functions and cannot conduct criminal trials or convict people through these proceedings. They are also authorised to release or grant police or judicial remand.

Can the actions of SEMs be reviewed by courts?

Yes, SEMs' actions are subject to judicial review and administrative oversight to ensure legality and the protection of the rights of citizens.

Their order can also be challenged before the appropriate court or authority depending on the nature of the order and remedy available.

CACHE



A costly hassle: Consumers such as time-pressed workers, minors, vulnerable adults, senior citizens, and non-literate customers face extra hurdles when struggling to offload unwanted subscriptions. GETTY IMAGES

What is the significance of New York City's 'Click to Cancel' rule?

The 'Click to Cancel' rule aims to enable residents to cancel any subscription just as quickly as they can sign up — ideally with a single click; it covers subscriptions for goods or services that meet the definitions of 'automatic renewal' or 'continuous service offer'

Sahana Venugopal

On October 1, New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani announced the enforcement of the city's 'Click to Cancel' rule that essentially lets residents cancel any subscription just as quickly as they can sign up – ideally with a single click.

"No one should need 45 minutes of hold music to stop paying for something they never wanted," said Mr. Mamdani. "If a company can take your money with one click, you should be able to get your money back with one click."

What is the need for a 'Click to Cancel' rule?

It can feel effortless to sign up online for a gym membership, a grocery subscription, a mobile phone plan, or a magazine delivery. When one wants to cancel the same service, however, the process is often so convoluted and time-consuming that customers end up keeping a subscription that they would prefer to eliminate.

This unethical retention is commonly achieved through digital "dark patterns" that make it hard for customers to act in their own best interests. For example, subscription cancellation or account deletion buttons might be obscured by multiple menus and sub-menus designed to confuse users. Or, they may require the user to "click" through pages and pages of text, wasting their time and making them likely to give up.

Sometimes, customers may not even know that they are locked into a subscription, as a free trial is converted into a paid commitment without clearly seeking consent.

Alternatively, many merchants who allow easy online subscriptions, arbitrarily require buyers to send personalised emails or letters, spend time on the phone, or even visit the business in person just to end their subscription.

This lack of parity ends up keeping reluctant customers locked into bad services.

Consumers such as time-pressed workers, minors, vulnerable adults, senior citizens, and non-literate customers face extra hurdles when struggling to offload unwanted subscriptions. In extreme cases, customers may even have to cancel their credit cards and get new ones in order to end a subscription.

The problem is so pervasive that media outlets have reported that people are resorting to AI agents – such as Meta's Muse – in order to identify and get rid of unnecessary subscriptions on their behalf.

'Click to Cancel' rules would force sellers to make cancellation processes easier, quicker, transparent, fairer, and customer-friendly, so that buyers don't need to depend on external tools and services.

As per one estimate cited by the NYC Mayor's office, the 'Click to Cancel' rule could save New Yorkers up to $162.5 million per year.

Who is covered by the 'Click to Cancel' rule?

The rule gives the Department of Consumer and Worker Protection (DCWP) citywide authority for enforcement, adding on to the New York state's existing regulations that govern subscription terms. The 'Click to Cancel' rule covers subscriptions for any type of goods or services meeting the definitions of "automatic renewal" or "continuous service offer," with exceptions for government-linked businesses and several licensed financial institutions.

"A person making an automatic renewal or continuous service offer to a consumer must provide the consumer with the option to cancel at any time using a simple cancellation mechanism that is as easy to use as the mechanism that the consumer used to provide consent and that is through the same medium that the consumer used to provide consent," stated the 'Click to Cancel' rule.

For example, an internet-based sign-up process cannot require a call-based or in-person cancellation process. New York City residents can also file complaints in order to seek mediation, while companies could face civil penalties starting at $525 for violations.

Does India have a 'Click to Cancel' policy?

India has a bank-based regulation that is meant to protect customers from deceptive subscription practices. Even so, the reality is that many consumers are often manipulated by the merchants that they rely on for their daily needs.

Take the Reserve Bank of India's 'Digital Payments - E-mandate Framework' from this April. It directs an issuer (of a mandate/recurring transaction) to send a pre-transaction notification to the customer at least 24 hours prior to the actual charge/debit. The issuer must share the merchant's name, transaction amount, date/time of debit, reference number of the e-mandate, and the reason for the debit. A post-transaction notification to the customer is also required.

In other words, merchants cannot silently deduct funds from customers' accounts and hope that they don't notice. However, a lack of regulation targeting "dark patterns" creates avenues for Indian consumers to be exploited by merchants.

According to Datum Intelligence's Dark Patterns Consumer Perception Study dated June 2026, e-commerce platforms Nykaa, Myntra, Flipkart, and Amazon, as well as quick commerce platforms Big Basket, Zepto, Swiggy Instamart, and Blinkit did not offer pre-renewal reminders for free trial billing. The study further noted that cancellation required more than 4 steps on most of the listed platforms.

In essence, Indian shoppers are far from being able to click to cancel.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

President Iskander Mirza's imposition of martial law and his ousting by Ayub Khan marked Pakistan's first period of military rule. A quiz on the coup and its aftermath

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1
Who was Pakistan's Prime Minister when martial law was proclaimed in October 1958?

QUESTION 2
What did Mirza abrogate when he proclaimed martial law on October 7, 1958?

QUESTION 3
What system of indirect elections did Ayub Khan introduce in 1959 as the foundation of his political structure?

QUESTION 4
In which year did Ayub Khan relinquish the presidency, ending his period in power?

QUESTION 5
To which country did Iskander Mirza go into exile after his removal from office?


PLOT AGAINST PAKISTAN

The Prime Minister of Pakistan, Mr. Liaquat Ali Khan, issued the following statement to the Press on Friday morning :

A conspiracy, hatched by the enemies of Pakistan, has just been unearthed.

The aim of the conspiracy was to create commotion in the country by violent means and, in furtherance of this purpose, to subvert the loyalty of Pakistan's defence forces.

Timely information of these plans was received by the Government, and action has been taken today to arrest the ringleaders.

These are :

Major-General Akbar Khan, Chief of the General Staff.

Brigadier M. A. Latif, Brigade Commander at Quetta.

Faiz Ahmed Faiz, Editor of "The Pakistan Times."

Mrs. Akbar Khan, wife of Major-General Akbar Khan.

The two military officers involved in the conspiracy have been dismissed from service with immediate effect.

Plot Inspired by Reds ?

'FRENCH POLICY IN MOROCCO OUTDATED'

Iraq's condemnation

Visual question: This is a front-page report in *The Pakistan Times,* dated March 10, 1951, announcing arrests in a conspiracy that preceded Ayub Khan's military coup by seven years. By what name is the conspiracy known? THE PAKISTAN TIMES

Questions and answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. After the Second World War, representatives of 50 countries gathered at a conference in this place, leading to the signing of the UN Charter that created a new international organisation. **Ans: San Francisco**

2. The two Asian countries that are presently non-permanent members of the UN Security Council. **Ans: Pakistan and Bahrain**

3. The contribution of Oliver Lincoln Lundquist to the identity of the United Nations. **Ans: He led the design team that created the original emblem of the United Nations**

4. The first session of the General Assembly was held at this place in January 1946, with 51 member nations in attendance. **Ans: Central Hall, Westminster, London**

5. Focus of the first resolution of the United Nations GA. **Ans: Peaceful uses of atomic energy and the elimination of atomic and other weapons of mass destruction**

6. The two UN Secretaries-General who won the Nobel Peace Prize. **Ans: Dag Hammarskjöld and Kofi Annan (jointly with the UN)**

7. October 24 was officially designated as 'United Nations Day' in this year. **Ans: 1947**

Visual: Name of this former Secretary-General who later became the President of Austria. **Ans: Kurt Waldheim**

Early birds: Tamal Biswas| Erfanally Oosmany| Tariqa Bali| Sukdev Shet| Dodo Jayaditya



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of "red-faced"? (R. Ajay, Madurai)

When you say that someone was "red-faced" what it implies is that the individual was very angry or embarrassed about something. Here are a few examples.

When the chairman accused Suman of stealing, she became red-faced.

We saw a red-faced Shyamala being led away by the police.

How do you address a female Mayor? "Mayor" or "Mayoress"? (S.K. Sharma, Vishakapatnam)

It depends on you, I guess. "Mayoress" is a word, which is mainly used in Britain. It can be used to refer to a woman who is a Mayor. It can also be used to refer to the Mayor's wife.

Does this mean that a lady Governor can be called a "Governess"? I don't think so! This is the age of equality and therefore it is not surprising that many word's that maintain the gender distinction are going out of use.

Words like "authoress" and "poetess" are considered old fashioned and are seldom used these days. Similarly, "chairman", "spokesman", and "stewardess" have been replaced by gender-neutral terms like "chairperson", "spokesperson", and "flight attendant".

What is the difference between "on foot" and "by foot"? (K.J. Prabhakar, Chintalpudi)

When you get from one place to another using some mode of transportation, you usually say "by". For example,

Aparna went to Mumbai by train.

We are planning to go by car.

The refugees came by boat.

When you walk from one place to another, then you say "on" and not "by".

He went on foot.

Mythreye is going on foot, not by car.

She walked to the hospital.

What the meaning of "smell a rat"? (P. Sailaja, Chennai)

This expression has more or less the same meaning as "smell something fishy'. When you smell a rat, you suspect or realise that something is seriously wrong. Perhaps someone is trying to deceive you or trying to harm you. This expression is normally used in informal contexts. Here are a few examples.

If I don't return Amarnath's calls, he will smell a rat.

I smelt a rat when Venkat started being helpful.

Is it OK to say, "I have forgotten my briefcase at home"? (S. Sandeep)

It's very common to hear people say, "I have forgotten my umbrella at the office", or "I have forgotten my glasses at home". Careful users of the language, however, frown on such sentences. They argue that the word "forget" should be used to talk about things that have been left behind accidentally.

For example, it is O.K to say, "I have forgotten my notes", or, "I have forgotten to bring my assignment". When you use the verb "forget", the place should not be mentioned. If you wish to specify the place, then the verb "leave" should be used. Here are a few examples.

I have left my umbrella at home.

Oh no! I've left my lecture notes on the dining table.

Published in The Hindu on May 14, 2002

Word of the day

Sardonic:
disdainfully or ironically humorous

Synonym: snarky

Usage: *The government's promise of accountability was met with sardonic laughter.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/sardonic

International Phonetic Alphabet: /sɑːˈdɒnɪk/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



Hyundai introduces compact SUV Bayon starting ₹10 lakh

Hyundai Motor India Ltd. (HMIL) has announced the introduction of its new compact mid-size SUV Bayon starting at ₹9,99,900 (ex-showroom). The top end model is priced at ₹18 lakh. The SUV is designed for modern customers who seek a seamless blend of innovation, technology and everyday versatility, the firm said. It combines future-ready connectivity, advanced safety systems and powerful performance to deliver an intelligent mobility experience, it added.

Sensex, Nifty end 0.7% higher, reverse early trade losses

Benchmark indices sharply trimmed early trade losses and settled nearly 0.7% higher on Monday. Sensex ended at 73,606.75, up 0.66%, while Nifty 50 closed above 22,600 at 22,753.20, up 0.68%. The stock market witnessed decline in early trade, with the Sensex slipping 0.8% to 72,514.57 while the Nifty stocks plunged 0.9% to 22,387.35. The decline was attributed to investors remaining cautious ahead of major central policy decisions and amid uncertainty over the West Asia crisis.

IOB net profit rises 56% at ₹1,962.67 cr. in Sept. quarter

State-owned lender Indian Overseas Bank on Monday reported a 55.9% jump in consolidated net profit to ₹1,962.67 crore for the September quarter, driven by core income growth and improved asset quality. In the year-earlier period, the bank had reported a net profit of ₹1,258.82 crore. Its core net interest income (NII) increased 26.41% year-on-year to ₹3,867 crore in the second quarter of the current fiscal, from ₹3,059 crore in the year-earlier period. PTI

Tata Communications plans 10,000-km AI network at ₹4,350 cr.

First phase to link data centre hubs in Mumbai, Pune, Hyderabad, Chennai; later phases to extend connectivity in Western India, East Coast

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



The company expects AI-driven workloads to boost demand for resilient, high-capacity connectivity. REUTERS

Tata Communications said it will invest ₹4,350 crore to build about 10,000 km of AI-ready connectivity infrastructure across India, linking major data centre and artificial intelligence (AI) hubs to meet rising demand for high-capacity digital networks.

The investment, which was announced on Monday, will be funded through operating cash flows, the company said in a stock exchange filing. The proposed network expansion is scheduled to be implemented between FY 2030 and FY 2036.

The initial phase will focus on the Mumbai-Pune-Hyderabad-Chennai corridor, a key growth route for AI and hyperscale data centres. Subsequent phases will extend connectivity to emerging clusters along the East Coast and in western India, including Visakhapatnam, Bhubaneswar, Jamnagar and GIFT City.

The network will connect major data centre and AI hubs with international cable landing stations, strengthening links between India and global AI hubs.

The planned expansion is expected to add around 6 petabits per second (Pbps) to the company's existing network capacity of 1.25 Pbps. Current capacity utilisation stands at approximately 70-80%, according to the company.

The investment is aimed at meeting growing requirements from global hyperscalers, digital platforms, multinational enterprises, global capability centres and emerging cloud platforms. The company expects AI-driven workloads to boost demand for resilient, high-capacity connectivity alongside computing power and energy infrastructure.

Ganesh Lakshminarayanan, managing director and chief executive officer of Tata Communications, said the data centre-to-data centre connectivity market could grow into a market exceeding $1 billion over the medium term.

"With our planned investments, we are building on our existing strengths to create one of the most comprehensive data centre connectivity platforms in the market," he said.

Rupesh Chokshi, executive vice-president and global business head of Network Services at Tata Communications, said AI workloads required networks built for speed, scale and resilience.

The company will continue expanding its national long-distance and metro network infrastructure to support enterprise and data centre connectivity needs.

According to a Press Information Bureau release, India hosts nearly 20% of the world's data but accounts for only 3% of global data centre capacity.

Mumbai and Navi Mumbai form the country's largest data centre hub, accounting for over 25% of live capacity.

Govt. amends rules to enable use of E100 in compliant vehicles

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI


E100 fuel allows vehicles to run on nearly pure ethanol.

The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) has amended the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, to permit the use of ethanol-based fuels containing up to 100% ethanol (E100) in vehicles, paving the way for flex-fuel vehicles that run either on petrol, ethanol blends of varying proportions, or pure ethanol.

The amendments modify Rule 115, which deals with emission standards and related requirements for motor vehicles, and Rule 115E, which contains additional provisions relating to emission testing.

One of the key changes is the inclusion of E100, or fuel comprising 100% ethanol, alongside E85 in several tables under Rule 115. E85 is a fuel containing up to 85% ethanol, while E100 refers to fuel consisting of 100% ethanol, subject to the applicable fuel specification.

The amendments also contain an explanatory note which states that E85 or E100 shall be used in vehicles designed by original equipment manufacturers as flex-fuel vehicles.

In a press statement, MoRTH sought to allay concerns among motorists. "A vehicle's compatibility with E10 or E20 alone does not establish suitability for E85. This notification does not require owners of existing vehicles to switch to E85 or modify their vehicles either at present or in the future," it clarified.

The Ministry also advised that motorists should check the fuel compatibility sticker on their vehicles and follow the manufacturer's guidance in the owner's manual while opting for fuel. Corrections have also been incorporated to fuel classifications, including the reference to gasoline blended with 20% ethanol, or E20, in place of an earlier notation that referred to E10.

"The MoRTH amendment formally recognises E100 alongside E85, giving manufacturers a clear certification pathway for flex-fuel vehicles in India. OEMs can now design, certify and type-approve dedicated flex-fuel vehicles. This is an enabling step, not a market outcome," said Amit Bhatt, MD, International Council of Clean Transport.

E20 is currently the default fuel since April 2025.

In May 2026, the government notified specifications for ethanol-petrol blends above the E20, covering E22, E25, E27 and E30.

Anthropic files for IPO as H1 revenue jumps 14-fold to $16.3 billion

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Anthropic, the AI company behind Claude, has filed to go public in the U.S., disclosing rapid revenue growth, expanding enterprise spending and the high cost of developing and running advanced AI models.

The company filed a registration statement with the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) on October 26. It intends to list its Class A common stock on the Nasdaq Global Select Market under the ticker symbol "ANT". The number of shares to be offered and the price range have not yet been determined.

The public filing follows Anthropic's confidential submission of a draft registration statement to the SEC on June 1, 2026. The proposed IPO remains subject to regulatory review.

One of the key disclosures is that revenue from a group of existing customers was about nine times higher in the three months ended September 30, 2026, than in the same period a year earlier. The calculation includes customers who generated at least $1 in revenue in the earlier period but excludes subscribers to Anthropic's Claude Pro and Max plans.

For the six months ended June 30, 2026, Anthropic reported revenue of $16.3 billion, up from $1.16 billion in the corresponding period a year earlier.

Bank of Maharashtra Q2 net up 41% to ₹2,310 cr.

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Bank of Maharashtra (BoM) reported a 41% year-on-year (YoY) rise in net profit to ₹2,310 crore for the second quarter ended September 30 on a 22% surge in net interest income (NII) to ₹3,954 crore.

Cost-to-income ratio improved to 33.7% from 37.1% a year ago while return on assets rose to 2.02% from 1.82%. Deposits rose 21.5% to ₹3.76 lakh crore while gross advances surged 29.7% to ₹3.29 lakh crore.

Gross non-performing assets (NPAs) slid to 1.25% from 1.72% and net NPAs to 0.12% from 0.18%.

CCPA fines Britannia over '100%' whole wheat bread claim

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

In its order, the CCPA asked firm to discontinue the advertisement with immediate effect

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has imposed a penalty of ₹1 lakh on Britannia Industries Ltd. for a misleading advertisement that claimed "100% whole wheat bread" though the product's declared wheat content is just 62%.

In its order dated October 22, the CCPA, headed by Chief Commissioner directed the firm to discontinue the advertisement with immediate effect across print, electronic and social media.

Britannia has been asked to submit a compliance report in 15 days.

The CCPA took suo motu cognisance of the matter after noticing the product packaging declared a wheat content of 62% despite the "100%" claim in its advertisements.

During the investigation, the firm accepted its "100% whole wheat bread" contained only 62% wheat flour (atta).

BPCL eyes Middle East as Russian oil turns costlier

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (BPCL) tapped more into Middle Eastern crude as Russian oil lost its price advantage and also due to rising freight costs, with the shift becoming more pronounced in November, Vetsa Ramakrishna Gupta, director (Finance), told analysts.

"Our spot crude share remained at around 67% in the second quarter, while Russian grade accounted for approximately 37% of our total crude procurement, both broadly in line with the previous quarter," Mr. Gupta said.

Blue Dart Express Ltd. forays into cross-border parcel shipping service

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI



The service is designed for e-commerce businesses.

Blue Dart Express Ltd., an express air, integrated transportation and distribution company has announced the launch of International Parcel Connect, its B2C cross-border parcel shipping service.

Starting with shipments from India to the United States, the service is designed for e-commerce businesses, D2C brands, marketplace sellers, SMEs and exporters seeking access to overseas customers.

The service supports eligible B2C parcels weighing 50 g to 11 kg, across categories including apparel and fashion products, automobile spare parts, books, handicrafts, imitation jewellery and rugs, alongside other eligible marketplace and e-commerce products.

The service offers businesses an alternative between premium-priced express services and lower-cost postal options.

Balfour Manuel, Managing Director, Blue Dart, said, "For years, our customers have asked us to extend Blue Dart's trusted service to their international shipping needs. International Parcel Connect answers that call with a world-class solution, combining our operational strengths in India with the reach of our international network."

"As Indian enterprises pursue opportunities beyond domestic markets, we are committed to providing the dependable logistics connections that turn their global aspirations into growth," he said.

Dipanjan Banerjee, Chief Commercial Officer, Blue Dart, said, "For many sellers, the choice has been between premium-priced express delivery and lower-cost postal shipping. International Parcel Connect bridges this gap, allowing customers to choose between two delivery speeds to suit their needs. Shipment visibility and Blue Dart customer support in India provide greater control and a local point of contact, making cross-border shipping more accessible and easier to manage."

Blue Dart plans to progressively extend this service to the United Kingdom, countries in the European Union, Canada and Australia.

Indian content quality improved drastically: JioStar's Malhotra

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI


Tie up: Amit Malhotra, head, international business, *JioStar* (left) with Maaz Sheikh, founder- CEO, *Starz Play.* SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The quality of storytelling and production from India, including outside of Bollywood, has improved strongly over the last decade and is now attracting viewers from cultures outside of South Asia as well, according to Amit Malhotra, the head of international business at *JioStar*.

It is this increased demand from outside India that led *JioStar* to tie up with international streaming platform *Starz Play* to expand to the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) regions, a deal announced earlier this month.

This comes soon after *JioStar* launched across three new markets – Singapore, the U.K. and Canada – in September.

Beyond South Asians

"We are seeing that the opportunity to go international is well beyond just super-serving the South Asian community today," Mr. Malhotra told *The Hindu* in an interview.

"Because of the quality of storytelling from India, the quality of production from India, the overall narrative in terms of our content is so strong and the quality is so high, we do see audiences from other cultures embracing this and watching it at scale," he added.

Maaz Sheikh, founder-CEO of *Starz Play* agreed with this assessment of Indian content, saying it has come a long way since the days of Bollywood movies driven by stars such as Amitabh Bachchan.

The two streaming chiefs acknowledged a substantial chunk of the value proposition of joining forces is backed by the strong South Asian market. "The MENA region has 19 million South Asians across its 15 markets and the largest part of this is based in the Gulf Cooperation Council," Mr. Malhotra said.

TMB posts record ₹451-cr. net; braces for higher ECL provision

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI



Total business grew 27.25% YoY to ₹1.30 lakh crore.

Tamilnad Mercantile Bank (TMB) reported its highest-ever quarterly net profit of ₹451.14 crore in the second quarter of FY27, registering a 42.09% year-on-year (YoY) increase on the back of strong core banking income and improved cost efficiency. However, the bank expects its provisioning requirements under the upcoming expected credit loss (ECL) framework to rise further as its balance sheet expands.

Total business grew 27.25% YoY to ₹1.30 lakh crore in the quarter ended September 2026, marking its highest annual growth in 18 years, managing director and chief executive officer Salee Sukumaran Nair said.

Net interest income rose 35.17% to ₹807.17 crore, while operating profit increased 41.80% to ₹641.55 crore. "The net profit is the highest ever," Mr. Nair said, attributing the performance to robust net interest income, business growth and cost control. The cost-to-income ratio improved to 38.28% from 44.80% a year earlier.

TMB estimated its additional provisioning requirement under the ECL framework at ₹385 crore as of September 30, against provisions of ₹304.24 crore already available. The requirement is expected to increase by March 2027 as lending and the overall balance sheet expand.

The framework is scheduled to take effect on April 1, 2027. The bank began preparing for the transition by providing for its Special Mention Account (SMA)-1 and SMA-2 exposures in line with ECL norms during the September quarter.

ITC Hotels Q2 net rises 52% to ₹203 crore

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

ITC Hotels Ltd., for the second quarter ended September 30, 2026, reported a 52% jump in consolidated net profit to ₹203 crore over the year-ago period.

Consolidated revenue from operations at ₹1,054 crore grew 26% year-on-year, supported by growth across Rooms, Food & Beverage and Management Fees, the company said.

Standalone revenue from operations at ₹885 crore grew 16% year-on-year. Net profit at ₹207 crore grew 37% year-on-year.

During the quarter, room revenue grew 22% YoY, driven by growth in both rates and volumes.

Why Wall Street banks want Democrats to back their capital relief



Beyond Trump: Ensuring regulatory changes survive long-term may require Democratic support. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
WASHINGTON

Wall Street banks are poised to score significant regulatory relief thanks to U.S. President Donald Trump's Republican regulators, but ensuring the changes survive long-term may ultimately require Democratic support.

The Federal Reserve is trying to finalise the biggest overhaul of bank capital rules since the 2007-09 financial crisis by year end. Although Trump appointed four of the Fed's seven governors, Wall Street banks hope his vice chair for supervision, Michelle Bowman, can secure Democratic backing for the changes too, hoping that will make them harder to unwind, half a dozen industry executives said.

The fraught, years-long rulemaking is wrapping up as Democrats, often skeptical of deregulation, are poised to win one or both chambers of Congress next month, according to independent analysts. Democratic lawmakers have said they planned to probe Trump's agencies and companies that have benefited from their policy shifts. Wall Street banks are now weighing how to protect their wins if Democrats gain more power next year, or retake the White House in 2028, executives said.

"Bipartisan consensus-driven results stand the test of time much more often than not," said Michael Bright, CEO of the Structured Finance Association, an industry group.

"I think that the market's expectation is that they're working to find overall consensus," Bright added, referring to the Fed.

A spokesperson for the Federal Reserve Board declined to comment.

Banks want more changes

Democrats typically favour tougher rules to prevent costly taxpayer bank bailouts, while Republicans often argue that overly burdensome regulation can constrain lending and economic growth.

Invoking that conservative argument, Bowman in March proposed rule changes that would reduce big-bank capital by around 4.8%, a major reversal for an industry that had faced a 20% hike under a 2023 plan led by her Democratic predecessor Michael Barr.

Banks fought Barr's plan, persuading Congressional Republicans as well as dozens of Democrats to pressure the Fed into revising it. That battle dragged the project into the Trump administration.

Barr stepped down as vice chair for supervision early last year, saying he wanted to avoid a legal fight with Trump, who was reportedly planning to strip him of that role. Barr remains on the board and opposed Bowman's proposal, arguing it will increase systemic risk. Progressive Democrats and advocacy groups have echoed his concern, but most other Democrats have not weighed in.

The board's other two Democratic-appointed governors, Lisa Cook and Philip Jefferson, voted for the proposals, and said they would assess the final rules on their merits after reviewing feedback on how they would affect the economy and financial resilience.

"It is critical that we strike the right balance," Cook said.

Some big banks are pushing Bowman for more relief, including tweaks that would further reduce their "GSIB surcharges,"additional capital applied to the biggest global banks.

Others want changes to how the proposal to implement international' Basel' standards treats unused credit card lines. Most banks also want some fine-tuning to remove what they say is overlap with other capital rules.

But cutting big-bank capital further could cost Bowman Democratic support. While a handful of executives are privately urging Fed officials to prioritise further gains, most favor a swift bipartisan vote, according to the executives, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive regulatory issues.

Bowman acknowledged that balancing act during Congressional testimony in June, when lawmakers asked why the Fed stopped short of adopting the industry's preferred approach for recalibrating the GSIB surcharge in line with economic growth.

Riding a local boom, Chinese beauty brands set sights on international sales

Proya to sell two skincare lines in 400 Ulta stores in U.S. from next month; Florasis, Joocyee and Judydoll opened shops abroad; moves follow rapid growth in home market; C-beauty brands overtook global names in 2022 and accounted for 57.4% of China's $159 billion cosmetics market last year

NEWS ANALYSIS

REUTERS
SHANGHAI/PARIS



Widening perspective: A Florasis store in Shanghai, China. REUTERS

China's beauty brands are stepping out into the global market, armed with intricately carved lipsticks, freeze-dried face masks activated with purified water as well as creams infused with ingredients from traditional Chinese medicine.

Proya Cosmetics, the largest C-beauty brand by revenue, is among the most aggressive. Its Advanced Firming and Original Repair skincare lines will be sold in 400 Ulta stores as well as on Ulta.com across the U.S. from November, and it opened a Paris research and development centre this month.

Other brands had a start in online sales and are now expanding to physical stores abroad. They include Florasis, whose lipsticks and other ornate cosmetics draw on traditional Chinese aesthetics. It opened its first overseas flagship shop in Tokyo's posh Ginza district last year. Joocyee, which produces skincare-infused makeup, and Judydoll, known for inventive products such as its metal-wand mascara, opened shops in Singapore last year. Both brands, owned by China's Joy Group, are also now stocked at Skin Cupid, a British retailer specialising in Asian beauty products.

C-beauty brands have grown rapidly within China over the past decade and industry executives today speak of a growing confidence that Chinese products will find favour with consumers worldwide. Gone are the days when China was associated with cheap and low-quality goods, as Chinese innovations – across many industries but particularly in electric vehicles – have produced a halo effect, they say.

"The shift can be seen in everything from cars and smartphones to AI models," said David Huang, CEO of NewYork-listed Yat sen Group, which owns the Perfect Diary makeup brand. The efforts by the C-beauty firms are part of a broader push abroad by Chinese brands – from fashion and electronics to bubble tea – keen to seek new revenue amid a years-long slump in domestic consumer spending.

> C-beauty brands have grown rapidly in China over the past decade and industry officials speak with growing confidence Chinese products will find favour with consumers worldwide

Challenges ahead

Some Chinese brands are very ambitious. Proya, for example, wants to become a top 10 brand globally and is among C-beauty companies exploring acquisitions of smaller foreign brands to expand their portfolios.

Its 51%-owned colour cosmetics brand Flower Knows, known for fairy-tale-inspired packaging, also launched with British pharmacy and beauty retailer Boots in March and began a limited run in Ulta stores in September.

While awareness of Chinese beauty brands is growing in many international markets, Proya says it has a long way to go.

"I would say that Proya's brand awareness in both Europe and the U.S. is currently zero," founder and CEO Hou Juncheng said at the opening of the company's R&D centre in Paris.

"We hope that through collaboration with our partners, we can earn consumer trust and encourage them to purchase our products."

Rivals believe Proya, founded only 20 years ago, has a bright future, with Marc-Antoine Jamet, president of French industry association Cosmetic Valley, describing Hou as an"incredible competitor".

"He moved from the mass market to the mid-market, and then from the mid-market to the premium segment. You can be sure he'll move into the luxury sector – whether in six weeks, six months, or six years. That's a near certainty," said Mr. Jamet.

Inspired by K-beauty

C-beauty brands overtook international names in 2022 and accounted for 57.4% of China's $159 billion cosmetics market last year, according to the China Association of Fragrance, Flavor and Cosmetic Industries.

They can also draw inspiration from the success of their Korean counterparts, which have become a significant force in the global cosmetics industry.

Exports for the K-beauty sector, known for 10-step routines to produce luminous "glass skin", surged 50% over five years to hit $11.4 billion in 2025. South Korea also overtook France in 2024 to become the top source of cosmetics imports in the tough-to-crack American market, U.S. International Trade Commission data showed.

K-beauty has helped pave the way by bringing "this Asian cultural awareness to the market," said Jing An, an attorney at Altman & An, a New York law firm that helps foreign firms with U.S. intellectual property and e-commerce operations. An says her Chinese clients are usually apparel firms, luggage brands and online platforms but in the past year she has taken on two Chinese beauty clients looking to enter the U.S. market.

One advantage that Chinese brands might have is their mid-market price points. Global consumers have become "really fed up of paying premium prices for topical skincare," said Elisa Harca, co-founder of marketing firm Red Ant Asia, which has advised global retailers on which C-beauty products to stock.

In the U.S., Chinese brands must also navigate persistent trade and geopolitical tensions between Beijing and Washington. Gabby Chen, president of global markets at Florasis, said that last year, China-U.S. tensions led the brand to shift its global expansion away from the U.S.

Ms. Chen is now focused more on building a sustainable global business regardless of the geopolitical backdrop.

SEBI's small and medium enterprises IPO reform offers a funding choice as interest rates increase

Santosh V. Perumal



Breathing easy: SEBI's central aim of reforms is to make fundraising easier for firms. REUTERS

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has proposed reforms to initial public offerings (IPOs) of small and medium enterprises (SMEs), at a time when the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is turning hawkish.

Given the present interest rate scenario and rate expectations, the choice between borrowing and equity raising is of great significance for the SMEs, which account for more than 31% of the country's gross value added (GVA).

The RBI Monetary Policy Committee's "calibrated tightening" stance by a 4-2 vote signals further hikes amid inherent strengths in the macroeconomy.

Heightened inflation risk, driven by higher oil prices and a deficient monsoon, led the RBI to raise the repo rate for the first time in nearly four years. The reasoning is that higher rates may squeeze margins, limiting the ability of businesses to invest in expansion since borrowing costs and debt-servicing burdens are tightly linked.

For a highly leveraged SME with volatile cash flows, raising equity through IPOs can strengthen the balance sheet and improve ability to borrow on better terms later.

Credit cost constraint

The cost of credit remains a structural constraint for SMEs, although available data does not establish a uniform rise across all Indian SMEs. Bank loans have been the main funding source for SMEs, but borrowing costs are generally higher than those of large enterprises.

An International Finance Corporation (IFC) study found the SME sector's overall debt-to-equity ratio at about 4:1, and 3:1 for early-stage firms.

Valuable choice

SEBI's latest initiative is not to make equity universally cheaper than debt, but to give viable SMEs a choice of financing suited to their business models. In a high-interest-rate regime, such a choice can be valuable.

SEBI proposed relaxing SME listing norms, potentially widening access to capital markets and reducing some compliance costs while imposing stronger profitability and governance tests.

Timing matters

The mainboard segment saw robust growth in the number of IPOs while SME IPO activity contracted. The mainboard IPOs raised about ₹1.73 lakh crore in FY2025-26, compared with ₹5,363 crore through NSE's SME platform. The average mainboard issue was more than 33 times the average SME issue in that year.

SEBI's proposed reforms could help revive the smaller-company segment though the ultimate effect will depend on market conditions, eligibility requirements and investor confidence.

SEBI's proposals

Under the new seven-point eligibility framework, the minimum application amount for SME IPOs would fall to ₹1 lakh from ₹2 lakh. Investors would have to apply for at least four lots, each valued at no less than ₹25,000. The minimum number of allottees is proposed to be raised to 500 from 200, in a bid to widen the investor base.

The minimum operating-profit norm would change significantly, from ₹1 crore in at least two of the preceding three financial years to an average of ₹3 crore a year over three years.

However, firms failing this test could still access the market through book-building if at least 75% of the net offer is allotted to QIBs or qualified institutional buyers, whose due diligence could provide an additional layer of scrutiny, although it cannot replace regulatory safeguards or guarantee investment returns. SEBI, instead of depending on paid-up capital-based norms, proposes using a post-issue market capitalisation (M-cap) framework, which may help growing businesses whose size and funding needs no longer fit comfortably in the existing SME-platform arrangements.

Firms with a post-issue M-cap of up to ₹1,000 crore would necessarily have to seek listing on the SME platform; those valued ₹1,000-4,000 crore could go either on the SME or the main board, subject to eligibility norms.

Companies exceeding ₹4,000 crore threshold would need to get listed on the main-board, even as it seeks to end reverse migration to mainboard.

No market making

SEBI has removed mandatory market making for SME-listed stocks, along with related inventories and the removal of the 100% underwriting requirement for SME IPOs, including the lead manager's obligation to underwrite 15% of the issue.

It has been proposed to allow SME-listed shares to be traded in single-share lots in a move to allow investors to buy or sell smaller quantities in the secondary market.

SEBI has also proposed changes to shareholding lock-in rules and the use of IPO proceeds. The offer for sale (OFS) route would have a separate framework, with a one-year holding requirement and specified exemptions.

Who benefits?

The potential is huge, but the number of entities that will actually benefit is yet to be quantified reliably.

The Ministry of MSME's official data showed that more than 7.83 crore enterprises were registered on the Udyam Registration Portal and Udyam Assist Platform as of February 28, 2026. These include informal microenterprises that are unlikely to meet the financial, governance and disclosure norms of a public listing.

The Government's Economic Survey reported that more than 1,380 firms had listed on the BSE and NSE SME platforms since inception, with 217 SME listings during FY26 up to December 2025.

The opportunity is notably relevant in sectors such as manufacturing, engineering, technology, defence components and specialised services, where firms may need substantial investment before their cash flows fully mature.

It becomes more relevant with many startups getting into highly specialised and capital-intensive rocketry and missile technologies.

The primary benefit for SMEs is capital raising but secondary spin-off is the enhanced visibility in the capital markets.

A stronger capital base can reduce leverage and potentially improve lenders' assessment of creditworthiness, which in turn, helps widen the access to subsequent funding.

The pitfalls

Micro enterprises, especially, may find IPOs impractical as public listing involves costs, disclosures, governance requirements and scrutiny. Moreover, credit rating penetration remains limited relative to the size of India's MSME sector, although that is not a prerequisite.

Market volatility can play spoilsport as it shuts the IPO window when businesses need funds, while weak post-listing performance can damage investor confidence.

SEBI's proposed changes are therefore more relevant to established, growth-oriented SMEs that have the financial capacity to meet listing requirements.

Central theme

The main aim is to make fundraising easier for firms while ensuring investors are not exposed to disproportionate risk. If ease of access comes at the expense of governance and market integrity, a short-term rise in listings may ultimately curb investor confidence.

The likely economic dividend of a deeper SME capital market is not the replacement of bank lending but a better balance between debt and equity.

AMMAN

Jordan arrests three in dawn raid over church attack that killed nine



AFP

Jordanian security forces on Monday arrested three suspects over an attack on a church last week that killed nine people, with the trio wounded in a dawn raid and shootout. The arrested suspects — two brothers and another man related by marriage — are Islamic extremists, the country's Director of Public Security said. AFP

GAZA CITY

Five Palestinians, including child, killed in Israeli strikes in Gaza Strip



REUTERS

Five Palestinians, including a young girl, were killed on Monday in Israeli air strikes across the Gaza Strip, medical sources and first responders said. Civil defence spokesman Mahmoud Bassal said a total of 13 people had been killed and about 60 wounded by Israeli fire and air strikes in Gaza in the past 24 hours. AFP

ORLEANS

Le Pen kicks off presidential bid, vows to restore French 'rule of law'



AFP

France's far-right candidate Marine Le Pen kicked off her campaign on Sunday vowing to "restore the rule of law" if elected next year. In her address, Ms. Le Pen vowed to preserve France's cultural identity. "We are going to restore the rule of law," she said, after looting and arson erupted on the sidelines of mass cost-of-living rallies. AFP

KHARTOUM

Mass outages in parts of Sudan after RSF drones hit power stations



AFP

Sudan's paramilitary Rapid Support Forces launched a coordinated drone attack on Monday against five power stations, causing mass power outages across the country's east, a government official said. The drones hit power stations in three States — Al-Jazira, Gedaref and White Nile — controlled by the Sudanese Army. AFP

Iran, Mecca pact nations hold 'de-escalation' talks

Saudi Defence Minister, Pakistani Army chief and Turkiye's intelligence head meet Iranian officials; President Pezeshkian says Tehran supports any deal that would deepen regional cooperation

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN



Crucial meeting: Saudi Arabia's Defence Minister Prince Khalid bin Salman, Pakistan Field Marshal Asim Munir and Turkish intelligence chief Ibrahim Kalin in Tehran, Iran, on Monday. REUTERS

Senior officials from Saudi Arabia, Turkiye and Pakistan held talks with Iran in Tehran on Monday in an attempt to stop war in West Asia from reigniting.

Officials from the three Mecca pact countries flew to Iran as part of efforts to "de-escalate between the parties to the current crisis", a Saudi Foreign Ministry statement said.

The delegations, which included Saudi Defense Minister Khalid bin Salman, Pakistani Army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir and Turkey's intelligence head Ibrahim Kalin, met Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and other top security officials during the visit. The meeting ended without concrete announcements, with the various parties saying they "agreed to continue discussions", according to Iranian state media.

Mr. Pezeshkian said that Iran supports any agreement that would deepen regional cooperation, resolve differences and make greater use of the shared resources and capabilities of Islamic countries.

As the talks in Tehran began, United Nations Secretary General Antonio Guterres said it was "essential to stop any escalation" in West Asia.

"The risk to have the combination of an overwhelming military attack on Iran, and an overwhelming military attack by Iran on the countries of the Gulf, needs to be avoided at all costs," he said.

Earlier, Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei told reporters that the agenda for the meeting wasn't set, but the talks would "address the most pressing threats to regional security."

Mr. Baghaei added that the meeting, proposed during a visit by Mr. Munir to Tehran last week, could be a first step towards establishing regional security mechanisms based on the interests of countries in the region.

In a televised address on Monday, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan warned that renewed attacks on Iran would destabilise the region. "It is our hope that all parties will refrain from any actions that could drag our region into a new spiral of violence," Mr. Erdogan said.

Rising tensions

Saudi Arabia intercepted another wave of missiles on Sunday as fighting with Yemen's Houthis continued unabated.

The Saudi-led coalition battling the Iran-aligned group said on Monday that it has degraded their ability to strike targets inside the kingdom after destroying tunnels used to store ballistic missiles.

Tensions between Washington and Tehran have sharpened in recent days. President Donald Trump said on Friday the U.S. may carry out another military operation against Iran and Iran's leaders have said that a renewed U.S. military campaign would be met with a stronger response than before.

(With inputs from AP)

Trump's South America plans hit hurdle with Lula's triumph

NEWS ANALYSIS

Shobhan Saxena
SAO PAULO



Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva gestures as he addresses supporters after his victory in the presidential poll, in Sao Paulo, on Monday. REUTERS

Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva's victory against far-right candidate Flavio Bolsonaro in Sunday's presidential run-off in Brazil bucks the recent trend of right-wing waves in South America and is a setback for Washington's plans for the region.

U.S. President Donald Trump had repeatedly made clear that his preferred candidate in the race was Mr. Flavio. Even on Sunday night, Mr. Trump questioned Mr. Lula's victory, comparing it to the 2020 U.S. election which he lost to Joe Biden and alleged that Brazil had followed the "Joe Biden playbook".

Mr. Lula's victory is "a defeat for the United States' defence strategy in Latin America, based on the Shield of the Americas," said Celso Amorim, special foreign policy adviser to the Brazilian President. On Sunday night, the veteran diplomat hailed the result as "a great victory, made even greater by the circumstances."

He also ruled out any possibility of Brazil joining the Shield of the Americas, an alliance launched by Mr. Trump in March this year, ostensibly to combat drug trafficking in the region.

Mr. Lula's victory drew congratulations from leaders across Latin America, many of whom underscored the importance of democracy and continued cooperation with Brasilia.

'Long live democracy'

Leaders from Mexico, Chile, Paraguay, Bolivia, Panama and other countries welcomed the result in posts on X. Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum celebrated Brazil's democratic process and popular participation, declaring: "Long live democracy, the people of Brazil have won. Congratulations, President Lula!"

Even as Brazil's historic election creates waves across the world, Mr. Flavio has refused to accept the result, announcing that he would seek its annulment. He accused the Federal Supreme Court of "changing the rules midway" after a judge ordered voting to be extended until 7 p.m. when Mr. Lula complained about many right-wing Mayors curtailing bus services in the poor areas in many cities. "It is impossible to recognise the election result in the context in which these things happened," said Mr. Flavio.

But on Monday, local media quoted three justices of the Supreme Court and Brazilian Election Commission as saying the decision to extend voting period by two hours is "unlikely to provide grounds for annulling the election or invalidating votes".

Mr. Lula, on his part, promised to change his approach to governing, ensure greater public participation in government decisions and give digital communication a more prominent role during his fourth term. "The future begins today, and its name is youth. I salute the women who made all the difference. I salute the older people who made sacrifices and made their way to polling stations," Mr. Lula said.

Open to local ceasefires, but no let-up in war: Kremlin

Agence France-Presse
MOSCOW

Russia said on Monday that it would not slow down its offensive on Ukraine despite upcoming U.S.-brokered talks on ending the conflict but that it could agree local "humanitarian" ceasefires.

The Kremlin said that it was open to short-term "humanitarian" ceasefires along the front line, ahead of a truce in the Russian-occupied city of Oleshky.

A ceasefire is to start in the Ukrainian city on Tuesday, brokered by U.S. First Lady Melania Trump after months of reports that residents faced dire food and medicine shortages.

Asked whether Russia would consider more local truces, Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov told reporters: "For humanitarian purposes, absolutely."

Trilateral talks

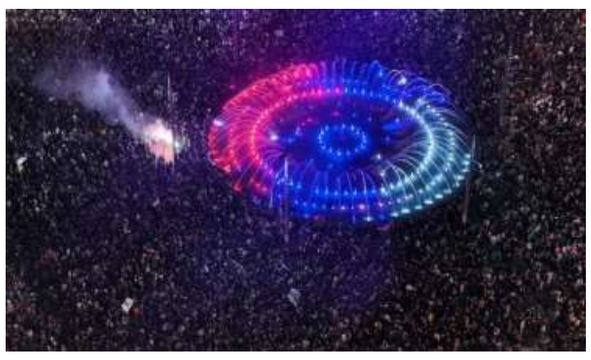
But Moscow vowed not to let up in the overall pace of the war, even as the sides prepare to restart stalled talks under U.S. mediation next month.

"The decision to resume trilateral talks does not imply any restrictions on combat operations," Mr. Peskov said.

"Our armed forces continue to carry out massive strikes on Ukraine's military-industrial complex," he added.

Student-led movement ousts Serbia's Vucic in snap poll

Associated Press
BELGRADE



People celebrate a day after the student-led Opposition movement won the parliamentary election, in Belgrade on Monday. AP

The long-serving strongman leader of Serbia, Aleksandar Vucic, conceded defeat on Sunday in a snap election that pitted him and his right-wing party against a diverse student-led opposition movement.

The victory in Sunday's parliamentary vote came after nearly two years of anti-government protests sparked by the 2024 collapse of a canopy at Novi Sad railway station that killed 16 people. It was a seismic political shift in the Balkan country where Mr. Vucic led with virtually absolute power for 14 years.

In conceding the election, Mr. Vucic said his party projects that his opponents, the youth-backed Students' List, will take between 135 and 140 seats in the 250-seat Assembly while his right-wing Serbian Progressive Party (SNS) will have around 105.

Alleges interference

"It is now clear that we have lost and the Students' List has won," Mr. Vucic told supporters at his party's election night event, though he blamed Serbia's independent media as well as alleged interference by unnamed European countries and an "American deep state" for the loss.

Near-record turnout of almost 70%, the Balkan nation's highest at a parliamentary election in more than three decades, likely drove the political upset.

Mr. Vucic said that his SNS party won around 1.7 million votes compared to the Students' List, which he said took around 2.2 million.

Radomir Saicic, a Students' List candidate, said "tonight is not just about results". "This is a victory over fear ... it is nobody's trophy, it is a citizens victory. But victory carries responsibility," he added.

The Students' List movement was shaped by university students but none actually appeared on the election list. Instead, its candidates are little-known experts, athletes, farmers and artists.

This approach was meant to counter Mr. Vucic's one-man rule and restore a sense of community and solidarity.

The student victory echoed the recent electoral defeat of a Mr. Vucic ally in Hungary, where youth participation helped oust the autocratic Viktor Orbán after 16 years and bring in a new pro-European government.

Protesters kill nurse treating Ebola patients in Congo

Reuters
KINSHASA

Congo has reported over 9,000 Ebola cases; such attacks have been fuelled by misinformation

Youths killed a long-time nurse treating Ebola patients in eastern Congo and other health workers were sheltering under police guard, health officials said on Monday, in the latest in a series of attacks that have been fuelled by misinformation.

The nurse worked at the general hospital in the town of Bafwasende in Tshopo province, where he sought to help residents understand and protect themselves from Ebola. He was attacked and killed on Friday.

"We are shocked at how the population turned against this nurse. It is impossible to believe that he was mistaken for a stranger," a local health official said.

Fear for their security

A colleague survived the attack and was recovering in hospital, the official said.

Other health workers were sheltering at the general hospital under police guard, too afraid to go home, while the Army also briefly deployed to the area, he said.

"None of the nurses have slept at their homes because they fear for their security," the official added.

Tshopo is among eight provinces in Congo that are battling a fast-spreading outbreak of the Bundibugyo species of the Ebola virus. Congo's public health institute on Friday reported 9,964 total confirmed cases with around a 48.6% fatality rate since the outbreak was declared in May

"The killing of a nurse yesterday in Bafwasende is a loss to the Ebola response and an even greater loss to patients," Julien Harneis, the senior United Nations Ebola coordinator, said in a post on X on Sunday.

'Earned settlement': U.K. PM backs immigration principle

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON



Andy Burnham

U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham has said that he stands by the principle that settlement (permanent residence) in the U.K. should be "earned" and not granted automatically.

An increase in the baseline qualifying period for settlement, from 5 to 15 years, had been proposed by U.K. Home Secretary Shabana Mahmood as part of a draft "earned settlement" immigration overhaul last year, during the Keir Starmer administration. Individuals could qualify for shorter or longer periods depending on income, immigration violations and other factors.

Indian citizens are likely to be significantly impacted by the new rules. Indian nationals constituted the largest group from outside the EU+ (EU and a few other European countries) area to migrate long-term to the U.K. for the year ending December 2025.

"We'll set out the plan on that quite soon," Mr. Burnham said during a TV interview on Monday. He said the government was still considering the responses received in the public consultation process that took place earlier this year.

In recent weeks, the Prime Minister has indicated that the government would soften the proposed stance towards social care workers. These individuals formed a significant part of the 'Boriswave' of migration – a surge in migrants in the early 2020s – who are now becoming eligible for settlement.

Mr. Burnham said that since the U.K. left the EU in 2016, things had not "played out as people said it would at the time" with the country's economy weakening and control over immigration becoming more challenging. He said "revolving-door immigration" was being replaced by permanent immigration to the U.K.

Over the weekend, the *Sunday Times* had reported that Mr. Burnham would be open to considering 'free movement' (i.e., right to live and work) between the U.K. and EU.

On rejoining EU

In his Monday interview, Mr. Burnham reiterated his wish to see the U.K. rejoin the EU in his lifetime, adding, however, that he would "not move ahead of the public".

"The British public... will be the bosses here. They will decide what will happen in relation to Brexit," he said, as he denied that he was "testing the waters" with the public and media on how a return to the E.U. would be received.

The U.K. and EU are working towards concluding an agreement that would cover agriculture and immigration among other areas, at a summit meeting on November 20.



A child receives treatment in an overcrowded measles isolation ward at a hospital in Sylhet, Bangladesh. REUTERS

Bangladesh measles crisis raises fears of more epidemics

Agence France-Presse
DHAKA

Experts have warned Bangladesh that deadly outbreaks of diphtheria, whooping cough and polio could follow an ongoing measles epidemic that has already killed over 1,200 children, according to a report seen by *AFP* on Monday.

"The measles outbreak is a litmus test and a warning sign of a deteriorating immunisation system," said the report by an independent committee of national and international experts, which carried out its research earlier in October.

Bangladesh has struggled since March to contain the outbreak, which has killed more than 1,200 children and infected 2,20,000 people, making it the country's deadliest in decades, according to the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS).

"If no urgent mitigation measures are taken, it is only a matter of time before there are large outbreaks of pertussis [whooping cough], diphtheria and even vaccine-derived poliovirus," added the report, which has been submitted to the government.

The Health Ministry pledged action on Monday.

"We are going to recruit vaccinators as quickly as possible as the first step towards implementing the recommendations," spokesman Zahid Raihan told *AFP*.

Netanyahu, wanted by ICC, battles for political survival as Israel goes to polls

Public anger over failure to prevent the Hamas attack, an inconclusive war, and the rising costs of living have eroded Netanyahu's standing at home and abroad; the outcome of this poll is likely to shape the longest serving PM's political future, the fate of Likud and the legal challenges he faces

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sambavi Parthasarathy

Thousands took to the streets of Tel Aviv on Saturday, demanding accountability for the failure to prevent the October 7, 2023 Hamas attack. The anti-government demonstration came just three days ahead of what is being described as one of Israel's most consequential elections.

The protest adds to the pressure on Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, whose bid to retain power comes amid mounting criticism of his government's handling of domestic and international issues.

For most of Mr. Netanyahu's latest term, Israel has been embroiled in one conflict or the other. In less than a year of him taking the seat as the Prime Minister in 2022, Israel witnessed the Hamas attack in which more than 1,200 were killed, and about 250 were taken hostage.

This stirred concerns and protests over security failure and hostage releases.

Mr. Netanyahu then promised a "total victory" over Hamas and other enemies.

Three years later, the war is still dragging on inconclusively. What began as Israel's response to the Hamas attack spiralled into an all-out regional conflict in West Asia, with the country launching attacks in Gaza, Iran, Lebanon, Yemen, and Syria.

His involvement of the U.S. in its war against Iran on February 28 has impacted countries much beyond West Asia, as it disrupted global energy supply.

He has also intensified Israel's operations in the West Bank and has increased settlement projects in the region. This has not only severely impacted his ratings as a Prime Minister but has also isolated Israel internationally.

According to a Pew Research Centre survey conducted earlier this year, majorities in more than thirty surveyed countries expressed unfavourable views of Israel and little or no confidence in Mr. Netanyahu. Even within Israel, the military actions have not alleviated the security concerns. A survey by the Israel Democracy Institute in July this year showed that only a little over one-third of Israelis think that the security situation is better than what it was before 'Operation Roaring Lion'. The constant state of conflict has also come at severe domestic costs– high inflation, a high cost of living, longer and more exhausting service for Army personnel, a soaring national debt, and declining business investment.



Satire on streets: A protester dressed as Benjamin Netanyahu with a Pinocchio nose during an anti-govt. demonstration in Tel Aviv. AFP

Further, he has been accused of weakening the judiciary and endangering democracy with his far-right government.

For Mr. Netanyahu, the longest-serving Prime Minister seeking the seventh term, a lot is at stake personally too.

Legal troubles

According to Arik Rudnitzky, from the Israel Democracy Institute in Jerusalem, these elections are the most deterministic political test for Mr. Netanyahu as the leader of the Likud Party. He told *The Hindu*: "I believe these elections are crucial to the political future of Netanyahu. If he no longer serves as Prime Minister, then he has to face his legal issues, and especially the file is being handled right now in court, with the accusations that he has to defend himself."

The corruption trial, which began in 2020, has been under way for six years now. Mr. Netanyahu has been indicted on charges of bribery, fraud, and breach of trust. He has, however, denied these charges, and the case continues in court. Without the political power, reports suggest that Mr. Netanyahu would have fewer chances of gaining immunity or reasons to postpone hearings.

He is also officially a 'wanted man' by the International Criminal Court (ICC), which issued arrest warrants for the Israeli Prime Minister on November 21, 2024. The warrants were issued in response to accusations of crimes against humanity and war crimes in Gaza. Israel has denied these allegations.

While the case is still at a pre-trial stage, it has impacted his travel to ICC member countries, and the scope could become much weaker if he loses his power.

His loss will also impact the Likud party, which he joined in the 1980s and through which he went on to become the country's youngest Prime Minister at the age of 46 in 1996.

Mr. Rudnitzky said, "There is the question whether Netanyahu can serve as the leader of the Likud... Although the Likud, to some extent, retained its 20 seats according to recent polls, it is 30% lower or one-third of its power, compared to the past four years. In past years, the Likud's power ranged between 30 to 36 seats. So, there's a significant loss of power, and this is why I believe that these elections are the deterministic political test for Netanyahu as the leader of the Likud."

The October Council – a group founded by the families of victims and hostages taken by Hamas militants on October 7, 2023 – which organised the latest protest, reasoned it as the "culminating event marking three years of struggle" to demand accountability and establish a state commission of inquiry.

These are the very demands that other contesting parties have made as central promises of their electoral campaigns.

North Korea displays howitzer near border amid rising strains with Seoul

Reuters
SEOUL

Tensions between North Korea and South Korea are running high this week after Pyongyang sent a letter to the UN Security Council, repeating accusations that Seoul fabricated a September landmine incident, and after a North Korean howitzer was spotted close to the border.

A *Reuters* witness at an observatory in South Korea overlooking the heavily armed border on Monday confirmed the presence of a North Korean artillery piece positioned in clear view near the frontier.

South Korea's Yonhap news agency on Sunday identified the weapon as a self-propelled 122-mm howitzer, saying its deployment near the border marked a rare public display of such artillery.



Sour ties: North Korean soldiers near the border, as seen from an observation deck in Gimpo, South Korea, on Monday. REUTERS

Reuters also observed three North Korean armoured vehicles with their gun barrels pointed south, as well as about 20 to 30 North Korean soldiers carrying out fencing work inside the Demilitarised Zone (DMZ).

"It is highly unusual [for North Korea] to expose its self-propelled artillery so conspicuously," said Lim Eul-chul, a professor at Kyungnam University in Seoul. "By deliberately displaying it, North Korea is signalling through action, not words, that it intends to enforce its border policy through force rather than dialogue."

North Korean state media KCNA reported that in the letter sent on Sunday, the country's UN representative said Seoul was using the landmine incident to depict Pyongyang's border construction as a military incursion.

North Korea warned in the letter that violations of its sovereignty could trigger self-defence measures and that South Korea would be "wholly accountable for all the ensuing consequences."

The letter is a response to a South Korean letter to the Security Council last week, which said a September 21 blast in the DMZ was planted by North Korean troops and constituted a violation of the Korean War Armistice Agreement.

Grave glamour



In character: A couple dressed as zombies take part in the Catrinas Parade ahead of the Day of the Dead (November 2) in Mexico City. AFP

Trump ramps up anti-Muslim rhetoric against Michigan Senate candidate

Associated Press
PORT HURON

President Donald Trump intensified his anti-Muslim rhetoric against Michigan Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed on Sunday, portraying him as a threat to national security and questioning his loyalty to the United States in remarks that drew a sharp rebuke from a former top Arab American ally.

Mr. Trump called El-Sayed, a former Detroit health official, a "jihadist" who was "on the side of the terrorists" and would "have to go through a metal detector before he's allowed to go into the Senate." He also repeatedly invoked the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks, drawing a comparison between stopping Mr. El-Sayed from entering the Senate chamber and the passengers who fought back against the hijackers aboard United Flight 93.

Mr. El-Sayed, who would become the nation's first Muslim Senator if elected, has called attacks on his loyalty to the country "shameful" and repeatedly denied any ties to extremist groups. The Republican President's remarks were condemned by Bishara Bahbah, a founder of Arab Americans for Trump, the group that helped lead the President's outreach to Arab American voters in 2024.

"The President's statements are out of line," he said in a phone interview. "They are crossing a red line. They are racist."

On the defensive

With Republicans on the defensive over inflation, soaring fuel prices and the Iran war, the President has been trying to generate turnout by claiming that Mr. El-Sayed and other Democrats are existential threats to America, instead of electoral rivals. Michigan's Senate race between Mr. El-Sayed and Republican Mike Rogers is among a handful of contests that could determine control of the chamber.

Mr. Trump made his remarks in Port Huron, a Canadian border city about an hour north of Detroit and near communities where he made significant gains among Arab American voters in 2024. He became the first Republican presidential candidate since 2000 to win Dearborn, a city with one of the nation's largest concentrations of Arab Americans.

Mr. Trump, who imposed a travel ban targeting several predominantly Muslim countries during his first term, has increasingly leaned into anti-Muslim rhetoric as election day approaches. He also attacked Democratic Representative Ilhan Omar of Minnesota at Sunday's rally, where he declared that he had come to Michigan "to keep a jihadist Muslim Brotherhood member from becoming a United States Senator."

Responding to Mr. Trump, who also regularly mocks his name, Mr. El-Sayed told supporters at a rally in Grand Rapids later Sunday that he doesn't care how Mr. Trump pronounces or misrepresents it.



Democrat candidate: Abdul El-Sayed speaks at a midterm campaign rally in Grand Rapids, Michigan, on Sunday. AFP

"I don't even care that he remembers my whole name because he can just go on and call me 'Senator' after November," Mr. El-Sayed said, drawing cheers. "I will be Senator Muhammad to you, bro."

Central to Republicans' strategy against Mr. El-Sayed in the final weeks of the campaign has been an effort to link him to the Muslim Brotherhood, an Islamic movement with branches that the U.S. government has designated as terrorist organisations.

There is no evidence that Mr. El-Sayed has any affiliation with the Muslim Brotherhood. His half-sister, Eman Abdelhadi, wrote on social media in 2012 that "my family has long been MB" and described a conversation with her mother about her involvement in the Muslim Brotherhood in the early 1970s.

Mr. El-Sayed was born in the United States to Egyptian immigrant parents who divorced when he was young. He was raised by his father, not his biological mother.

Mr. Trump on Sunday also targeted Mr. El-Sayed's ties to popular streamer Hasan Piker, who appeared alongside the Democrat multiple times during the primary campaign, including at his election night event.

Mr. Piker in the past has said that "Hamas is a thousand times better" than Israel, describing some Orthodox Jews as "inbred" and that "America deserved 9/11."

Mr. El-Sayed has faced criticism for his own rhetoric. He has repeatedly refused to answer questions about whether Iran or Israel poses a bigger threat to the country. Earlier this year, he said "hurt people hurt people" after an attack on a synagogue in the Detroit area. The attacker had lost four relatives in an Israeli airstrike on Lebanon the week earlier. El-Sayed later apologised, saying he was not trying to justify what happened.

"To anyone who feels like my comments might have been hurtful, I'm really sorry," he said. "That was not my intention."

'Out of line and crazy'

Mr. Bahbah, whose organisation has since changed its name to Arab Americans for Peace, said Mr. Trump's remarks were unacceptable to Arab and Muslim communities, including Christian Arabs.

"The remarks are out of line and crazy. I mean, no sane individual would say these things," Mr. Bahbah said.

Dearborn helped Mr. Trump win Michigan in 2024 after many voters in the city were outraged by the Biden administration's handling of the war in Gaza.

"The President of the United States saying that about a person because of his religion, that is just not acceptable," said Mr. Bahbah. "And people are going to remember that on November 3."

Senator Bernie Sanders, speaking at the Grand Rapids rally, said Mr. Trump and his allies were using Islamophobia because they have "nothing to say" about the issues most important to working people, such as health care, housing and income inequality.

"All they can do is foment hatred and divisiveness," Mr. Sanders said.

Mr. Rogers and Mr. El-Sayed have been locked in a bitter race to fill the seat of retiring Democratic Senator Gary Peters.

While it lacked a fresh promise for Michigan's economy, Mr. Trump's rally did deliver a bit of star power.

Rapper Nicki Minaj appeared on stage and urged people to get out and vote for the State's Republican ticket.

INNOVATIVE BEST

Walk into the fan: Morkel's tip to tackle 'windy Wellington'



CREIMAS/BCCI

India bowling coach Morne Morkel has a pro-tip for players to tackle the windy conditions in Wellington. "We spoke about it and we have planted those seeds. I told the boys: 'Make sure you get a very strong fan at home. Walk into the fan... that is your preparation'," said Morkel ahead of the third T20I against New Zealand.

THE MESSAGE

Just be you and connect with that: Morkel tells Bhuvneshwar



ANI

Don't chase anything, just be you. And for me, that has been the message from the start when he [Bhuvneshwar] joined the squad. Yes, there will be expectations. But every game you'll get better and every game you'll find your rhythm. So let's not think about the outside noise. Just be you and connect with that — Morne Morkel

PREPARATORY MODE

Bumrah and Pant added to India-A squad for third 'Test'



FILE PHOTO

Jasprit Bumrah is expected to feature in the third 'Test' between India-A and New Zealand-A, scheduled to be played in Lincoln from November 7 to 10, while Rishabh Pant has also been included subject to fitness clearance from the BCCI medical staff. Bumrah and Pant are currently training at the CoE in Bengaluru.

TRUE LEGEND

'Anderson should have a stand named after him at Old Trafford'



FILE PHOTO

There's no one better than James Anderson. He can swing the ball either way, and he has so much control. At the iconic Old Trafford ground, there's a stand named after Clive Lloyd, there's a stand named after me. Now, the third stand should be called the Jimmy Anderson stand — Former India wicketkeeper Farokh Engineer.

Retention deadline set for November 15

IPL AUCTION

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

The retention deadline for the Indian Premier League (IPL) franchises has been set for November 15 ahead of the player auction to be held in Goa on December 16.

While the Board of Control for Cricket in India secretary Devajit Saikia had confirmed the auction date and venue earlier this month, the IPL executives have informed the franchises of the retention deadline through an official communication.

With all franchises having confirmed their head coaches and several marquee trades potentially in the offing, the next fortnight could witness frantic activity in the transfer market.

The trade window, which opened a month after the IPL 2026 final, has so far witnessed two deals. In June, Lucknow Super Giants released captain Rishabh Pant to Delhi Capitals in exchange for left-arm wrist-spinner Kuldeep Yadav.

The Capitals then let go pacer T. Natarajan to Sunrisers Hyderabad for uncapped leg-spinner Zeeshan Ansari.

Under IPL rules, the trade window remains open until a week before the auction and reopens until a month before the following season begins.



The dates for the 2027 IPL season has not yet been finalised. FILE PHOTO: VIJAY SONEJI

With the retention deadline looming, franchises are expected to assess their squads and purse before deciding whether to pursue further trades or enter the auction with a larger budget.

The dates for the 2027 season are yet to be finalised. While the BCCI had previously earmarked a March 14-May 30 window for the 2027 edition, Saikia indicated after the board's annual general meeting in September that the tournament could begin towards the end of March.

The December auction will be the last mini-auction in the IPL's current cycle, with a mega-auction scheduled ahead of the 2028 season.

India looks to continue domination, seal series

The conditions in Wellington could test the Indian batters while veteran seamer Bhuvneshwar will be eager to bounce back; the trio of Seifert, Allen and Mitchell needs to fire for the Black Caps

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
WELLINGTON

Canny operator Bhuvneshwar Kumar and the ever-so-consistent Arshdeep Singh will have their task cut out when a focussed Indian team eyes a series-clinching win in the third T20 International against New Zealand here on Tuesday to continue an unbeaten run that dates back to 2020.

Virat Kohli's Indian team had blanked New Zealand 5-0 when the Men in Blue visited this part of the world in 2020. In their next visit in 2022-23, the Indians won the only match that was not wrecked by inclement weather, while the series-decider ended in a tie.

Ahead of the third T20I, the Indian team will not just be worried about a gutsy New Zealand bouncing back but also about the gusty wind that often traverses the Basin Reserve Ground, which is open from three sides.

Whether the conditions will force any tactical changes in the playing XI was not revealed by India's bowling coach Morne Morkel.

The much-anticipated return of Bhuvneshwar, after four years on the sidelines, hasn't gone as per plan. However, Basin Reserve, with its cross-winds, could prove to be the venue where those supple wrists become more effective.

He will have a reliable partner in Arshdeep, whose ability to push the ball across the right-handers and occasionally bend it back or straighten it, could create issues for the New Zealand top-order comprising Tim Seifert, Finn Allen, and Daryl Mitchell.

The trio hasn't exactly joined the party yet and pressure is mounting as the series progresses.

The heavy-lifting has mostly been done by Glenn Phillips in the middle-order, with two half-centuries, and by Bevon Jacobs in the last game.

India has used 13 players in the first two games. Vaibhav Sooryavanshi came in place of an injured Ishan Kishan and death overs specialist Prince Yadav replaced Mayank Yadav in the second game.

An evening match in chilly and windy conditions could also test the technique of Indian batters.

The absence of Lockie Ferguson and Matt Henry as part of New Zealand's workload management plan can also work to India's advantage. The host has included Matt Fisher and Blair Tickner in the squad.



Immediate task: Shreyas will be keen to wrap up the series in the third match itself. CREIMAS/BCCI

More game time will help Bhuvneshwar, reckons Morkel

Press Trust of India
WELLINGTON

India bowling coach Morne Morkel wants Bhuvneshwar Kumar to "block out expectations" and focus on being himself as the seasoned pacer looks to regain his rhythm in international cricket after a four-year absence from the T20I side.

Bhuvneshwar has endured an underwhelming return to India's T20I set-up, conceding 49 and 50 runs in the first two matches against New Zealand at an economy rate of 12.37 while claiming just one wicket, the poorest among India's bowlers.

"I've got a lot of sympathy. There will be expectations when one comes back after four years. He has done exceptionally well in the IPL and bowled really well," Morkel said on the eve of the third T20I.

"One challenge is to block out the expectation factor. Two, leading into selection, he trained for a month, but playing international cricket is a different beast where the margins are small. He had to come in with limited training because of the schedule to get himself ready."

Morkel, however, backed the veteran to find his feet as he gets more game time.

Bhuvneshwar, known for his ability to generate swing and seam movement, played a key role in Royal Challengers Bengaluru's IPL triumphs, taking 17 wickets in the 2025 season and 28 in 2026.



Solid support: Morkel backed Bhuvneshwar to regain his rhythm. FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

Mind over matter — the tweak that helped Harmanpreet rediscover form

ZIMBABWE IN INDIA

Lavanya L.
VADODARA

The last few weeks have been challenging for Harmanpreet Kaur. After ceding the captaincy of the Indian women's national side, which she held for over a decade, her spot in an evolving team was finally at the mercy of form.

A stunning 91 in the final T20I against Zimbabwe in Raipur brought some much-needed relief from inconsistency. Six days later in Vadodara, she registered an almost instructive 121-ball 126.

Watching along in Patiala was her batting coach, Himanshu Chawla, whose working relationship started when he pointed out her grip was wrong during a net session three years ago.

"Immediately, she said that Amol Muzumdar (India coach) told her the same. That may have told her that I knew what I was talking about," Himanshu, who coaches at the Cricket Academy of Patiala, told *The Hindu*.

"The focus in our drills has always been about how she will face the ball mentally, not technically. After playing for so long, fear of failure is one major thing that makes you take bad decisions, and she faced that."



In full flow: Harmanpreet is back to her best. CREIMAS/BCCI

"Cricket is a game of failure. Even the best, your Kohlis and Tendulkars, average in the 50s. It's not a 100."

Two days after her Raipur 91, Himanshu checked in on how she felt heading into the ODIs. "*Aise hi khelenge loongi*!" (I'll play the same way), came the instant reply.

But Himanshu urged her to tune her game to the format: stay in till the 45th or 46th over, and then let the T20 game take over. And Harmanpreet obeyed.

He says a three-session daily routine began when he jokingly told Harmanpreet to have breakfast and return at noon. She did, and again in the evening, and it stuck.



Harmanpreet with her coach Himanshu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Refreshingly open to unlearning, she worked with him on shot selection, innings building and 25-minute single-skill blocks, playing along the ground, minimising risk and scoring all around the wicket.

While the liberation from leadership is a theme that is following her batting returns, Himanshu doesn't believe captaincy hurt her scoring.

"The naughtiest kid usually becomes the class monitor, right? Added pressure always brings discipline to a Punjabi," he quipped.

Like a river after a long dry spell, form is finding its way back to Harmanpreet, quietly and steadily. Big assignments lie downstream, including the Women's Champions Trophy, and India will need Harmanpreet at her flowing best.

Padikkal misses a double by a whisker

INDIA-A IN NZ

Press Trust of India
LINCOLN

Devdutt Padikkal put a stop to the debate surrounding India's potential No.3 for the upcoming Test series with a superb 199 as India-A made a remarkable recovery to post 488 for eight in its second innings against New Zealand-A on the third day of the first unofficial Test here.

Going into the last day, India-A leads by 288 runs, a brilliant turnaround after conceding a 200-plus first innings lead.

Padikkal missed out on a well-deserved double hundred when he was adjudged caught behind down the leg-side off a delivery from medium-pacer Zak Gibson.

Padikkal was aghast when the umpire raised his finger and indicated that he hadn't nicked the ball. He then dragged himself back to the dug-out.

Padikkal, who faced 248 deliveries, struck 23 fours and three sixes.

Sai Sudharsan, too, scored an impressive 91 while adding 210 for the third wicket with Padikkal. The former hit 12 boundaries in his 184-ball knock.

The scores: India-A 113 & 488/8 in 119 overs (Devdutt Padikkal 199, Sai Sudharsan 91, Yash Rathod 66, Washington Sundar 51 batting) vs. New Zealand-A 317 in 89.3 overs.



Marathon effort: Padikkal led India-A's recovery. FILE PHOTO: R. RAGU

Manvir strikes late as Bagan edges CFC

ISL

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

Manvir Singh struck in the 85th minute to help Mohun Bagan Super Giant secure a hard-fought 1-0 win over Chennaiyin FC in an ISL fixture at the Salt Lake Stadium on Monday.

Bagan started brightly, with Manvir and Scottish forward Lee Erwin leading the early attacking moves. But the host soon lost momentum, allowing Chennaiyin to take control and launch repeated forays into the final third.

Playmaker Madih Talal orchestrated the visitor's moves, but Brison Fernandes, Irfan Yadwad and Namgyal Bhutia failed to convert the opportunities that came before the break.

Bagan's attacking rhythm was affected by the absence of Jamie Maclaren, Miguel Figuera and Apuia, all out through injury.

Coach Panagiotis Dilmperis' midfield reshuffle, particularly his attempt to find the right position for Lallianzuala Chhangte, further disrupted the plans. A return to a more familiar approach in the final quarter helped restore some cohesion.



Manvir... the match-winner. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Chennaiyin continued to threaten after the break, with Brazilian striker Ramon Tanque adding impetus to its attacks. Tanque had a promising opportunity in the 61st minute after being set up by Talal, but goalkeeper Vishal Kaith produced a crucial save.

CFC came closer in the 77th minute when Nikola Stojanovic's swerving left-footed effort struck the crossbar following a timely touch from Kaith.

Chennaiyin paid dear for its missed chances when substitute Liston Colaco delivered a precise cross from the left. Manvir redirected the ball into the net to seal the victory.

The result:

Mohun Bagan SG 1 (Manvir Singh 85) bt Chennaiyin FC 0.

Zubair frustrates TN after bowlers come to the party

The Railways player, walking out at No. 8, dominates the 61-run last-wicket stand with Himanshu to take the visitor to 184; Sonu strikes thrice in his opening burst while Sai Kishore also scalps three

RANJI TROPHY

Sankar Narayanan E.H.
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu dismissed Railways for 184 in 53.3 overs: a good showing by the home team bowlers, at least on the face of it.

A closer look at Monday's proceedings at the MAC Stadium, though, reveals a story of missed opportunity. Sai Kishore & Co. had the visitor reeling at 123 for nine before Zubair Ali Khan (75, 121b, 7x4, 4x6) took the attack to the bowlers.

His 61-run stand with No. 11 Himanshu Sangwan (7 n.o., 25b, 1x4) frustrated Tamil Nadu for over 13 overs, with Zubair farming strike well and finding the boundary at will.

Earlier, this Ranji Trophy Elite Group D fixture began with Sonu Yadav breathing fire under overcast skies.

While the conditions were tough for batting, the Railways willow-wielders did not do themselves any favours by going for unnecessary release shots, often leading to a miscue and a catch.

The medium-pacer bowled eight consecutive overs in his first spell (three for 13), but his figures took a beating during Zubair's late assault.

Sonu drew first blood by having S. Yuvraj Singh caught at second slip, a terrific grab by B. Indrajith, before trapping southpaws Eshaan Goyal and Mohammad Saif in front.

While the conditions were tough for batting, the Railways willow-wielders did not do themselves any favours by going for unnecessary release shots, often leading to a miscue and a catch.

Ravi Singh's wicket would have hurt Railways the most as it came with barely five minutes left for lunch. The left-hander played across the line against off-spinner J. Hemchudeshan, only to be caught at wide mid-off by Pradosh Ranjan Paul (82 for seven).

If not for Zubair, Tamil Nadu could have had a longer batting stint on day one, and a greater advantage.

For now, the host has reached 71 for three in 25 overs, and trails by 113 runs.

By removing Vimal Khumar for a duck, N. Jagadeesan (30, 31b, 4x4) and Pradosh (19), the Railways bowlers have kept their team in the hunt.

The scores:
Railways — 1st innings: S. Yuvraj Singh c Indrajith b Sonu 4, Vivek Singh c Hemchudeshan b Sai Kishore 14, Eshaan Goyal lbw b Sonu 0, Mohammad Saif lbw b Sonu 0, Raj Choudhary b Sai Kishore 7, Bhargav Merai c Indrajith b Gurjapneet 17, Ravi Singh c Pradosh b Hemchudeshan 21, Zubair Ali Khan c Vimal b Sai Kishore 75, Toufik Mondal c Indrajith b Hemchudeshan 18, Pradhyumn Parikh c Pradosh b Ajith Ram 9, Himanshu Sangwan (not out) 7; Extras (b-9, lb-2, w-1): 12; Total (in 53.3 overs): 184.
Fall of wickets: 1-7, 2-7, 3-7, 4-18, 5-33, 6-51, 7-82, 8-102, 9-123.
Tamil Nadu bowling: Gurjapneet 12-3-27-1, Sonu 11-1-46-3, Sai Kishore 13.3-0-53-3, Ajith Ram 12-3-27-1, Hemchudeshan 5-0-20-2.
Tamil Nadu — 1st innings: Vimal Khumar b Himanshu 0, N. Jagadeesan b Toufik 30, Pradosh Ranjan Paul c & b Toufik 19, B. Indrajith (batting) 13, Andre Siddarth (batting) 8; Extras (w-1): 1; Total (for three wkts. in 25 overs): 71.
Fall of wickets: 1-10, 2-44, 3-55.
Railways bowling: Himanshu 6-1-18-1, Zubair 4-0-11-0, Yuvraj 1-0-7-0, Raj 5-1-16-0, Toufik 7-1-15-2, Pradhyumn 2-0-4-0.




Stars of the day: Zubair found the boundary at will after Sonu threatened in his first spell. R. RAGU

RANJI TROPHY SCORES - ROUND THREE, DAY ONE

Elite: Group A: At Vadodara: Baroda 259/6 in 86 overs (Priyanshu Moliya 113 batting, Deepak Hooda 45) vs. Jammu & Kashmir. **Toss:** Baroda.
At Indore: Bihar 99 in 30.3 overs (Mangal Mahrour 42, Saransh Jain 7/40) vs. Madhya Pradesh 261/3 in 57 overs (Yash Dubey 84, Saksham Purohit 113 batting). **Toss:** Bihar.
At Nagpur: Goa 204/8 in 86 overs (Yash Kasvankar 51 batting, Darshan Misal 51, Nachiket Bhute 4/40) vs. Vidarbha. **Toss:** Vidarbha.
At Puducherry: Uttar Pradesh 67/4 in 37 overs vs. Pondicherry. **Toss:** Pondicherry.
Group B:
At Vijayawada: Andhra 231 in 73.2 overs (S.V. Rahul 89, Jayant Yadav 4/75) vs. Chhattisgarh 35/1 in 14 overs. **Toss:** Andhra.
At Hyderabad: Punjab 289/6 in 90 overs (Prabhsimran Singh 81, Jashanpreet Singh Sidhu 45, Salil Arora 57 batting, Ramandeep Singh 52) vs. Hyderabad. **Toss:** Punjab.
At Mysuru: Tripura 194 in 82 overs (Bikramkumar Das 51, Shikhar Shetty 5/54) vs. Karnataka 10/1 in 6 overs. **Toss:** Karnataka.
At Rajkot: Assam 235/6 in 93 overs (Denish Das 90, Sibsankar Roy 59 batting) vs. Saurashtra.



Saransh Jain (MP vs. Bihar, 7/40). FILE PHOTO

Toss: Assam.
Group C:
At Ranchi: Delhi 309/5 in 90 overs (Ayush Badoni 106 batting, Sumit Mathur 50 batting) vs. Jharkhand. **Toss:** Delhi.
At Bhubaneswar: Odisha 194 in 82.3 overs (Gourav Choudhury 41, Pulkit Narang 6/47) vs. Services 13/0 in 5 overs. **Toss:** Services.
At Pune: Gujarat 223 in 75.5 overs (Abhishek Desai 79, Jaymeet Patel 58 n.o., Siddhesh Veer 4/20) vs. Maharashtra 24/1 in 12 overs. **Toss:** Maharashtra.
At Thiruvananthapuram: Bengal 172/6 in 50 overs (Ankur Paul 66) vs. Kerala. **Toss:** Kerala.
Group D:
At Dehradun: Rajasthan 272 in 81.2 overs (Kartik Sharma 73, Kunal Rathore 47, Devendra Bora 6/72) vs. Uttarakhand 18/0 in 5 overs. **Toss:** Rajasthan.
At Chennai: Railways 184 in 53.3 overs (Zubair Ali Khan 75) vs. Tamil Nadu 71/3 in 25 overs. **Toss:** Tamil Nadu.
At Chandigarh: Chandigarh 363/2 in 87 overs (Nehal Pajni 126 batting, Arjun Azad 147, Manan Vohra 61) vs. Himachal Pradesh. **Toss:** Himachal.
At Mumbai: Mumbai 290/3 in 82 overs (Angkrish Raghuvanshi 114, Musheer Khan 109) vs. Haryana. **Toss:** Haryana.
Plate:
At Rangpo: Nagaland 187 in 72.5 overs (Joshua Ozukum 59, Yugandhar Singh 47) vs. Sikkim 30/1 in 15 overs. **Toss:** Sikkim.
At Ahmedabad: Arunachal Pradesh 111 in 41.4 overs (Ajay Singh 4/27) vs. Manipur 165/5 in 46 overs (Karnajit Yumnam 56, Jotin Pheiroijam 52 batting). **Toss:** Arunachal.
At Nadiad: Meghalaya 385/2 in 89 overs (Ajay Duhan 167 batting, Kishan Lyngdoh 144 batting) vs. Mizoram. **Toss:** Meghalaya.

'Murugappa Cup offers valuable exposure for Malaysian juniors'

HOCKEY

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI

Nor Saiful Zaini Nasir-ud-Din and Dhanraj Pillay share a long friendship, with its share of banter. Saiful still remembers the 1998 Commonwealth Games semifinal, when Dhanraj apparently "missed a few chances" as Malaysia won 1-0.

"That's a painful memory for him. You can ask him," said Saiful, a three-time Olympian, who recalled how they called the former India captain "King" for the way he walked and talked.

Now 60, the former international has another reason to smile after guiding Malaysia's junior team to the Sultan of Johor Cup title on Saturday, ending a 15-year wait.



Nor Saiful Zaini Nasir-Ud-Din. R. RAGU

"I think with this win, we have a team that we can prepare for the Junior World Cup next year. That's the motivation we have from this title. We hope these youngsters make the national team. That's most important for development," he said on the sidelines of the All-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup here on Monday.

> We have only six or seven clubs. It is difficult to find quality players to represent the country

The tournament offers valuable exposure against senior Indian sides.

"Playing against senior players from India, we see a lot of different skills and a different type of hockey. That is the most valuable thing," he said.

The tournament also presents a new challenge, with his team playing four matches in as many days.

"Almost after we finished the final (in Johor Bahru), everyone packed up and went straight to the airport. We arrived here yesterday (Sunday), and are playing another game today. The problem is that we have never played four games in a row.

"We need a good plan - playing without getting tired unnecessarily. The rotation must be very good. Everyone has to play, rest and come back," he said.

Saiful also pointed to the shrinking talent pool in Malaysia, where hockey remains a relatively unpopular sport.

"We have only six or seven clubs. It is difficult to find quality players to represent the country.

" In the 1970s, we had a good mixture of Malay, Chinese, Indian, and Sikh players. Now, the hockey population has dropped," he said.

Aditya eases into gold medal bout at World Boxing u-19 c'ships

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Aditya became the second Indian to make it to the final of the World Boxing u-19 championships after beating Nihat Gasimov of Azerbaijan in the men's 55kg semifinals in Budva (Montenegro).

Dominant
Aditya was dominant through the three rounds to bag a 5-0 verdict from the judges on Sunday and will face Islam Magomedov of Russia in the gold medal bout. Megha Sheokand had earlier clinched the final spot in the women's 80kg category with a RSC win over Meerim Chynybekova of Kyrgyzstan in the semifinals.

Team MRF Tyres wins its fourth ERC Teams title



Reigning supreme: The triumphant Team MRF Tyres contingent. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau

Team MRF Tyres was crowned 2026 FIA European Rally Championship Teams' champion, completing another remarkable European campaign with a commanding performance at Rally 6 Cities North of Portugal.

It won ended the championship with 233 points, a commanding 98-point advantage over its closest rival.

This is MRF Tyres' fourth title in five years after victories in 2022, 2023 and 2025.

Martins Sesks and Renars Francis delivered a spectacular overall victory in the final round of the season. The team featured an international line-up of drivers, including Sesks, Roope Korhonen, Patrick Enok, Simone Tempestini, Andrei Girtofan, Nicolas Otto, Erik Cais, Martin Vlcek, Frank Tore Larsen and Eyvind Brynildsen.

For the final round in Portugal, MRF Tyres fielded six crews across its official Team MRF Tyres and MRF Tyres Dealers Team programmes.

Narrow victory strengthens BPCL's semifinal prospects

MURUGAPPA GOLD CUP

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI

Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) edged a travel-weary Malaysia junior team 1-0 in a Pool-B match of the 97th All-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup hockey tournament at the SDAT Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium here on Monday.

Malaysia, which won the Sultan of Johor Cup on Saturday night in Johor Bahru before reaching Chennai on Sunday, looked off-colour after the short turnaround. BPCL dominated with its raids but failed to make the most of several scoring opportunities, including a penalty stroke.

Sudeep Chirmako scored the winner in the third minute with a well-worked goal. A long aerial pass from near the halfway line found a teammate near the right post, who squared the ball to Chirmako in front of goal. The forward made no mistake.

BPCL had a chance to extend its lead in the 36th minute, but Devindar Walmiki sent the penalty stroke wide. Malaysia won a penalty corner in the 44th minute, but Gunaseelan Dheeressh's drag-flick was blocked by an advancing defender.

BPCL failed to convert two penalty corners in the final seconds but strengthened its semifinal prospects with a third consecutive win.

The results: Pool-A: Indian Army 5 (Dhariyashil Jadhav 15, Ankush 21, Cyril Lugun 28-pc, Rohit Irengbam 40, Ritendra 41) bt Punjab National Bank 2 (Naveen Antil 35-pc, Abhimanyu 50). **Pool-B:** BPCL 1 (Sudeep Chirmako 3) bt Malaysia junior team 0.



Hero! Chirmako's goal gave BPCL its third straight win R. RAGU

Haryana teen Poonam lets her javelin do the talking

NATL. JR. ATHLETICS

Tarun Shastry
CHENNAI

If Sunday was dark and gloomy, with a steady drizzle throughout, Monday brought a different kind of blue, with slightly brighter skies.

For Haryana's Poonam, though, it was anything but bright.

Two successive fouls threatened to end her women's under-20 javelin campaign at the 41st National junior athletics championships at the Nehru Stadium here on Monday.

Watching from the stands, her coach Hanuman Singh was livid. He charged down and began giving instructions as Poonam walked back after her second attempt.

A third foul would have ended her competition.

"My first thought was to get into the top eight. I had already committed a couple of fouls," she told *The Hindu*.

Hanuman's advice was simple: adjust the direction of release and keep the javelin within the sector.

"He told me to release it a little more towards the inside and use my shoulder," said Poonam.



Rising star: Poonam's coach believes she can get even better. SIVA SANKAR A.

She did just that on her third attempt, turning back a little more confidently, while her coach, too, appeared to have settled down.

The 19-year-old gradually found her rhythm and went on to claim gold with a throw of 51.48m.

It was not the first time Poonam had found a way to carry on in difficult circumstances.

In December 2024, just days after her father passed away, she won silver in the under-18 javelin at the National junior athletics championships in Bhubaneswar.

It was Hanuman who introduced Poonam to javelin while she was studying in Class 10 at a school in Haryana's Fatehabad district. "I didn't even know what javelin was. Sir took me from the classroom and introduced me to it," she said.

Hanuman believes there is more to come. "She can throw much better. Her technique is not that good yet, and she has had only about three years of javelin training. She will improve," he said.

For now, though, an evening that began with two red flags ended with a different colour around Poonam's neck.

Nobody on the outside can judge the length of my spells

The 36-year-old hasn't played for India since the ICC Champions Trophy in March 2025. While he continues to turn up for Bengal in the domestic circuit, the persistent absence from the national set-up has raised questions about his fitness standards. The experienced quick offered his response after being ignored for the tour of New Zealand, and says that he is enjoying playing for his State team whilst still hoping that he can don the India jersey again

INTERVIEW

Mohammed Shami

Vivek Krishnan

It was a warm Tuesday afternoon at the Airforce Complex Ground in Palam. As soon as Bengal wrapped up a 60-run victory over Services on the stroke of what should have been the scheduled tea interval in the second round of the 2026-27 Ranji Trophy, the journalists present, a significant number for a domestic encounter at a quaint venue in the national capital, hovered outside the winning team's dressing room. An interaction with Mohammed Shami was unanimously sought.

Shami hadn't even taken part in the Ranji fixture, but he was clearly the star attraction at the culmination of the game. Two days before the commencement of the encounter, the veteran pacer's name had again been omitted from India's squads for the ODI and Test series against New Zealand next month.

It has been a theme for the last year. Shami has been keen to prove his detractors wrong and allay doubts over his fitness by playing regularly for Bengal - he played in seven of nine matches in the State's Ranji semifinal exit last season - in the domestic circuit, but the wise men of Indian cricket have repeatedly looked in a different direction.

His last assignment for the country was the ICC Champions Trophy in March 2025. He had returned to the Indian set-up just ahead of the tournament after a lengthy lay-off due to a knee injury and ankle surgery following the 2023 ODI World Cup. Over the course of the eight-team Champions Trophy, where spearhead Jasprit Bumrah was missing in action because of a lower back injury, Shami stepped up ably, scalping nine victims in five matches in India's undefeated march to glory.

Yet, Shami's yearning for a return to the bright lights of international cricket hasn't materialised.

Whether that will change in whatever is remaining of his career is uncertain. Regardless, Shami's reputation as one of India's finest fast bowlers cannot be taken away. Particularly when he was part of the pace attack also featuring Bumrah, Ishant Sharma and Umesh Yadav under Virat Kohli's captaincy, there was no let-up for the batter facing. Shami, never mind his fondness for a sumptuous plate of *biryani*, would charge in all day long and release the ball with a perfectly upright seam to make it jag at his command. He went on to produce many great spells, as 229 wickets in 64 Tests and 206 scalps in 108 ODIs testify.

During the course of the media interaction in Palam, he set the record straight on his fitness, responded to his omission for the tour of New Zealand, the motivation to play for Bengal and more. Excerpts:

You had trained on the day before the Bengal-Services game. The Bengal captain and coach said that you were fit and resting. What was the reasoning behind you opting not to play the match?

I trained on day three and four of the game too. You could see the condition of the pitch, right? There was no point in playing on this wicket and bowling two to four overs. It was better that the youngsters got a run. The more they play, the more experience they will get. My motive is that when the team requires me, I play. I don't think there was really a need here. I can't play as a batter.

You have been playing domestic cricket regularly. Yet, you are not part of the touring party to New Zealand. How disappointing is it to have been overlooked for the series?

It was not about disappointment. I played (almost) all the matches last season as well. My motive is to play as much as I can in the upcoming tournaments. Nobody knows when anybody will be needed. For me, it is good even for Indian Premier League (IPL) preparation if I keep playing domestic cricket. As long as I play a lot of matches, my rhythm will be good. If I am with the team, the atmosphere will be good. These are the things that I try to do.

Your record in international cricket is proven. Skill-wise, do you still consider yourself one of the best in Indian cricket right now?

I can't praise myself. That is something that you all will have to be asked. But I try to ensure that whoever I am playing for, I tick the boxes required and fulfil my responsibility. I try to ensure that my effort is 100% and the team's needs are fulfilled. I don't think of anything more than this.

You have played a lot of cricket with Bhuvneshwar Kumar. He has made a comeback to the T20I team. Does it offer encouragement that your performances in domestic cricket will also be rewarded?

I don't know what will happen or not happen. But there can't be anything better for any player than the fact that the domestic season has started. This is the best platform for any player to get into rhythm. Whoever is available, whether senior or junior, should look to make the competition tough for the opponent (in domestic cricket).

How happy are you for Bhuvneshwar to have earned a recall?

The way he has performed, he should have been there in the Indian team much earlier.

There has been talk that you haven't been able to bowl long spells for Bengal, and that you have needed frequent breaks off the field. What would you like to say to that?

How can anyone from the outside judge whether I am bowling long spells? It is dependent on the demands of the team. It is not like I will keep bowling over after over. On a wicket like this, for example, how can you plan to have a fast bowler bowl five or ten overs on the trot? If it is uncomfortable for a batter, the fast bowler will bowl. If we think a spinner will take the wickets, he will bowl more. This depends entirely on the game situation and pitch conditions. That is the captain's call.

By the way, I bowled for one-and-a-half hours today. There was no issue.

You have had your peak. Is your age a barrier now?

I am still at my peak. There is no point in not saying what I think is right. Regardless of how old I am, I feel I am at my peak.

You were instrumental in India reaching the 2023 ODI World Cup final. The next World Cup is in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia, and just a year away. How keen are you to keep pushing yourself with that tournament in mind?

I do not think that far ahead. You never know what will happen in life. You don't know who will score runs or take wickets. There is no point thinking that far ahead. Just keep playing the matches. Just keep improving. I always say that my focus should be on my skill and my fitness. I don't want to take on any load by thinking about the future. I am getting to play domestic cricket right now. There is a lot of time (for the 2027 ODI World Cup). I am just playing.

There has been a change in the selection panel recently. Ajit Agarkar has left his role. Has there been any communication with the selectors after that?

I am not with the Indian team. I am not contracted. Why will anybody talk to me right now?

How much are you enjoying this phase of playing domestic cricket for Bengal?

This is the team that has given me a name. All these cameras and questions are because of this team. And whenever I end my career, it will be with this team. The stage or level does not matter. You should have loyalty and work hard. I am doing that. Only that is in my control. The rest isn't in my control. That is how I think.

You say that the 2027 World Cup is some time away. But how much hope do you realistically have of playing for India again?

Why would I give up hope? Hope should always be there. I say this for any profession. You should always have a goal. Even when we play in the Ranji Trophy, it is to win the title for the State. Goals should always be there. I don't deny that.



PHOTO: R. RAGU

> **Why would I give up hope? Goals should always be there. I don't deny that**



> I don't know what will happen or not happen. But there can't be anything better for a player than the fact that the domestic season has started

PHOTO: NIRMAL HARINDRAN